Graduation

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/48470929.

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Teen And Up Audiences

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F/F, F/M

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Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra)

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Angst, Shadow Weaver's A+ Parenting, Angst with a Happy Ending, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Medical Procedures, Medical Conditions, Emotional Hurt/Comfort, Alternate Universe - Summer Camp

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Part 14 of Camp Bright Moon

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Graduation

by TheSofterGentlerMe

Summary

Adora is graduating with her doctorate, the pinnacle of her multi-year labors. She has friends, she has family, and she is loved but she is still quietly haunted by her past.

Chapter One

Chapter Summary

> Adora is graduating with her doctorate, the pinnacle of her multi-year labors. She has friends, she has family, and she is loved but she is still quietly haunted by her past.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra fiddled with the tassel hanging off Adora's graduation cap.

"OK, you've had enough fun with that," Adora said with a laugh. "You did this same thing when I got my bachelors."

"I did the same thing when you got your masters as well," Catra said. "I can't help it. It's fun."

"Just don't move it yet," Adora said.

"I remember, I remember," Catra said with a roll of her eyes and a smile.

Adora waved at someone in the crowd they were standing in below the stadium of the university that Adora had gone to for her doctorate. As Adora looked at the crowd of graduating bachelor

degree students, she smiled. She remembered when she'd been there years before and thought of how young they looked now to her even though she wasn't quite thirty years old just yet. She spotted a few she'd taught when she'd been a teaching assistant for a little while and felt proud she'd had some hand in where they were now.

Catra was dressed in a dark red suit that Adora thought she looked amazing in but that Catra had just grumped about even though she'd admitted she wasn't going to come watch her wife graduate in jeans and t-shirt that was her everyday wear. That didn't mean she appreciated the suit, even though Adora definitely did, especially with the scarred and scuffed pair of heavy boots Catra was wearing that gave just the right touch to the rest of the outfit. As she admired Catra once again, one of Catra's pockets started buzzing.

"Glimmer and Bow are here and seated with the rest," Catra said as she got her phone out and then typed out a quick reply to the text before shoving it back in her pocket.

"Should I have let them come down?" Adora said as she watched other people's family crowd around their graduates.

"You said it'd just make you nervous," Catra said. "Remember?"

"I'm already nervous," Adora said.

“You’re graduating,” Catra said. “You’ve done this before, several times in fact.”

“I haven’t got a doctorate before though,” Adora replied.

Catra rolled her eyes as she absentmindedly reached up to flick at the tassel again as she said, “It’s the same thing. You’re going to sit while some speeches are made and then you’re going to walk while people cheer and then we’re going out for a fancy dinner.”

Adora looked thoughtful as she gave a little head nod as she replied, “I do like the fancy dinner part.”

“I still don’t know where we’re going,” Catra replied. “Glimmer is keeping it a secret.”

“Why?” Adora said.

“I have no clue,” Catra replied. “Probably because she can.”

“Probably because it’s expensive,” Adora said, fiddling with the cuff of her robe.

“You did freak out when she took us to that steakhouse for your masters,” Catra said.

“I didn’t freak out,” Adora said, rolling her eyes. “I just didn’t want her spending that kind of money on me.”

“She’s not a broke college student anymore,” Catra said. “Let her treat you.”

“She’s still working on getting her practice off the ground though,” Adora said.

Catra sighed as she said, “Adora, it’s not only off the ground, it’s flying. She’s doing fine, I promise. Her and her partner are starting to hire other lawyers, remember? Let your friends do nice things for you.”

“OK, OK,” Adora said.

“Seriously,” Catra said. “I just need you to relax a little. I don’t want to go back to you talking in your sleep in Hebrew again.”

Adora laughed as she said, “I said I was sorry.”

“Listen, I’m just saying, it is unnerving to wake up to your wife babbling in a whole other language,” Catra said.

“I wish I knew what I was saying,” Adora said.

“Nope, stop,” Catra said with a raised eyebrow. “We’re not doing that again.”

“I’m just saying, I should have tried to record it. Maybe it was important,” Adora replied.

“It was probably gibberish,” Catra said.

“We’ll never know now,” Adora said with a mock sigh.

Catra gave her a kiss before she took her hand as she said, “Doesn’t matter. And uh, I’m proud of you, if I haven’t said that.”

Adora’s face lit up with a smile as she said, “You have but I love to hear it. This is as much a result of you. There’s now way I could have done it without your support.”

“Yeah, you could have. Would have been damn hard though,” Catra said with a grin before looking around. “Looks like families are starting to leave. I’ll see you afterwards. South entrance, don’t forget and don’t get lost.”

Adora pulled her in for a kiss again before she said, “I’m not going to forget or get lost.”

Catra started backing up as she said, “Bet you will!”

“Bet you a kiss I won’t,” Adora said.

“Done,” Catra said as she finger gunned both her hands at Adora before turning to leave.

A few minutes after Catra left, they began to herd the graduates towards a tunnel in preparation for getting them seated and Adora was shuffled up to the front with a couple other people getting their doctorates. It set her to thinking of everything that happened since a rainy evening on a dock when she’d thrown caution to the wind and admitted to herself who she was. It hadn’t been easy. She and Catra had their problems. Some of them had been self-imposed, as they learned how to be in a relationship, and some of them had been from the outside, as they tried to deal with living in the world.

They’d had help. Glimmer and Bow had helped where they could and Adora had lived in the dorms with Glimmer through most of her first few years of college. She’d always been able to ask Glimmer’s parents and family for help and advice and she’d been able to do the same from Bow’s fathers as well when she’d met them. She knew she didn’t stand there all on her own abilities. She was about to walk across the stage because she’d reached out and a whole host of hands had reached back. She had people

she could call family and she had a wife she loved more every day as they both learned more and more about each other.

But there was still a hole there and it was the shape of her mother. She'd never heard back from her and she had eventually stopped trying for the most part after a few years. She'd talked it out with many people, including professionals, and Adora had come to terms with the abandonment. Her mother's last words to her had been that Adora was dead to her and so that was how Adora had eventually come to look at their relationship, as a dead thing that came out as a ghost that haunted her at the oddest hours.

As everyone began to walk towards the main auditorium Adora fell into line. As they all walked out to the music and the applause she didn't even bother to look out into the seats to see if she could spot Catra and the rest. She'd learned when she'd graduated for her bachelors that she couldn't really pick anyone out in the sea of people anyway.

The ceremony didn't feel like it took long. There were speeches from the university president and the keynote speech was from a local conservative politician that Adora did her best to tune out as she gritted her teeth a little. Soon she was standing on the edge of the stage, handing a piece of paper with her name and her degree to a person with a microphone, and started walking as she heard over the speakers, "Adora Manzana, doctorate of philosophy in Religion, Ethics, & Philosophy."

There was applause and she knew she could hear Catra and Glimmer trying to outdo each other in who was cheering the loudest and didn't even bother to hide her grin as she walked to

the president of the school, shook her hand, took the empty folder that worked as a placeholder for a diploma, and turned for the obligatory picture. She walked off the stage for another picture by herself and then went and sat down to wait for the rest of the graduates to cycle through.

As she sat, she let her mind drift a little. It went to the summer before she went to college, the summer when everything had changed. She remembered helping around Camp Bright Moon and figuring out who she was as a person. She remembered conversations with the different people around camp as she began to figure out the whole new world she'd fallen into. She remembered the winter solstice and sitting out all night by a fire, mostly in silence, with Glimmer's father while everyone else slept. She remembered running into a former camp kid named Kaitlyn that she'd briefly been a counselor for at Camp Horde for the Lord and how she'd connected with other kids from that camp over the years through her that had broken free for one reason or another. She'd tried to pay forward even a fraction of the help that she'd gotten herself by not only helping those grown kids but also sometimes being a foster parent, first for a person named Madison and then with a few others.

She grinned as she thought of her friends, like Scorpia, sitting in the crowd that night with her wife, Perfuma, and how they'd bought the old Camp Horde for the Lord just the year before and were turning it into a flower farm and horse ranch. Then there was Kyle and Rogelio who had been off and on for a few years after they'd left on their own from Camp Horde for the Lord. They'd started a band with Lonnie, broke up the band because of their relationship, and then finally the three of them had moved in together after one fiery weekend at a remote campground out in the desert somewhere that no one had ever got the full details on beyond vague comments and that actual real, uncontrolled fire had apparently been involved at one point. Adora knew things had

been difficult, things had been scary, and things hadn't worked out in some cases but they'd also been full of laughter, full of joy, and most importantly, full of people who cared and loved for each other. As Adora waited, a song that had been in her head off and on for the last few days, started to refrain in her head again.

"A time to be born, a time to die, a time to plant, a time to reap, a time to kill, a time to heal, a time to laugh, a time to weep."

She hummed it softly to herself as she waited for the ceremony to be over, getting a bit of a look from the person sitting next to her, but she wasn't paying attention to them. Finally, the president of the university took the podium again, thanked everyone and congratulated the class to the accompaniment of cheering and clapping as tassels switched from one side to the other on their cap. Adora was standing and clapping with the rest but as everyone started heading for the exits she sat back down and waited for the crowd to recede a little. She pulled her phone out as she did and texted Catra.

I'm waiting for the crowd to let up a little, she typed. *I'll see you at the south entrance and I expect to collect my winnings then.*

She added a little kissy emoji and tucked the phone back in her pocket. After about ten minutes, she stood up and headed for the exit tunnel that would let her out into the main hallway. The crowd was heavy in the main hallway but the exit tunnel under the seating only had a few people in it. She was almost to the end when Adora noticed one of the people standing at the end was looking at her.

“Hello, Adora,” her mother said.

Adora didn’t know what to say. There her mother stood, the floor length red dress not the same as the last time but for all intents and purposes it was to Adora. Her black hair hung to her shoulders in odd curls that Adora never would have pegged her mother wearing. Her purse was over her shoulder and she held a small bag in her hand but Adora didn’t really notice that as she locked eyes with her as she struggled between saying hello or something much more vulgar.

“You can’t even say hello? You are the one who sent me an invitation,” her mother said.

Adora was rapidly regretting doing so. It was something she’d done for her bachelors out of a last bit of hope that she’d show up and then done for her masters because she felt like rubbing her success in her mother’s face and she’d done it for her doctorate almost as reflex.

“You’re right,” Adora finally said. “Hello, Sharon. Why did you come to this one and not the others?”

“That’s not a polite way to say hello to your mother,” Sharon said, her face crinkling in disapproval.

“I don’t have a mother,” Adora said, feeling the anger bubbling up in her chest. “I’m dead to her, remember?”

“That was just hurt feelings talking,” Sharon said, making a little hand gesture. “You shouldn’t hold a grudge like that.”

Adora’s mouth fell open and she suddenly found herself laughing as she said, “Are you fucking serious!? It’s been nine years since you’ve spoken to me!”

“Watch your language, you are in public,” Sharon said, stepping closer to Adora.

“If there was ever a time to curse, it’s this,” Adora said, fighting the urge to look away, step back and hang her head because for a moment she was a little girl being chastised by her mother but then the anger surged up again. “You returned most of the letters I sent. You have not spoken word one to me in that whole time. What should I say?”

“What letters? What are you talking about? The first letter I ever got from you was for this,” Sharon said.

Adora felt her shoulders sag as she looked at the ceiling for a moment before looking back as she said, “It’s not going to work; don’t try and act like I never reached out. I know damn well what your handwriting looks like and it was on the envelopes that came back. Every move we made for six years, I sent at least one letter from that address because I had some sick hope you’d reply.”

“OK, OK, no need for the melodrama,” Sharon said. “We’re not going to rehash who did what. I’m here now, aren’t I?”

“Yes, but why? Why now?” Adora said. “If you saw doctorate on the invite and thought I was going to be loaded, I have some fun facts for you about what doctors of philosophy make.”

“How tacky. I am not here to try and milk you of your money,” Sharon replied. “Why did you even bother to invite me if you weren’t expecting to see me?”

“Because it was damn near a tradition at this point,” Adora spat back. “I send you something and then get silence in return and you still haven’t said why you picked now to actually respond.”

Sharon sighed as she held the bag out as she said, “We can discuss that but for now, I got you something for your graduation.”

Adora felt sickly validated by the gift and it took effort to cross her arms to keep from taking it as she said, “I’m not taking a gift from you.”

“It’s rude to…,” Sharon started to say and Adora cut her off.

“It’s rude to cut your child off because she fell in love and then refuse to speak to her for nine years,” Adora replied. “Last chance

before I walk away, *why are you here now?"*

Sharon sniffed in disapproval as she put the bag back down by her side and said, "I was hoping we could talk over dinner."

"I'm not going anywhere with you," Adora said, suddenly remembering that she was supposed to be meeting everyone at the south entrance. "What do you want?"

"Is it so inconceivable that I wanted to see my daughter?" Sharon said.

"Yes," Adora said.

"That wounds me," Sharon said.

Adora almost said good but snapped it back as she said, "Explain, now."

Sharon stood for a moment, not speaking, and Adora was about to walk off when she finally spoke.

"I'm sick."

Adora rolled her eyes as she said, “Are you kidding? That is the most transparent…”

She trailed off as Sharon reached into her purse and brought out a folded sheet of paper that she held out for Adora to take. Adora looked at her and then the paper. Almost everything in her told her to walk away but the little girl in her who still loved her mother had her reaching out and taking the paper from her and unfolding it. She read for a moment before sighing.

She looked at the paper, not able to look up into her mother’s eyes, as she said, “How bad?”

“Pretty bad,” Sharon said.

“I know this can be helped with donations,” Adora said, looking back up. “You don’t care about me, you’re just here to see if I’m a donor match, aren’t you?”

“Being sick gives you a new outlook on life…,” Sharon started to say when Adora shook her head.

“No,” Adora said. “This isn’t dated just the other day. You ran out of options, didn’t you?”

“The waiting list is really long and…,” Sharon said and again Adora cut her off.

“Yep, you ran out of options,” Adora said as she held the paper back out to Sharon.

“You really have changed,” Sharon said. “The Adora I knew never would have been so heartless. You were a kind child, who cared about people with the shining love of Christ. The Devil has hardened your heart against your own mother.”

“You hardened my heart against you,” Adora said. “God and the Devil had no part in it so take some responsibility for your own actions.”

“You can’t even face how you’ve fallen,” Sharon said with a shake of her head. “I know what’s Truth from God.”

Adora snorted as she fought back a laugh as she held up her diploma case and said, “You really want to debate religion and ethics with me?”

“You don’t know the real Gospel anymore. You just know what your secular books say,” Sharon said. “I can see with the witness of my own eyes and ears how you have become.”

“I know the Gospel better than you, I’ve read them in the original Greek,” Adora said before shaking her head. “Why am I even arguing with you? I’m leaving.”

Adora started to push past Sharon when she put a hand on Adora's arm. Adora was about to shove her away when she looked into Sharon's eyes and saw fear.

"Adora… wait," she said. Adora hesitated, the little girl within her seeing the fear and feeling scared herself and the force of wanting to please her mommy holding her in place as she tried to think of what to say, when she heard Catra.

"I told you you'd get lost… what the hell are you doing here!? Get your hands off of her!" Catra said. Adora turned to see Catra stomping their way, her hands balled up into fists and her whole body tensed in fury.

"Catra, hold on," Adora said.

Catra's eyes snapped to Adora and she slowed down.

"Your friend?" Sharon said.

"That is my *wife* and you better get that right going forward," Adora said as she turned back to Sharon.

"Going forward?" Sharon said.

“Yes, going forward,” Adora said and held her hand out to Catra without taking her eyes off of Sharon. “Sweetheart, do you have one of my cards?”

“Adora…,” Catra started to say but trailed off as Adora turned to look at her.

“Please?” Adora said and Catra muttered as she took her wallet out and pulled out a card with Adora’s name and contact information on it. She handed it to Adora while glaring at Sharon.

Adora stepped back, Sharon’s hand slipping off her arm as she did, and held the card out to her.

“I am going to go with my wife and friends to celebrate my achievement,” Adora said. “You can write to me with the details and I will decide what needs to be done. Do you understand?”

“You would seriously…!” Sharon started to say.

“She said do you understand, lady, it’s not hard,” Catra snapped.

Sharon’s whole face filled with anger and was about to respond as Adora spoke up in the voice she used to reach the very back of lecture halls when the A/V equipment was on the fritz.

“Enough!” Adora said and didn’t notice several people suddenly turning to look at them. Catra and Sharon both turned their attention to her as she went on in a more normal tone. “You don’t get to order me around. I will decide how this goes, not you. This is how it is.”

“You have changed,” Sharon said, shaking her head.

Adora stepped to Catra and took her wife’s hand as she said, “More than you will ever know.”

Adora walked away then as Catra fought the urge to turn around and stick her tongue out at Sharon.

Chapter End Notes

Here we go! The last fic in the Camp Bright Moon series. I've been looking forward to this one and a good portion of it has been written. I can't wait for you all to read it.

That song Adora has stuck in her head at graduation is Turn, Turn, Turn by the Byrds and is an arrangement of Ecclesiastes 3:1-8. I like to think she heard it at Micah and Angella’s place and immediately felt a connection to it because it was secular music but it was religious as well. There’s a version by Pete Seeger as well if you’re interested (the original if memory serves) and it’s more liturgical feeling, if that makes sense.

I write for myself but I post for you so thank you for reading!

Chapter Two

Chapter Summary

Adora has run into her mother for the first time in nine years and now she's not sure what to do.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As they made their way through the crowd, Catra hugged Adora's arm tight as she said, "Are you alright?"

Adora was fighting back tears as she said, "No, I'm not and I don't want to be crying when we get to everyone else. Can we stop please?"

They moved beside a column out of the flow of people and Catra hugged her tight as Adora put her head on Catra's shoulder.

"It's alright," Catra said. "I mean, it's completely fucked up but it's alright."

Adora gave a little laughing snort that was followed by a long sigh before she looked back up.

“I can’t believe this,” she said as she wiped at her eyes. “All these years and this is when she shows up.”

“Do you want to talk about it?” Catra asked.

“Not now,” Adora said. “I’ve kept everyone waiting long enough. I want to go out to dinner, I want to laugh with my friends, and then I want to go home with my wife and I’m going to pretend like the world is still the world it was this morning.”

“We can do that,” Catra said as she put a hand on Adora's face. “It’s just one more thing and we’ve gotten through plenty of those.”

“We have,” Adora said, taking the hand and giving it a kiss before letting out another sigh. “OK, dinner.”

“Don’t look so excited,” Catra said as she gave a little hip bump to Adora as they began to walk again.

The next few hours went well. Adora put on a cheerful face and after a little bit found out she was cheerful as she forced the memory down. As she expected, Glimmer had picked some high end restaurant that sat at the top of a skyscraper that made Adora choke when she saw the prices.

Before Adora could say anything Glimmer was already cutting her off as she said, “Adora, stop. Just order what you want. This is your night.”

“Before you say are you sure, she’s sure,” Catra said, leaning into Adora.

“I don’t like how you can guess what I’m going to do,” Adora said with a smile.

“As if you don’t do the same thing to her,” Bow said.

“I don’t!” Adora said as Scorpia, Perfuma, and Casta replied that she absolutely did. Juliet just gave her a raised eyebrow with a smile and Adora rolled her eyes as she stuck her head back in the menu.

Glimmer dealt with the waiter as Micah had Angella laughing as he horribly mispronounced some of the French names of the food on purpose. Everyone commented on the beautiful view of the city spread out in glittering lights seven hundred feet below them. Adora almost started crying again when some bread was brought to the table and Bow tore a piece off of his and held it up while saying, “In remembrance of our friendship” before eating it. Adora held up her roll as well in a little toast and when the wine came, they didn’t go as far as serving each other from their glasses but they did have a moment of recognition.

After the main course was cleared away, as they waited on the dessert to come out, Scorpia pushed Adora for a speech which quickly got picked up by the others at the table, drawing glances from the other diners. Finally, Adora, making little hand gestures to quiet down, agreed to it.

"I don't have much to say. Thank you to everyone at this table, I couldn't have done it without you. Your support, your love, your advice, it all meant something to me and I'll never forget," Adora said and then her eyes caught on a red dress on a woman walking across the restaurant to a table. Adora faltered for a moment and looked down at the table as she swallowed past the sudden lump in her throat. Catra placed a hand on her shoulder and Adora gave a strained smile before looking at the rest as she went on. "You've all been there for me when you didn't have to, for both of us in fact, and I can never thank you enough. Thank you."

She was saved awkward questions as the desserts came around. Adora tucked into an enormous paris-brest pastry, trying to ignore the thoughts running in her head. She was able to recover in enough time to be able to continue in the conversation and was just fine as they all went downstairs and started saying good-bye.

"I hope to see you soon," Scorpia said as she hugged Adora. "You have to see what we've done with the old camp."

"We're going up to Bright Moon for the solstice in a few weeks. I promise we'll see you then," Adora said.

Angella and Micah were next in line for hugs as Micah chatted on about the solstice ceremony.

"I can't wait," he said. "Hopefully the field will be clear and not a swamp like it was last year."

"Record rainfall, what can you do about it?" Adora said with a final hug to him.

It was Angella that caught her off guard as she hugged Adora tightly and whispered to her, "Whatever is bothering you, know you can talk to us if you need."

Adora hugged her back just as tight as she said, "I will."

"Good," Angella said.

It wasn't long before the farewells were over and Catra and Adora were walking to the bus stop to catch a ride back to their home. Glimmer and Bow walked with them, chatting about minor things as they did.

"Well, Doctor Manzana, what comes next?" Glimmer said with a laugh.

“I start on my next paper,” Adora said. “Publish or die, you know how it is. Maybe I’ll chase tenure, we’ll see.”

“Good plan,” Bow said. “I don’t know how you managed it. I was so done with school after the bachelors.”

“Is that why you’re always talking about going back for your masters?” Catra said.

“Talking about it and doing it are two entirely separate things,” Bow said. “Besides, I like working with the foundation and I’d probably have to quit to really pursue it.”

“The foundation might as well attack windmills while you’re at it,” Catra said with a roll of her eyes as she leaned up against the bus stop sign. “Pushing progressive politics in this state is a waste of time.”

“Someone has to do it,” Bow said.

“I know and I’m glad someone is but all I know is that tomorrow, I’m going to wake up and hammer on some steel while pretending it’s Senator Colk,” Catra said, referring to a state senator trying, and succeeding in some cases, to pass various anti-queer bills, “and then when I’m done, I have something made.”

“I just wish we could have kept fostering kids,” Adora said. “Just not a good idea though with that law they keep pushing and that AG opinion but I still miss it.”

“Well with Fran gone, it would have been so much harder,” Glimmer said. “She really did use you two as like the no fucking around foster home. Adora to give the kid all the philosophy and Catra to threaten someone with a hammer if they came nosing around.”

Catra laughed as she said, “Yeah, she did.” She got somber as she went on. “I heard from her the other day by the way.”

Bow’s face fell a little as he said, “How’s she doing?”

“She’s out of the inpatient treatment and is doing a day program now,” Catra said. “She sounded better but it’s hard to tell you know?”

“I’m just glad that coworker found her,” Glimmer said. Adora nodded before she perked up and changed the subject a little.

“I talked with Madison this morning. They and Riley got settled down. When we go up for the solstice we’ll have to try and take a day trip to go see them.”

There were agreements and as Bow talked about a possible plan for it, Adora suddenly thought of her mother. She thought about how there was more than likely an email waiting for her already and if she didn't, it was coming at any moment. Bow was the one who caught the expression on her face.

"Adora, you alright?" he asked.

"Sorry, must be tired," Adora replied as she tried to plaster on a smile.

"Nope," Glimmer said. "Somethings up. You were distracted when you and Catra finally caught up with us, your eyes were red, which implies you had been crying, and something has been troubling you but it didn't start until after the ceremony judging by your general body language, which up to that point had been upbeat and excited."

"You're not in court," Catra said.

"That's not my court mannerism. You couldn't survive my court mannerism," Glimmer said. "Now, is something going on? Is Catra leaving you for a superstar again?"

"Confess one crush and you never live it down," Catra said with a roll of her eyes as Adora put her arm around Catra and pulled her close.

“After the ceremony I ran into my mother,” Adora said. She had expected silent shock. She should have known better.

“Oh, fuck her!” Glimmer said, drawing a few looks from people walking down the sidewalk. “Are you fucking serious!?”

“Yeah, I saw her,” Catra said.

“Did she just want to see you graduate?” Bow said and Adora gave a tiny smile at Bow expecting the best from someone.

“No, she’s sick,” Adora said. “Leukemia, I forget which one. She wants me to be a donor.”

She got the silence then as Glimmer and Bow stepped forward and wrapped her up in their arms.

As the bus came, Glimmer stepped back as she said, “We’re taking you home tonight.”

“It’s alright, the bus is here, we can talk later,” Adora said.

“Nope, it’s not happening,” Glimmer said. “Come on. The garage is just down the block.”

Adora wanted to argue but she couldn’t bring herself to do so and just followed Glimmer. As they got into the car, Glimmer got it started up and pulled out onto the road with a screech of tires.

“Should have taken the bus,” Catra said, “it’d have been safer.”

“I drive just fine,” Glimmer said as she cut off a pickup behind her and Bow did his best not to comment. “Now, you’re going to need a protective order to keep her from bothering you. I can have a temporary one for you by ten in the morning tomorrow, nine if the right clerk is at the courthouse. I just need a few bits of information from you.”

“I’m not doing that,” Adora said as she stared out the window. “I’m going to help her.”

Bow reached into the backseat and patted Adora’s leg as he said, “I get it.”

“I don’t,” Catra said as she squeezed Adora’s hand. “I’ll support you though.”

“I can’t let her just die,” Adora said and before she knew it, she was crying. Catra leaned over with an arm around her and Bow

twisted around the best he could to hand her some tissue and rest his hand on Adora’s leg in comfort.

Glimmer drove out of downtown into an area of old warehouses and industrial buildings near the river that ran through town. She pulled up to the gate of one building that sat by itself with empty lots around it. The building was a big Quonset hut-style structure and fading paint on the side declared it the home of A-1 Reliable Machining Company. The gate itself had a big sign made of polished steel with an apple cut into it and the words Manzana Metalworks beneath that. Glimmer rolled down her window and punched in a code on the beat up keypad and then rolled through as the gate opened and parked by the giant garage door next to Catra’s pickup and Adora's old subcompact car.

Adora for her part was calming down as she saw her and Catra’s home. She could see the boughs of the big old tree that sat behind the building and the gravel walk that went behind the building to the back patio. Glimmer turned around as Adora took a deep breath.

“Thank you for taking us home,” she said.

“I offered earlier but you wanted to take the bus,” Glimmer said.

“It stops right there,” Adora said, pointing at the unlit bus stop by their gate.

“Want to talk about what’s happening?” Glimmer asked.

“It’s what I said,” Adora said as Bow passed her some more tissue. “After all of this I can’t just let her… you know.”

Glimmer gave a little grunt as she said, “You’re a better person than I am.”

“No, you’d do the same,” Adora said. Glimmer’s eyes told a different story but Adora didn’t want to push it.

“You know, you don’t have to do anything you don’t want to,” Bow said softly. Adora looked at him in surprise as he smiled back at her. “I know but it’s true.”

“I want to,” Adora said. “It’s the right thing.”

“Then she should have done the right thing,” Catra muttered and Adora squeezed her hand.

“Two wrongs don’t make a right,” she said.

“Doctor of philosophy here,” Catra said as she pushed Adora’s head with her forehead. Adora laughed a little and sank back into the seats of Glimmer’s car.

“It’s true but that’s not why, not really and I’m not sure I can really sum it all up tonight,” Adora said. “That said, I think I’m going to go in now. Thank you again everyone. Sorry for bringing the night down.”

“Hey, it’s your party,” Bow said. “You do what you want.”

“I want to go to bed,” Adora said. “It’d been a long day even before this.”

“Alright, love you,” Bow said as Glimmer echoed his words.

“Love you both,” Adora said as she and Catra got out of the car. Glimmer waited until they went in the door next to the big garage door before driving off. Adora walked through the gloom of Catra’s metalworking shop towards their home in the back. It’d been offices until they’d bought it when Catra had sold a piece of metal art for a particularly good sum a year before and then they’d renovated it together into living space. Adora walked into the living room, tossing her graduation gown on an overstuffed easy chair in the gentle light of a colored lamp they’d left on.

“Finn, we’re home,” Adora hollered to be rewarded by the sounds of little feet running down the hallway towards them. She leaned down and picked up the blonde cat that came running across the floor to her and held it close as it purred up a storm.

“Cat loves you more than me, I’m telling you,” Catra said with a laugh as she tossed her jacket on top of Adora’s graduation gown.

“I’m sure Finn loves us both equally,” Adora said as she sat down on the couch. “Don’t you, beautiful?”

Finn looked up at her before settling back down into her lap with more purrs. Catra went into the kitchen off the living room and grabbed two cookies from a platter before walking back into the living room. She held one out to Adora who just shook her head. Catra shrugged as she sat down on the couch next to Adora and began to eat one.

“You refused a cookie. You must be distressed,” Catra said. Adora fiddled with Finn’s ears for a moment, watching them flick as she did, before she responded.

“Is it sick that there’s a part of me that’s happy she came?” Adora said quietly.

“Kind of, yeah,” Catra said as she set the second cookie on the back of the couch.

“Just for a moment there, I was like, ‘Yes! Mommy loves me!’ before all the anger came screaming in,” Adora said. “That’s still there, even though I know the only reason she was really there was because she wanted something from me.”

“Can I tell you something?” Catra said. Adora shifted a little to face Catra, earning a dirty look from Finn in the process who jumped out of her lap and went over to lay down in one of the many cat beds around the home.

“Sorry, Finn,” Adora said. “Yes, you can tell me something.”

“OK, so yeah, I never really had parents. A ward of the state ‘twas I,” Catra said, adopting what she thought a Dickensian character would sound like as she said the last part. Then she sagged a little as she went on. “That doesn’t mean I don’t miss having them. I used to dream up ideal parents. Stuff like a father who’d teach me stuff and a mother who I could confide in. A mother who would be serious but loving, showing her love for me in little gestures. A father who would laugh with a deep belly laugh and smoked a pipe while he puttered around making models on the weekend.” Catra trailed off as she sniffed a little and Adora took her hand sitting on the back of the couch. “I guess what I’m saying is that despite what I said, yeah, I guess I do get why you’re doing this. Your mom is shit but she’s at least there.”

“Yeah, she is,” Adora said, not specifying which part of Catra’s statement she was agreeing with.

“I understand is where I’m going,” Catra said.

“Good because I’m not sure I entirely do myself,” Adora replied.

“Listen, I have an idea of how to handle this. We can either sit up late and talk this to death or…,” Catra said. Adora looked at her and when she didn’t immediately go on, made a little hand gesture at her to hurry it up. Catra grinned as she continued. “We can go to bed, cuddle, and get some sleep and deal with this in the morning. Because this is not getting taken care of all at once tonight.”

“You had me at bed,” Adora said as she stood up from the couch, stretched, and then held her hand out to Catra.

“I figured it’d be at cuddle,” Catra said as she stood, took the second cookie, and then took Adora’s hand.

“Nope, sleeping sounds great right about now,” Adora said as they started towards the back. “I don’t have to do anything or be anywhere tomorrow so I am going to sleep as late as I want with no alarm.”

They turned off the lamp in the living room and made their way to the bedroom, little cat feet padding along behind them.

Chapter End Notes

> So, remember that letter from The Summer After that Catra wrote to Adora? Where she wrote about what she wanted? Here’s the passage:
>
> > I want you to do this thing where you’re figuring out religion and I want to work metal and make art with it. I

> want us to have a place where I can have a big shop and we'll build a house behind it and you can have a big office where you can put up all your diplomas and books and stuff. It'll be ours and we can have our friends over and I'll wake up next to you every day. We can sit out on the porch and watch the clouds and have dinner together and maybe a little fire on the patio, like Micah and Angella have. You and me.

I bring that up to say, they did it. It isn't quite like they imagined back then but it's theirs.

Chapter Three

Chapter Summary

> Adora wakes up the morning after her graduation, not sure what all had just happened. Then she goes to check her email.

Chapter Notes

> Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora's plan was to sleep in with no alarm but she still found herself awake and staring at the ceiling before eight in the morning. Catra had been up for a little while and as Adora drifted out of the bedroom, and the insulation they'd installed to deaden the noise from the shop, she heard Catra hammering on something in the main shop area. Living next to the shop, Adora had become a connoisseur of shop noises and whatever Catra was working on was small so the hammer blows were almost musical. Adora liked those but could do without the brutal noise that came off of Catra's vintage, renovated drop hammer when it was in use.

She went into the kitchen and poured some cereal that she just picked at before sighing and walking out into the shop. She leaned against the railing that separated the main work area from the little walkway from the outside door to their living area and watched as Catra held up a piece of copper and gave it a critical eye before nodding and setting it aside. Catra caught Adora out of the corner of her eye and took off the headset she was wearing and Adora could hear music screaming out of it before Catra paused it.

“You know, the point of hearing protection is protecting your hearing, not finishing it off,” Adora said.

Catra walked over to Adora as she said, “It’s not that loud.”

“I could clearly hear it over here,” Adora said.

Catra leaned forward and gave Adora a kiss before she said, “What happened to sleeping in today?”

Adora shrugged as she looked over at Catra’s workbench and saw more copper shapes.

“Making that kitchen set?” Adora said.

“Finishing it up actually,” Catra said. “I’ll deliver this afternoon and you’re avoiding a question.”

“Fine,” Adora said. “I can’t sleep. I keep thinking about last night.”

“I get it. That’s a lot to take in, Doctor,” Catra said with a little grin.

Adora shook her head with a little laugh as she said, “Stop. I swore I wasn’t going to be one of those people who insisted on being called doctor. Besides, who’s trying to change the subject now?”

“You know you love it,” Catra said and Adora nodded as Catra went on. “Fine. What is going on? Have you even heard from her?”

Adora shook her head as she said, “I haven’t checked. That card I gave her only has my work phone and email on it.”

“Good,” Catra said.

Adora nodded but didn’t say anything else. Catra watched her for a minute before she spoke up.

“Listen, you’re standing out here in boxers, slippers, and a t-shirt. How about you go back in, eat something, and try to relax.”

“You think I didn’t try that already?” Adora responded.

“Well, the apprentice is going to be here soon and besides, it’s cold,” Catra said.

"It's not cold out here," Adora said. "I'll go in though, to spare you the embarrassment of others seeing your wife in fuzzy slippers."

As Adora backed up to the door with a smile, Catra shook her head as she said, "It's not the slippers, it's the Holy Rollers shirt."

Adora looked down at her t-shirt emblazoned with gold block script that said Holy Rollers with the word holy above a pair of white, winged roller skates and the word roller beneath them.

"Hey, you loved going to their matches," Adora said as she grabbed the doorknob in her hand.

"I did and if the shirt still looked like it did when we were going to them, it wouldn't be a problem," Catra said, pointing at the various holes all over it.

"I stopped wearing it out at least," Adora said before blowing Catra a kiss and going back into the living area.

Once inside, she went down the hall to a tiny room that served her as an office. It had shelves built into the wall on one side and Adora was pretty sure it had been a supply closet when the place had been offices but it fit a small table at one end and the shelves held books, files, and notebooks now. Her diplomas were hung on the wall opposite the shelves and Catra had already hung the empty frame she'd made for Adora's latest. She pulled out her old

office chair she'd bought at a surplus auction, ignored the squeak from the chair frame as she sat down, and fired up her computer.

While she waited for the computer to start up, she stared at the notebooks and assorted paper she hadn't filed away yet from her dissertation and picked one of the notebooks up to flip through it before almost immediately putting it back down. She'd spent months of her life working on it and suddenly found she didn't want to even look at it. She knew that wouldn't last but she'd have to get some distance first before she could even think about it.

Her computer finally got to the desktop and she smiled at the picture that was her background. It was of her sitting with Catra, Glimmer, and Bow on the dock at Camp Bright Moon from a few summers back. She had worked there straight through her bachelors, picking up other work when she was in school, but had given it up when she graduated. They still made a point of going out for at least a week around the summer solstice when they could and if they couldn't, they'd still go out for a week during the summer and various shorter visits here and there. They hadn't missed a winter solstice yet though and she still stayed up the whole night in vigil.

As she stared at the photo, she moved the mouse and let the cursor hover over the shortcut to her work email. She finally talked herself into opening it up and the program immediately told her she had her out of office reply on and asked if she wanted to turn it off. She didn't see anything new from the last time she'd checked it the previous morning and let out a long sigh of relief that sputtered out as the server updated and sent several new messages. Most of them were on the lines of congratulations from friends and colleagues but one from late the previous night was

from an email she'd never seen. The name alone was enough for her to know though as the email was from the username blessedofgod7.

Adora leaned back in her chair as she doubted exactly what she wanted to do. She considered just deleting it and blocking the email address but then she thought of what she had seen on the paper the night before and shook her head as she clicked on the email.

"Dear Adora, I am reaching out because I… blah, blah, blah," Adora muttered as she read the email. It wasn't long but it was a mix of sweetness and subtle backhanded judgment that her mother was quite good at and Adora shook her head again as she saw the name of a doctor and contact information near the end.

"Contact her first thing on Monday," Adora read and gritted her teeth as she heard her mother's commanding voice in her head. She read the last bit that suggested Adora call her mother to talk as soon as she could and then snorted at the closing.

In God's Eternal Love,

Sharon Weaver

Ephesians 6:1-3

Adora's hand gripped the mouse tight at the verse because she knew exactly what it said. Her mother had quoted it at her constantly growing up and Adora almost shot back an email that

just said Ephesians 6:4, since she felt that part always got left out, and then remembered what Ephesians 6:5 said and realized it was pointless to try and get into that kind of back and forth.

Adora considered not responding but finally just sent a short email. She wrestled with what to say. She didn't want to get into an argument, she knew she wouldn't get the apology she so desperately wanted, and so she just decided to keep it short.

I'll contact them Monday.

She looked at her auto signature that went out on every email and took a moment to put PhD after her name. She looked at the name Adora Manzana and thought about deleting the whole thing to try and keep it from being an issue. Then she felt guilty for wanting to delete the name she had from her wife and finally she realized she was overthinking everything and just hit send and went out into the living room. Finn looked up from where they were perched on the back of the couch, made a little chirping noise at Adora, and then rolled over a little before going back to sleep.

Adora heard the blows of a sledgehammer coming from the shop, not as bad as the trip hammer but definitely further up the unpleasant hammer noises, and sighed as she went out the outside door of the living room to their patio. She sat down in the sunlight and stared across the lawn towards the tall chain link fence in the back. When they'd first bought the place, the lawn had been weeds, dirt, and various pieces of industrial junk. They'd spent some time cleaning it up and then Catra had run a tiller over the whole thing, thrown down some native grass and wildflower seeds, and let it be. What had sprung up was far from

what most people would call a lawn but it was ground cover and Catra kept it mowed at least every other week during the season.

Now Adora was watching the waving grass and other weeds in the empty field behind their place as she picked at the peeling paint on the old wood chairs they'd stuck outside on the flagstone patio. She briefly thought about starting a fire in the hand built iron fire pit to distract herself but shook her head with another sigh.

"I remember those sighs," Glimmer said as she came walking around the side of the building, following a crushed gravel path that led to the parking lot. "What's on your mind?"

"I thought you and Bow were going up to see his dads today," Adora said.

"I backed out," Glimmer said as she sat down on a wooden bench.

"Please tell me you didn't back out to come see me," Adora said.

Glimmer looked at her initials carved into the bench, in a little heart with Bow's initials, as she said, "OK, I won't. But I did."

Adora shook her head as she said, “I’m going to be alright. I’ll ask if I need anything.”

“Except you never do,” Glimmer said. “That’s why I’m sitting here right now.”

“Hey, I do so,” Adora said and Glimmer laughed a little.

“You don’t but I’m not getting into that back and forth,” Glimmer said. “I know how fucked up you are about your mom and yeah, you’ve worked on that over the years, but come on, I know you.”

“Fine,” Adora said, leaning forward. “I actually considered telling her to get lost. Do you know how screwed up that is? Telling my own mother to go and die? I mean, do you have any idea how many arguments I’ve had in classes over the years about human life and its sanctity with some wannabe eugenist or know-it-all edgelord and then I can’t even do this thing for my own mother?”

Adora slammed back into the chair with a huff as Glimmer said, “Listen, you can Railcar Dilemma this to death…,”

“It’s the Trolley Problem and you know it,” Adora said.

Glimmer made a little rolling hand gesture like, “Yeah, yeah” as she went on.

“But the fact of the matter is that this is emotion, not some ivory tower philosophical logic problem that doesn’t actually say anything,” Glimmer said.

“You’re doing this just to rile me up and get me out of the funk,” Adora said.

“I mean, yeah, I am,” Glimmer said. “Did it work?”

“You know you almost got my Freshman level first day of class speech, right?” Adora said.

Glimmer put on a horrified face as she said, “No! You monster!”

Adora laughed then before letting out another sigh as she said, “Seriously though, I can’t just tell her to choke and trust me, I’ve spent plenty of time over the years fantasizing about just that. Like this is my dream. She *needs* me. If she wants a chance at life, she has to come to me.”

“And let me guess, she was arrogant about it?” Glimmer said.

Adora started to say it wasn’t that but she was suddenly nodding as she stood up and said, “Yes! She was all, ‘Oh, here, I brought a

gift. Oh, what do you mean I never reached out to you? Oh, by the way, I'm dying.'"

"And you wanted her to grovel," Glimmer replied.

Adora started to choke up as she said, "Yes! It's awful but yes, I wanted her on her knees! I wanted her to beg me!"

Adora turned her back on Glimmer and walked to the edge of the patio as she shook, wiping at the tears with angry swipes of her hand as she stared at the bare patch of dirt where she'd tried to start a garden when they'd moved in. She felt ashamed of herself but the anger that was simmering hot under the surface was turning that shame to something hateful as she gritted her teeth.

"Don't do that, you're going to end up at the dentist with a cracked tooth," Glimmer said from behind her.

"Glimmer, just…, not right now," Adora snapped.

"Sorry," Glimmer said and Adora sighed as she turned around.

"I'm sorry, you didn't deserve that," Adora said. "I know you're just trying to be helpful."

“Have you heard from her?” Glimmer asked. “Since last night?”

“I got an email that I responded to right before you got here,” Adora said. “Told her I would contact her doctor on Monday but that’s it. Can you believe she wanted me to call her?”

“Yeah, I can actually,” Glimmer said.

Adora crossed her arms and looked down at the packed pea gravel between the flagstones of the patio as she kicked at it a little.

“I guess I can too,” Adora said.

“You going to do it?” Glimmer said.

“No,” Adora said. “I don’t see why I need to. I can just talk to her doctors.”

“I get you,” Glimmer said.

“You think I should, don’t you?” Adora replied.

“I think it’s up to you,” Glimmer said.

“That’s not an answer.”

“Sure it is.”

“Fine, but it’s a lawyer’s answer.”

“I am a lawyer so that makes sense.”

Adora gave a half hearted laugh.

“Well, I guess we have the answer then. It’s just up to me.”

Glimmer put a hand on Adora’s arm as she said, “You say that like it’s some impossible thing for you. You’ve made harder decisions.”

“Not really, no,” Adora said.

“Oh, come on,” Glimmer said. “Yes, you have.”

“OK, maybe I have but this one feels so much more important. This one is, sheesh, it sounds cheesy to even say it but this one feels like life or death,” Adora said.

“Sheesh?” Glimmer said. “I know you don’t really curse but come on, do better than sheesh.”

Catra came around the corner of the building, her arms over her head as she stretched, and Adora gave a goofy smile at the sight of her wife.

“Hey there, Sparkles, saw your car,” Catra said. “What’s up?”

“I thought I’d come see how Adora was doing,” Glimmer said.

“And?” Catra said, looking at Adora.

“I’m doing fine,” Adora said. “And shouldn’t you be in there supervising your apprentice?”

“She’s doing fine,” Catra said. “I’ve got her working on a cleaver someone ordered. Idiot wants some weird ass metal, like carbon steel isn’t a perfectly good kitchen knife steel. The only hard thing will be the temper on it but she can shape it just fine. You with us for the day, Glimmer?”

“I can be,” Glimmer said.

“Hang around for lunch at least,” Catra said with a grin.

“What’re you having?” Glimmer said, looking suspiciously at Catra.

“Whatever you’re picking up for us,” Catra replied.

“I walked right into that,” Glimmer said.

“You did. Some lawyer,” Catra said.

“Hey, I am an amazing lawyer and you know it first hand,” Glimmer said with a laugh.

“You are,” Adora said. “And I’ll go with you and pick it up.”

“In that case, Thai,” Catra said.

“Can do,” Adora replied.

Chapter End Notes

If you're wondering about Ephesians 6 and what in the world is going on there, it's like a textbook example of how you need to read at least the whole section, and the chapter is better, if someone quotes just a verse at you. Context is everything. The section from Ephesians 6 that was quoted follows.

Ephesians 6:1-9
1 Children, obey your parents in the Lord, for this is right.
2 "Honor your father and mother"—which is the first commandment with a promise—
3 "so that it may go well with you and that you may enjoy long life on the earth."
4 Fathers, do not exasperate your children; instead, bring them up in the training and instruction of the Lord.
5 Slaves, obey your earthly masters with respect and fear, and with sincerity of heart, just as you would obey Christ.
6 Obey them not only to win their favor when their eye is on you, but as slaves of Christ, doing the will of God from your heart.
7 Serve wholeheartedly, as if you were serving the Lord, not people,
8 because you know that the Lord will reward each one for whatever good they do, whether they are slave or free.
9 And masters, treat your slaves in the same way. Do not threaten them, since you know that he who is both their Master and yours is in heaven, and there is no favoritism with him.

Yeah, this is, as we say, problematic now. You could write whole dissertations on this more than likely (and I'm sure someone has).

The part about Adora picking up her work and then immediately putting it back down is such a mood for me with my fic, especially the long ones. I'm really proud of them but as soon as I'm done with them, I do not want to look at them. It's just a whole, "I've been working on this forever. I

need to see something else." I'll come back and read them later, and the comments, but I need a little distance first.

Also, Catra bitching about steel is me speaking through her. I've done a little bit of blacksmithing, like very little but enough to know how, and I've got opinions on steel and knives and how people talk about the tempering of kitchen knives. I'll spare you my rant, except to say that ice tempering language on packaging means nothing because either you have to quench the steel at that temperature and you did it right or you weren't supposed to and you screwed up the temper. Ice tempering is basically marketing BS to make people think of a rugged smith plunging the knife into a quench bucket full of ice like a Viking or something. Also, carbon steel is a perfectly good knife steel, it's cheap and easy to sharpen to a good edge, but it's not stainless so you have to put in an ounce of extra effort to maintain it and it doesn't stay shiny. The modern steels that talk about how hard they are just mean to me that you're going to have a damn nightmare of a time sharpening them. Carbon steel you can literally sharpen on a rock. OK, so you got a bit of my rant. I should do a side story of Catra just bitching about this.

Chapter Four

Chapter Summary

It's the Monday after Adora's graduation and it's time to reach out to the doctor. The appointment gets set for that day and she doesn't know just what is in store for her.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Monday came and Adora made the phone call. She'd never been someone who hated doctor's offices, and in fact kind of liked the whole feel of them what with the healing feeling she got from them, but this was different. She'd only ever contacted a doctor's office for something like the flu. This was something else entirely.

"Ah, yes, Ms. Manzana, Ms. Weaver let us know you'd be calling," the receptionist said and Adora gritted her teeth at the presumption. "Now, we'll need you to come in for a physical as well as have you complete a medical history. Sooner is better than later so do you have a time that's good for you?"

Adora hadn't been prepared for that, she wasn't sure why, she completely understood the concept of needing to go in for an appointment and so she found herself fumbling to bring up her email to check her calendar.

"I'm sorry, I don't have one off the top of my head," Adora said, slipping into a neutral voice she thought of as her customer

service voice from when she'd worked at a call center for a time. "If you'll give me a moment, I'm reviewing my calendar." That part was pointless as she already saw she had plenty of time over the next week but she still took a moment before she responded. "I have time Wednesday afternoon or Friday morning."

Adora had more time than that but those times felt right.

"We can certainly fit you in during that time frame but Doctor Alsid has some time at one this afternoon if you can fit us in," the receptionist said.

Adora wanted to ask why the receptionist hadn't just led with that rather than ask Adora what time worked for her but she just nodded as she said, "Yes, I can manage that."

"Excellent," the receptionist said as she seemed to go on autopilot for the next part. "Please bring your ID, a current copy of your insurance, and a list of all your medications and dosages, including any over-the-counter medications you take regularly."

"I can do that," Adora said.

"Very good," the receptionist said as Adora heard her typing away. "If you give me your email address, I can send you the forms we'll need filled out so you can do that in advance."

Adora provided her email address and then the woman gave Adora the address to the office. The call came to an end and Adora found herself staring at the wall in her office as the sounds of work filtered in from Catra's workshop. She pulled up the email address she'd provided and watched but nothing came through in the couple of minutes she stared at it before she finally stood up and left the room. Finn was curled up under the couch when Adora came out into the living room and she spent a minute trying to get the cat's attention but they just looked at her and rolled over in the other direction.

"I'll remember that the next time you want a treat," Adora said, knowing it was a toothless threat.

She grabbed a set of hearing protection off a hook by the door and had them on as she went out into the shop. She immediately looked away as a welding arc lit the room in shifting blue-white shadows as a couple of people moved about the shop, working on various things. Catra had a tendency to take on anyone who wanted to try and learn metalworking. She couldn't promise steady work but she still managed to keep at least one apprentice on hand. Right now, she had two and they were rapidly getting to the point where calling them apprentices was not appropriate. One, a woman named Mia, was already selling her work under her own name. Catra had said her work, incredibly intricate sculptures of steel, copper, and bronze, was already beyond what Catra herself could manage in some respects.

It was Mia who saw Adora first, before she'd even stepped foot on the shop floor, and immediately shouted, "Hey! No! Shoes!"

She pointed with a tiny chasing hammer at Adora's feet, currently residing in slippers. Adora nodded understanding. She needed at least closed toe shoes to be in the shop. It was a rule Catra drilled into anyone who worked there and she'd told one person not to come back after that person had ignored the rule one too many times. Catra was bound and determined to run a shop with no accidents. Catra heard Mia's raised voice and straightened up, flipping up the welding mask with cat ears on it and whiskers drawn on around the mouth area to see what was going on.

"Hey," Catra said. "You need me?"

"Yeah," Adora said. Catra nodded and shut off the welder and hung up her mask as she headed towards Adora.

"Sorry, didn't mean to yell at her," Mia said.

"No, you did fine," Catra said, grinning at Adora as she spoke. "My own wife should know the rules as well as anyone. I'm glad you're not too shy to say something just because it's her."

"Gee, thanks," Adora said.

"It's for your own good," Catra said as she got up to Adora. "I love you and I love all your toes right where they're supposed to be."

Catra stopped at where Mia was working for a moment, gave approval at whatever it was she was doing, and then headed inside with Adora.

Adora hung the hearing protection back up as she said, "So, I talked with the doctor's office."

Catra leaned against the door as she said, "Alright, what's the word?"

"They want me in at one this afternoon," Adora said.

Catra raised her eyebrows a little as she said, "That soon?"

"That soon," Adora replied.

"That can't be good," Catra said.

"I don't know," Adora said. "I've never been through something like this before."

"Neither have I," Catra replied. "Closest is that cancer scare Angella had but that was over pretty fast. Do you want me to go with you?"

“Kind of?” Adora said. “I don’t know, it’s just a doctor’s visit. You know what, no, don’t go. I can handle it.”

“I don’t mind,” Catra said. “I mean, my boss is a pain in the ass but I think I can talk her into it.”

Adora laughed a little. It was an old joke, since Catra was her own boss, but it made her feel a bit better.

“No, I think I don’t need you to go,” Adora said.

“It’s really not a problem,” Catra said. “You don’t have to do it on your own.”

“Listen, if she was going to be there, yes, I’d want you along,” Adora said. “This is just some poke and prod thing though, I think. I can do that on my own.”

“Adora…,” Catra started to say and Adora laughed as she cut her off.

“You know, we’re going to do this back and forth, back and forth, each of us trying to be the most helpful,” Adora said. “Let me just take this one, alright?”

“That was not what we were doing,” Catra replied.

“That was absolutely what we were doing,” Adora said.

“Fine, it was what we were doing but I want it known, I was going to give up sweating and hauling heavy pieces of metal around in the shop for you,” Catra said. “You know how much I love that.”

Adora stepped up and hugged Catra, the scent of hot metal rising off her clothes as Adora did, as she said, “Yes, very noble of you.”

Catra gave her a kiss as she said, “It is, I agree.”

Adora spent the rest of the morning getting ready, filling out the forms that had been sent, and then sitting at her computer prepping for a summer intro course on philosophy she was teaching. She sat at their table for lunch with Catra, Mia, and the other apprentice, a woman named Chuck, and then headed out the door after a kiss from Catra.

The doctor’s office turned out to be at a big hospital complex that sat about a mile north of them and it took Adora longer than she expected to find a parking space. Then it took her what felt like forever to make her way through the winding halls. Finally, after

stressing out that she was going to be late, she walked into the waiting area right on time.

The receptionist looked up at her with an expectant face as Adora said, “Hello, I’m Adora Manzana. I have an appointment with Doctor Alsid at one.”

“Yes, I see you have already filled out your forms.” the receptionist replied as she typed. “Do you have your ID and insurance?”

Adora nodded, pulling them out of her shirt pocket where she’d stashed them before coming in so she wasn’t digging in her wallet, and handed them over as she said, “Yes, ma’am, right here.”

The woman ran them through a little desktop scanner before handing them back over.

“Thank you. If you could have a seat, the nurse will be out shortly.”

Adora sat down and picked up a magazine about jogging. She flipped through it, just amusing herself, and learned she needed a fancy type of shoe if she wanted to put one foot in front of the other in a rapid fashion and do it properly. She gave a little smile as she found herself pulling apart the logic in the article. The writing kind of reminded her of some of the students who took

her intro class thinking it was an easy A. She shook her head as she frowned suddenly and tossed the magazine back down as she remembered Sharon saying how she didn't know anything about the Gospel and in Adora's head, it was as a sneer.

Why am I wasting my time? Adora thought as she looked around the waiting room. At the same time, she knew why. She couldn't just let it happen and she leaned forward, her hands clenched tight in front of her. She knew she needed to talk with Catra about how she was feeling and now really wished she'd brought her along.

"Adora Manzana?" a nurse said.

"Here," Adora said and then felt silly answering like she was answering a roll call. She followed the nurse through a door and down several beige hallways before being put into an office. The nurse took her vitals, which Adora didn't understand why they were doing that, before telling her the doctor would be with her shortly. Adora sat in the room, idly reading the various posters on the wall, and tried not to play with her cellphone since there was a big sign asking people not to do so. After five minutes, she was engrossed in an online argument about some niche hypothesis about the nature of the early Christian church in Asia Minor and how it shaped the theology of the wider Christian world. She felt like she was just getting to the good part when Doctor Alsid came into the exam room.

"Hello, I'm Doctor Alsid," he said as he rubbed some sanitizer into his hands before pulling a monitor and keyboard over to him and began typing. "Ah, you're here about being a potential donor for Sharon Weaver. What do you know about the process?"

“Nothing really,” Adora said. She’d done her best not to research it as she knew she’d fall down a rabbit hole if she let herself.

“OK, well we need to make sure you’re a match for her but since you’re her daughter, it’s likely you will be,” Alsaid said before going on and laying out a general procedure of what would happen. As he came to the end, he said, “Then if all goes well, she should recover.”

“And if it doesn’t go well?” Adora said and then wished she hadn’t.

“Let’s not borrow trouble,” he said, his face slipping into a sympathetic look that was like a mask that slipped off again as he smiled and went on. “First things first. I’ll have the nurse come back and do a blood draw so we can do the HLA typing. We should have the results fairly quickly and then we’ll move to the next step. Do you have any questions?”

“Not at this time,” Adora said and Doctor Alsid smiled at her again.

“If you think of them, just ask or you can call if they come to you after you leave,” he replied. “If there’s nothing else, I’ll get the nurse in and get you on your way.”

He was out the door within a minute and the nurse was back shortly after and led her to a little alcove in the office where Adora sat and had a vial of blood drawn. As the nurse got everything ready she said, “So, what do you do when you’re not here?”

“I’m a professor of philosophy,” Adora said.

“Really!?” the nurse said. “Sounds fascinating. Roll up your sleeve please.”

As Adora did that she said, “It’s definitely got its moments but it’s also a lot of meetings and stuff.”

“I bet,” the nurse replied and then was quiet for a moment as she drew the blood. As she finished up and wrapped Adora’s arm, she went on. “Well, you should be good to go.”

“Thanks,” Adora said as she stood up and left. As she stepped out into the waiting room, she froze as she saw her mother coming out another door. The two stared at each other for a moment before Sharon spoke up.

“I see they got you in quickly,” she said.

“Yeah, they had a spot open,” Adora said, taking an uncomfortable step forward. “I just finished the blood draw.”

Sharon sighed and shook her head as she said, “Oh, if I never have another draw, it will be too soon. I swear, they’re like little vampires in that regard.”

Adora surprised herself by chuckling at the image of little vampires shuffling about as she said, “Gotta pay the blood tax, I guess.”

Sharon looked equally surprised when she chuckled at the joke as she said, “Indeed. If I may, I’m heading to the cafe in this building for a late lunch. Would you be interested in joining me?”

Adora started to make an excuse but something about the look on her mother’s face had her saying, “Sure, I’ll come along.”

The walk to the cafe was short but silent as the two of them walked a carefully calculated distance away from the other, as if leaving enough room for all their problems to walk between them, and they both ordered separately at the counter before taking a seat at a little table by the window. Adora looked out at a little walled garden full of trees and plants with a little water feature and a bench. The whole thing looked like no one had stepped foot into it since it was set up. The silence stretched before Sharon finally spoke up.

“May I ask what it is you do for a living?”

"I'm a professor," Adora said.

"So you teach classes?" Sharon said.

Adora could see she was trying to be civil and so she took a breath, gave a little shrug, and said, "A few. Mostly I supervise TA's who do the actual teaching but I always try and teach an intro class. That's just part of it though. I also do research and write about philosophy."

Sharon started to say something and stopped herself and Adora found herself tensing up, waiting for the inevitable dig.

"I saw that you got your degree in religion and ethics," Sharon said. "That sounds interesting."

Adora looked for the dig, the insult, the underhanded compliment, but as far as she could tell, there was nothing there. It was just a curious question.

"It really is," Adora said. "I love my intro classes. Kids take them because they think it'll be an easy class to get a few credits but I try and engage them and show why they should care about the field, even if they're not going to major in it."

Sharon didn't say anything for a moment and Adora was already running through her head what she had said wrong when Sharon

smiled.

"You really light up when you talk about that," Sharon said. "It must be fulfilling."

Adora blinked once in surprise before she said, "It really is. I've learned so much and engaging with those kids, I say kids, they're college students," Adora laughed before she went on, "but engaging with them and getting them to really think about these grand concepts is a big highlight."

"What grand concepts?" Sharon said and Adora almost flinched as she suddenly realized she'd probably just walked right into a trap. Sharon wasn't going to respond well to anything like basic philosophy that wasn't grounded in the Biblical. Adora thought about just waffling on the answer but plowed ahead anyway.

"The nature of existence, reality, what we can and can't know, and what does it mean to be ethical," Adora said. "Things like that."

Sharon paused once again but when she spoke, she surprised Adora.

"That sounds deep. You received a doctorate in all of that?"

“I did,” Adora said and couldn’t help but feel happy that her mother seemed impressed. It wasn’t anything she said or even really did. It was less something being there and more something not being there. She hadn’t belittled or laughed or scolded her. She hadn’t made any little gestures or facial expressions that Adora had known so well as a child. Adora didn’t even think about it at the time but she felt good, she felt validated.

“That’s very interesting,” Sharon said and then the two were silent as a waiter sat their orders down on the table and took the little plastic number while telling them by rote to enjoy their lunch. They both thanked him and Adora went to pick up the spoon for the cup of soup she’d ordered when she saw Sharon staring at her. Old instincts snapped back to her like old machinery coming to life in a cloud of dust and rattling and she sat the spoon back down. Adora waited for the rebuke for eating without praying but it didn’t come. Sharon simply bowed her head and Adora did the same, feeling out of place in a way she never had when she’d done this regularly.

“Lord, from you, all good things flow and so ask that you bless this food and give thanks for all that you have given us. Watch over us, guide us in the path you have laid out for us, and protect this great nation from evil,” Sharon said. “We ask this in Jesus’ holy name, amen.”

“Amen,” Adora echoed back before she picked up her spoon again. The two of them were quiet as they each took a few bites of their food.

“How is yours?” Adora said, nodding at the salad her mother was eating.

“It’s good,” Sharon replied. “And yours?”

“Pretty good,” Adora said. “Kind of surprised actually. I’d always heard hospital food is terrible.”

“The kind they serve in the rooms might be but I’ve found this place to be quite acceptable,” Sharon said.

Adora had a momentary flashback to her childhood. Acceptable was her mother’s way of saying that things met her minimum standard. Quite acceptable meant she liked it. Superb meant it was, well, superb. Adora’s efforts had received an acceptable on occasion and quite acceptable would please her. She didn’t think she’d ever had something described as superb more than a handful of times though and she frowned as she picked at the chips sitting next to her soup.

“I’ll have to remember it, bring Catra here sometime for lunch,” Adora said, feeling the sting of that thought. As she did, she realized she’d mentioned Catra as a way to try and start an argument. She found she didn’t particularly care.

“Indeed,” Sharon replied and then went quiet.

The two sat for a second and then resumed eating. Adora knew that bringing Catra up had brought up the fact that she was a

lesbian and that was the reason they hadn't seen each other in years. The fact hung over them like a corpse dangling from a gallows and Adora dug into the last of her cup of soup grimly while waiting for the inevitable comment but it never came.

"So do you have any hobbies?" Sharon said and Adora felt like she'd taken a step, expecting a fall, and then just kept going forward as normal.

"Why haven't you talked to me in almost ten years!?" is what Adora wanted to scream at her. What she said though was, "I'm not sure I'd say hobbies. My work is kind of my hobby, I do a lot of reading and stuff that relates but is still for fun. However, we do board game nights and stuff with friends when we can all get together."

Sharon nodded as she took another bite of her salad. After chewing, she said, "That's good. It's good to have people you can spend time with."

Adora smiled, as she saw the hidden jibe at herself, as she felt like she was back on familiar ground now with her mother. She was determined though to not fall into her old habits as she said, "It certainly is. I've made lots of close friends. And you? Have you kept busy?"

Sharon nodded again as she replied, "I have. Still busy as ever running various projects. I helped start a food bank a few years ago that the church runs now. That was quite fulfilling to bring the love of God in tangible form to those who need it."

In spite of herself, Adora found herself interested as she said, "That is good. Which food bank, perhaps I've heard of it."

Sharon made a little it's no big deal gesture with her hand as she said, "It's nothing big. It's Helping Heart Food Bank. They're on the south side."

Adora didn't say anything for a moment. Helping Heart Food Bank was one of the more well known food banks in the city at that point, if only through their advertising.

"I have heard of them actually," Adora had said. "They're growing from what I heard."

"Yes, they are," Sharon said. "I did their books for them when they first got started up, advised them, things like that."

Again, silence fell at the table and Adora went to take a bite of her soup to find it all gone and grabbed a some chips, simply as something to do to avoid awkwardly sitting at the table thinking of something to say. They both ate a little in silence before Sharon spoke up as she sat her fork down in the remains of her salad.

"I appreciate you coming to lunch with me but I do have to go."

Adora nodded, feeling relief that things had come to an end without any blow ups.

"It's not a problem. The doctor said they'd do some blood typing and that I'd hear back from them," Adora replied. "I assume they'll let you know."

Sharon stood up, picking up her trash as she did, as she said, "Of course."

Adora stood as well, picking up her trash as well, not sure what she'd do if her mother tried to hug her as she said, "Well, I'll be on my way."

Sharon looked at Adora, her face unreadable as the two stared at each other, before she said, "Of course. Drive safely."

"Thank you. You do the same," Adora said as she backed up a step, stood in one place for a moment, and then gave a little nod and walked out, throwing her trash away as she went.

She didn't turn to look but Sharon watched her go all the way out the door.

Chapter End Notes

I was chuckling to myself when I wrote the part with Adora interacting with the receptionist and the scheduling because that is something that happens all the time to me. I swear

they're trained not to just throw a date out themselves half the time. I have learned to respond with, "What day and times do you have available" instead of throwing a date and time out. Nothing else to say for the moment so I hope you enjoyed and thank you for reading!

Chapter Five

Chapter Summary

Adora heads home after her lunch with her mother, wondering what it all means.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora drove home and sat outside in her car for a few minutes before finally taking a breath and getting out. She walked around the back towards the patio door and ran right into Catra and the two apprentices sitting outside.

"Hey, it's the best wife in the world! I'll destroy whoever injured you if you want me to," Catra said, pointing at Adora's arm and the bandage from the blood draw.

"Hey, babe. No need to lay waste, it's alright," Adora said as she walked up and gave her a kiss. She could see Catra was wondering how it had gone but there wasn't a chance she was bringing it up in front of the other two as she sat down next to Catra.

"Good to know," Catra said as Adora sat down next to her. "A good laying waste takes it out of you after all."

“You two are disgustingly cute, anyone ever tell you that?” Mia said.

“Often,” Catra said. “They’re just jealous though.”

Mia snorted as she said, “I’m not jealous. Nauseous perhaps but not jealous.”

“Don’t hate,” Chuck said with a laugh. “I think it’s cute.”

“Sucking up isn’t going to make up for you messing up that heat treat,” Catra laughed.

“I told you, that thermostat is borked,” Chuck said.

“I know it is,” Catra said. “Still going to tease you.”

“Why do I put up with you?” Chuck said as she took a drink of her soda with a grin.

“Because I’m the only boss who lets you sit around on the back patio on a fine spring day,” Catra said.

“Because you wanted a break you mean?” Chuck said.

“No reason work can’t be fun,” Catra said.

“There’s a lot of reasons it can’t be,” Chuck replied.

“Well, I’m about to add one,” Catra said, glancing at Adora for a moment. “Time to go back to work. Chuck, you think you can get that thermostat out?”

“Maybe,” Chuck said with a shrug.

“Mia, give her a hand, would you?” Catra said.

“Oh, I guess,” Mia replied with a grin. “Come on, it’s obvious the boss wants some alone time.”

“I do not know what you are referring to,” Catra said with a fake affronted dignity.

The two apprentices laughed and walked back around the building. When they were out of sight, Adora let out a sigh she’d been holding in and sprawled backwards.

“Figured you had something to say,” Catra said as she squeezed Adora’s leg. “You always have that look like you’ve got a rod down your shirt when you’re trying to keep up appearances.”

“I ran into Mom,” Adora said.

Catra was silent for a moment before she said, “Are you alright?”

“Yeah, we actually went and had lunch. It was… it was weirdly not bad,” Adora said, a bit surprised.

“How so?” Catra asked.

“It was awkward, it was uncomfortable, but we just, I don’t know, talked? I told her a little bit about what I do and she talked about a food bank she started, and then it kind of ended,” Adora said as she picked up Catra’s hand and absentmindedly ran her thumb over the top of it.

“So you’re alright?” Catra said.

“No,” Adora said after a pause. “It’s just so weird. I was expecting a fight and then nothing happened. I mean, I should be happy about that, right?”

“Well, yeah,” Catra said, giving her a nudge. “But you’re always looking for the worst case so I’m not surprised that you’re all freaked out that it didn’t work out.”

“I am not always looking for the worst case,” Adora said with a laugh.

“Do I need to rehash all the worries you had over your dissertation?” Catra replied.

“Those were legit,” Adora said. “And I needed to do that to iron out any potential problems.”

“Yeah, OK, whatever you say,” Catra said with a smirk before going on. “So what about the doctor?”

“They did a blood draw, talked a bit out what to expect, and then let me go,” Adora said.

“So you don’t really know anything more,” Catra said.

“No, I don’t really know anything more,” Adora said.

“You going to be OK?” Catra said.

“I’m going to be OK,” Adora said. “It’s weird but I guess that’s how it goes.”

“It really isn’t,” Catra said. “Or at least it shouldn’t be. She should have apologized.”

“She’s sick,” Adora said and immediately felt weird for defending Sharon.

“She is and she has cancer,” Catra responded.

“That’s not funny,” Adora said, snapping a little, before letting out a sigh. “Sorry, that was out of line.”

“No, it’s alright,” Catra said. “It’s your Mom, you probably have some mixed up feelings about the whole thing.”

“You think?” Adora said with a shake of her head. “Can I ask you something?”

“You know you always can,” Catra said.

“You never talk about your parents,” Adora said. “Do you ever think about contacting them?”

Catra sat still for a moment before giving a feigned shrug of indifference.

“Sometimes. Then the carbon monoxide detector in the shop goes off and I rush to get fresh air.”

Adora gave her a little push as she said, “I’m serious.”

Catra looked at the round burn scars on her arm, scars she never talked about, as she quietly said, “Yeah, I sometimes do but I get over that real quick.”

Adora carefully set her hand over the scars as she said, “Sorry. Didn’t mean to stir that up.”

“It’s alright,” Catra said as she continued to look down. “In my head, I meet them, I let them have it, they weep and ask for my forgiveness and I laugh in their face. They offer me money. They offer to be good and talk about how they’ve changed. They’re desperate to be in my life and I walk away cackling in delight.”

“And you don’t want to meet them because you think they won’t do that,” Adora said.

“No, I don’t want to meet them because what if they do that and I say yes?” Catra said, her voice quiet. “What if I cave?”

“What if they’ve really changed?” Adora said, thinking of her mother and what she thought she’d seen in her earlier.

“What good would it do me?” Catra said, looking back up. “I haven’t seen them since I was a little kid. What connection would we have? What kind of relationship? They’re not my parents, except as some kind of genetic thing. I know I’d only be doing that to reach out for something that I could never have.”

Adora hugged her tight as she said, “I get it. If you ever change your mind, I’m there for you.”

“And I’m here for you,” Catra said. “It’s not the same thing with you and Sharon. She at least raised you.”

Adora snorted as she sat back and wiped a little at her eyes as she said, “I guess.”

“Hey, you’re the best thing she’s ever done,” Catra said, squeezing Adora’s hand. “If you want to try this relationship, then try. And the first time she does you dirty, I’ve got a spot right back there by the fence I’ll plant her in.”

Adora sighed as she rolled her eyes as she said, "You are not burying my Mom there. Or anyone for that matter. Stop with that."

"Hey, it's my designated murder corner," Catra said. "Why do you think I wanted this place?"

Adora poked her gently as she said, "You do not have a designated murder corner, stop it. Listen, if you need to go back to work, go ahead. I'm going to sit back here for a bit and then get some work done myself."

"You sure?" Catra said.

"Yeah, I'm sure," Adora replied.

"Alright," Catra said as she leaned in and kissed Adora. "Don't forget, Kaitlyn is coming over tonight. You said you'd cook."

"I haven't forgot," Adora replied. "I'll get the chicken in the oven soon. Chuck and Mia staying?"

"Sounds good," Catra said. "And I don't know. We got enough?"

"More than enough," Adora said.

"I'll let you know," Catra said as she gave Adora one last kiss and went around the corner to the shop.

Adora sat back as she let out a long sigh. She wasn't sure what she planned with her mother but she played every second of the encounter back in her head as she analyzed every bit over and over and over. After a little bit of that, she stood up and went into the house. She settled down in her office, Finn following her and snuggling up into one of their pillows that Adora had on a lower shelf.

She booted up her computer and started going over the material she required for her upcoming Intro to Philosophy course she was teaching over the summer. She tapped her finger, wondering if she was going to keep *Sophie's World* by Jostein Gaarder as reading or if she should shift to something else. She'd had at least one other professor give her grief for using the book but she thought it was a bit more accessible, especially for a 1000 level intro course that most of the students were taking just to fulfill a Humanities credit.

Adora's eyes drifted over one of the first weeks in the syllabus, where she covered religion and its relation to philosophy, and immediately she was thinking of her mother again. She sighed as she shook her head. For a moment she wondered why she wasn't more freaked out by the whole thing and quickly thought of the feeling she'd had when she'd seen Sharon at graduation. How she'd felt a small piece of herself that had never stopped loving her, no matter how terrible everything had been.

When Adora had been younger, a few years into college, she'd had a chance to talk with a lot of people who lived in the dorms. Some of them had terrible stories of physical abuse, like Catra, and Adora had counted herself lucky she didn't have any marks. Her mother had almost never hit her and when she had, it'd been a spanking when she'd been younger, nothing that would have raised eyebrows.

Then she'd come to realize, after thinking and talking with therapists and close friends, that she did have marks. They were all over her psyche, just as obvious as the marks on Catra's arm to those who understood and she'd carry them for the rest of her life, just like a physical scar. She didn't like to make people unhappy, she had to fight to keep from always trying to please people, and make herself small for others. She didn't flinch away from confrontation anymore but she sure didn't seek it out either. Someone raising their voice too loudly was enough to set her heart thudding and, depending on the day, could make her withdraw for the rest of it.

To top it off, it affected how she acted as well. She had to watch her every interaction with people or she had a tendency to be passive aggressive. She'd read intentions into people's words and actions that weren't there. She'd had to learn to actually voice her problems instead of assuming others should just know. These things had come close to destroying her relationship with not only Catra but other friends as well.

All of that and one awkward lunch where Sharon didn't immediately belittle her or yell at her and Adora was ready to maybe forgive her or at least tolerate her. She actually found herself thinking about inviting her over for dinner some evening

and in that she spotted the little girl in her desperately trying to get mommy's approval and fill the empty spot in her soul.

Adora ground the heels of her hands into her eyes for a moment, the sting giving her something to focus on that wasn't the spiral of thoughts, and she let out a long sigh. She thought of Catra's words only a little bit ago, about what kind of relationship would she have with the people who'd been her parents, and Adora realized the same probably applied to her. No matter how much that little girl in her screamed for what she wanted, Adora had a feeling that it would never happen. Barring a miracle, something Adora didn't really believe in anymore, she knew too much sat out there between the two of them.

Adora stared at the screen on her computer for a moment before she noticed the clock. She shut her computer down, leaving the door open so Finn could get out if they decided to stop lounging around. Into the kitchen she went and began to get things out to make the chicken. She'd never been a good cook but she and Catra had spent cheerful evenings in the kitchen learning together over the years, burning some things, undercooking others, but still spending time together and laughing at each setback. She still wasn't a great cook but she was what she called a serviceable cook and it was a great way to get out of her head she found.

She assembled the things she needed, twine to tie up the chicken, seasonings, butter, the boxes of pasta salad for sides, some potatoes, onions and carrots to cook with the chicken, and some fresh veggies for a salad. She slipped into the immediate moment of preparing the meal and she found herself humming a little as she rinsed the chicken and patted it dry.

Adora had got the chicken prepped, in a roasting pan with the vegetables, and into the oven and was cutting up veggies for the salad when Kaitlyn stuck her head in the sliding door that went back to the patio, her purple hair obscuring her face for a moment until she flipped it out of the way.

"Hello!?"

"Hello, right back," Adora said and Kaitlyn saw her in the kitchen. She came in and Adora saw someone coming in behind her.

"Uh, I hope it's alright but I brought someone along," Kaitlyn said, gesturing to the tall lanky women dressed in layers of baggy clothes and wearing ballet slippers. "This is Adora; I've talked about her. Adora, this is Peki."

Adora started to wave and then realized doing that with an eight inch chef knife in her hand might be seen as a bit aggressive and set it down before waving.

"You're more than welcome here, Peki. Adora, she/her, have a seat wherever."

Peki nodded as she quietly said, "I'm she/they."

Adora immediately loved her voice, a deep and rich voice that filled the room even when Peki was talking quietly. Adora said,

“Are you hungry? Want a little snacky-snack to hold you over until everything is ready?”

“No, thank you,” Peki responded as she sat down on the couch.

“I’m not shy,” Kaitlyn said as she walked into the kitchen area and snagged a few baby carrots from the salad prep before going to sit down next to Peki.

Adora chatted with the two, Peki slowly opening up as Adora finished up the salad and stuck it in the old industrial refrigerator that chugged along in the kitchen and started up the water for the pasta salad on the stove. Shortly after that, she had the pasta cooked and drained, everything mixed up and in the refrigerator alongside the salad and she moved into the living room to sit with Kaitlyn and Peki.

“So how do you two know each other?” Adora asked.

“I met them at the call center,” Kaitlyn, referring to where she worked. “We just started dating.”

“Congrats!” Adora said with a smile.

“She’s told me some stories about you,” Peki said, giving Kaitlyn a little smile.

“I bet,” Adora said, shaking her head with a rueful smile. “She’s been around for some, um, let’s say interesting moments in my life.”

“Like you telling a bunch of cops to fuck off?” Kaitlyn said with a laugh.

“OK, first off, I didn’t say anything like that,” Adora said. “I just told them they weren’t coming in without a warrant.”

Peki lit up with a huge grin as she said, “You did not!”

“She did!” Kaitlyn said. “Swear to God!”

“You make it sound so, I don’t know, heroic,” Adora said. “I was scared out of my mind that night.”

“Well, I want to be you when I grow up, just saying,” Kaitlyn said with a laugh.

“I think you’re pretty cool the way you are now,” Peki said with a sly smile at Kaitlyn, who immediately blushed.

A few minutes later, Catra came in with Mia and Chuck, all of them smelling like the orange soap that Catra had at the shop sink. Everyone got introduced around and Adora took the opportunity to check on the chicken. As she was doing that, Bow and Glimmer came in the door from the patio, tabouli and some dumplings in their arms, to more greetings and introductions. Adora looked at the chicken in the oven, looked at her living room full of people and just gave a little nod as she did some quick thinking.

After a little bit longer, Adora got the chicken out, let it rest, and then shredded it all into a bowl. She put everything out on the table, along with some tortillas they had sitting around, and declared dinner ready as she opened a couple of bottles of wine and set out a pitcher of ice water and some cold cans of soda.

"Look at you, feeding the masses with a few loaves and fishes," Kaitlyn said as she nudged Adora with her elbow.

"Do I look like the Messiah?" Adora said with a laugh.

"You certainly saved me," Catra said as she gave Adora a kiss on the cheek as she passed with her plate on the way to one of the seats in the living room. Adora gave a soft smile at that as she finished her plate and followed Catra.

The rest of the evening was spent laughing and talking. When the eating was done, everyone pitched in to clean up, and then drifted out to the patio where the talking continued for a little while longer before people started making their way home. Late in the

evening, Catra and Adora cuddled up together in bed as Adora let out a long sigh of contentment, happy with where she was and without a thought of what had just happened earlier that day or what it might mean for the future.

Chapter End Notes

Snacky-snack is a phrase stolen directly from my wife, who honestly reminds me a bit of Adora. They're both self-sacrificing to a fault. In fact, when we watched the fifth season and Mara says that line about being worth more than just what you can offer to others, I was staring holes into her because that describes her so well. I love her immensely.

Thank you as always for reading!

Chapter Six

Chapter Summary

Adora has an idea that she follows through on even after a surprise visitor shows up.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next two days were quiet. Catra worked and Adora went up to the college to start getting ready for the summer semester that would be starting soon. Colleagues congratulated her when they saw her and she even got her own office finally. One that was only about a hundred square feet but it had room for a desk, a few guest chairs, and a bookshelf so she couldn't complain, especially when her former working area had been half a cubicle in a cramped room with a bunch of others.

She had just settled down in the office and was putting off some boring administrative task she needed to do when she got a message in her email from her mother. She stared at it for a long moment before opening it.

I just wanted to thank you for lunch the other day. It was enjoyable to catch up with you.

Adora snorted at the phrasing of catching up, as if the two of them just hadn't seen each other in a couple of weeks.

I'd like to make that a regular thing. Let me know, by email or by phone, when you are available again.

The end had Sharon's name, her phone number, and a verse of Exodus 20:3. For a split second, recognizing the chapter as the Ten Commandments, Adora was sure that it was the honor your father and mother verse but then she realized that was further down in that chapter.

"Thou shalt have no other gods before me?" Adora muttered as she remembered the verse. "Why would she send that?"

After a few moments of wondering, she gave a little grunt as she realized she was wasting her time trying to figure it out. Either it was directed at Adora and trying to figure it out just bought into whatever passive-aggressive thing her mother was trying to do or it was just a generic email signature and then it had nothing to do with her. Either way, it didn't matter.

Adora marked the message as read and went on with her work. After a little bit of time though, she found she couldn't get the idea of having lunch with Sharon out of her head. The email was right, sort of. It hadn't necessarily been what Adora would call enjoyable but it hadn't been awful. She picked up her phone and tapped out the number. She sat there staring at the Call button, wondering why she was even considering making the call. Then she hit the button. After a few rings, she heard her mother's voice on the other end.

“Hello, this is Sharon,” she said.

“Uh, yeah, hey, Mom, it’s me,” Adora said, feeling like an awkward child. She then immediately kicked herself for calling her Mom.

“Hello, Adora,” Sharon said. Adora could hear some people in the background, although the noise was fading and then cut out as Adora heard a door close. “I’m volunteering at the moment, can I help you?”

Adora found herself gritting her teeth at the nonchalant manner that Sharon was putting out. She’d made the call after all and she’d expected a bit more cheer, or at least interest.

“I saw your email. I had a few minutes to spare in my schedule so thought I’d call and set up our next lunch,” Adora said, finding herself slipping into the same nonchalant manner of speaking. “I hope you don’t mind if I pick the place.”

“Not at all,” Sharon replied. Adora told herself she sounded pleased but it was hard to say.

“I was thinking a place called Fengs,” Adora replied. “It’s a great little Chinese place on Clark Boulevard. I’m available today if you are.”

“Adora, you should give more notice before setting up things like this,” Sharon said and Adora was about to snap at her when she went on. “I understand though. I’ll see you there at noon.”

Adora was about to say Sharon should ask if she was available at noon but the point of the whole thing was to be civil. Adora checked the clock and nodded.

“I’ll be there.”

The call ended a few seconds later and Adora tried to concentrate on what she was doing. After about an hour, she knew that wasn’t working and she put her head on her desk with a groan.

“Is it really all *that* bad?” a voice said from the doorway.

Adora’s head snapped up as she recognized the voice and saw Mista standing in the doorway.

“Mista!?”

“Who else would it be?” Mista said as she walked in and tossed an old green duffel bag on the ground behind one of the chairs

Adora came around the desk and met her in a hug as she said, “But I thought you were in the Lesser Anteriors?”

Mista hugged her back before saying, “Seriously? A doctorate and you don’t know it's the Lesser Antilles?”

Adora gave her a little push as they both grinned at each other as Adora said, “Fine, Antilles and that still doesn’t answer why you’re here!?”

“Because I wanted to come and congratulate my friend,” Mista said as she flopped down into one of the two chairs in front of Adora’s desk. “We got into Saint Vincent early, I had some frequent flier miles, and figured I’d drop in.”

Adora sat down on the edge of her desk as she said, “You say that like it’s just no big deal.”

Mista shrugged as she said, “Meh. I got caught up on my reading on the way.”

“Still reading those horrendously bad mystery novels?” Adora said.

“They’re not horrendously bad and I’m actually writing them now. Not published yet but I’m not really pushing hard either,” Mista

said. “Lots of long quiet time when you’re at sea and that helps fill it.”

“I bet,” Adora said. “So where's Sea Hawk?”

“Still in Saint Vincent,” Mista said and then stopped for a minute. “No, I take that back. He should be on his way to the Caymans by now. He had a chance to crew a ship and took it. I’ll probably meet him either at Lower Matcumbe Key or Biloxi, depending.”

Adora was smiling as she shook her head.

“I swear, you live the most romantic life out of all of us from the old days,” Adora said.

“The old days? It was like a few years ago. I don’t think we’re old enough to be calling it the old days,” Mista replied. “Besides, we’re just sea bums. The rest of you own property, got degrees, did all that stuff.”

Adora asked, “So you regret it?”

Mista remembered climbing on the back of an old scooter one cold winter morning with nothing but what she had in a duffel bag as she shook her head.

“Not one damn bit.”

“Well I’m glad you came by. I wish you could have been here last Friday. We had a great time,” Adora said.

“I do too,” Mista said. “I’ll catch up with everyone as I can while I’m here though.”

“So what else brings you here?” Adora said.

Mista shook her head as she said, “Not a goddamn thing. I don’t miss this state one bit. In fact, I feel a bit twitchy being so far from the ocean. Get that look off your face, I miss you all but you’re not this state.”

“OK, that’s fair,” Adora said. “You never did say why you just kind of up and left.”

“And I’m still not going to,” Mista replied. “So why does the newly minted doctor have her head on her desk?”

“Remember my Mom?” Adora replied.

“I remember threatening her,” Mista said.

Adora suddenly remembered that Mista had in fact met Sharon in the one moment she'd come to Camp Bright Moon to try and get Adora to come back to her house. It was the same day she told Adora she was dead to her.

"Oh, gotcha, yeah," Adora said as she picked up a tavern puzzle that Catra had made her. It was two small horseshoes joined together by a bit of chain with a metal heart in the middle. She started fiddling with it, the object being to separate the heart from the rest of the puzzle, to keep her hands busy as she grimaced. "So, she, um, she showed up at my graduation."

"And you need a good alibi?" Mista said.

Adora shook her head as she said, "She's dying and needs my help."

Mista's response was immediate.

"Let her die."

"Mista!" Adora said.

"What? She hasn't talked to you in years as far as I know. Screw her," Mista said. "Bet she came on all nice and sweet too didn't

she?”

“Well, yeah,” Adora said. “We had lunch together as well on Monday. It wasn’t awful. In fact, we’re supposed to have lunch again here in a little bit.”

Mista reached out and took the puzzle from Adora’s hand as she said, “Listen, I think this is a stupid idea. I know I just got here and everything but people shouldn’t expect things from you, even your attention, if they can’t do the same in return. And she’s asking for what? Money?”

“Bone marrow donation,” Adora said.

Mista nodded as she handed Adora back the heart separated from the toy.

“Of course. Because you were dead to her when she didn’t need anything from you but now that she needs you, you’re her kid and she just wants it to be water under the bridge,” Mista said.

Adora noticed the bitterness in Mista’s voice as Adora said, “I’m not going to just let her die.”

“You think she’s going to apologize? You think she’s going to do something to recover all the lost time? She won’t,” Mista said.

Adora shook her head, starting to feel angry, as she said, "You don't know that."

"Yes, I do," Mista said. "Both of my parents are like that."

The pure anger that seethed out of Mista as she said it caught Adora by surprise and tempered her own anger a little.

"I… I didn't know," Adora said.

"I know you didn't," Mista said as she looked down at the two small horseshoes in her hand. She fought a little battle within herself for a split second before she went on. "I never talked about my home life at camp. That was my escape and I didn't want it there as well. Not going to go into detail so I'm just going to say, both my parents are fucking trash, both of them have done the bullshit I just said, multiple times, and that's what she's doing to you. Don't be a sucker."

"Even if she is, I can't live with myself if I could have done something and didn't and she dies," Adora said. "It's not about her. It's about my own consciousness. I don't know. I'm not religious like I used to be but I still believe in love your enemies."

Mista rolled her eyes even as she grinned a little.

“You know, I think you’ve changed so much and then you say that,” she said. “It’s alright, it just means you’re a good person, I guess. Me, well, I know what I’d do and I’d laugh the whole time.”

“I don’t think you would,” Adora said as she reached down and took the horseshoes out of Mista’s hand and reattached the heart.

“Well, I haven’t talked with either of the genetic donors that call themselves my parents in some time, and have no plans to do so, so I guess I’ll probably never know,” Mista said.

Adora set the toy back on her desk as she said, “Do you want to come by the house tonight, have dinner? It’s really different from the last time you were there.”

Mista nodded as she said, “I remember that. You two were sleeping in some converted office and the place was a mess. Yeah, I’ll come over. I’ll even make dinner.”

“You don’t have to do that,” Adora said.

“I don’t mind,” Mista said. “Just got to find a decent seafood market in this town first.”

“Best of luck,” Adora snorted. “Total Groceries is probably your best bet.”

“I’m not give the fucker who owns that place money,” Mista said as she stood up. “I’ll find something.”

Adora stood up off the desk herself and reached forward to hug Mista.

“Sorry for dumping my opinion on you,” Mista said. “I just had to tell you.”

“It’s alright,” Adora said. “You always had a way of putting things. I don’t agree with you but that’s fine.”

“Ah, look at you, disagreeing with me,” Mista replied before she stepped back and got serious. “Doctor Adora Manzana, you really did it. I’m proud of you.”

Adora found her eyes getting a little damp as she smiled and said, “Thanks. I’ll tell you the same thing I said to others on Friday. I couldn’t have done it without your help.”

Mista gave Adora a little push as she grinned, the serious moment gone, as she said, “Bullshit, I just give you grief and dump you in the river from time to time. You’re a hell of a person.”

"That does remind me, come up to Bright Moon sometime. We'll go… canoeing," Adora said with what she thought was a wicked grin but just looked goofy on her.

Mista started laughing as she said, "Yeah, you can't pull that look off and I promise you I know more about boats and water than you *ever* will. Maybe pick a revenge that's not in my element."

"We shall see," Adora said before hugging her one last time. "See you tonight."

What Mista said was on Adora's mind as she drove from the college over to Fengs. It was a little place that had moved into an old chain pizza place that Adora and Catra had found one night when they'd been driving around arguing about where to go eat. They'd been worn down and agreed to just go to Fengs, a place they'd never been, because it was there and they'd found they loved it.

Adora got there about five minutes before noon to find that Sharon was just getting out of her car. Adora let out a sigh of relief as she remembered Sharon always berating her on how she should be fifteen minutes early and if she wasn't, she was late. Adora parked her little car and met Sharon at the door to the restaurant. As they went in, Sharon looked around and Adora could almost see it through her eyes. It was kind of run down, the fixtures, tables, and chairs a bit worn. There was a fish tank in the tiny lobby that was currently empty and in need of a scrub. Adora waited for a backhanded critique that never came though as they were seated and the server took their drink order.

“Interesting,” Sharon said at the two menus that were set in front of her, one with a small paper A taped to the front and the other blank.

Adora picked up one of hers, with the A on it, and began to look through it.

“The A is for American,” Adora said quietly. “The other is written half in Cantonese but does have some fantastic stuff they don’t have on the A menu.”

“Thank you,” Sharon said as she picked up the one labeled A.

Adora tried to think of something to say and finally said, “You said you were volunteering when I called. Was it Helping Heart?”

“No, it was at a nonprofit thrift store,” Sharon said. “It’s to support a ministry.”

They looked over the menu in silence for a few minutes before the server came back. They both ordered and when the server went away, silence hung over the table like a shroud. Adora, not for the first time that day, was irritated at herself for putting herself in the situation. After the silence had gone on just long enough to be awkward, Adora said, “Which ministry?”

“I’m sorry?” Sharon said.

“I didn’t know you knew that word,” was what Adora wanted to say. What she did say though was, “The ministry at the thrift shop. Which one is it?”

“A drug rehabilitation ministry,” Sharon said as she took a sip of her water.

Adora just nodded as she tried to think of something else to say and hit on, “So, you said the other day you’ve kept busy and of course mentioned the food bank. What else have you been up to?”

Sharon looked at her over the rim of her large glasses as she said, “Now, I think that’s a question I could ask of you as well.”

Adora could feel the accusation in the statement but she just gave a thin smile as she did what a therapist had told her and took the statement at face value.

“School, mostly. I knew even before I really got started that I was going to go into some kind of religious studies,” Adora said and felt her gut tighten as she knew she was venturing into treacherous waters with that statement. “It took me until almost my junior year to figure out what form that would take and then I’ve been working at that ever since.”

Sharon looked at Adora and Adora thought she could feel the judgment coming back at her but she just waited and reminded herself that she couldn't read minds.

"Sounds like a lot of work," Sharon replied. "I hope you did at least have time for something fun."

Adora once again felt like she'd stepped, expecting a step and not finding one. The fun thing was particularly weird as Adora had grown up doing things that were useful, like volunteering at the church and such, but simply doing something fun hadn't been a priority her mother had for Adora.

"Uh, yeah," Adora said after a moment. "Catra and I went to Colorado for a bit over a week a few years back. Knocked around Gunnison and Crested Butte, did some hiking, stuff like that."

"Sounds delightful," Sharon said. "I'm not sure I ever told you but your father and I went to Colorado Springs when we were first married and spent a week there ourselves. Had a delightful time. We'd honeymooned at Lake Quinault Lodge in Olympic National Forest and went to Colorado the year after because he loved the mountains and hiking."

Adora blinked in both surprise and shock. Her mother hadn't talked much about Adora's father when she'd been growing up. She knew shortly after she'd been born that he'd died in an accident at his job. Adora knew that between life insurance and a

settlement from the accident it had allowed Sharon, with careful funds management, to not really have to work for money. Adora didn't really know anything about the accident beyond some vague industrial thing and didn't know much about her father either beyond his name and a few facts. She definitely didn't know that he'd loved the mountains and hiking or where they had gone on their honeymoon.

"What did you do there?" Adora said, leaning forward.

"Oh, we went to a chuck wagon dinner and show. Toured the Air Force Academy grounds and went up Pikes Peak. Did some hiking in Garden of the Gods. Things like that," Sharon said with a little dismissive wave of her hand.

Adora was about to speak when the food arrived at the table. They both thanked the server and Adora remembered this time to wait until Sharon had prayed. Then she got a loop thrown at her.

"Would you bless this?" Sharon said.

Adora froze for a second as she tried to think of a prayer and the only one that came to mind was one she'd read when she'd been researching religious rituals around meal times for a paper in one of her masters degree classes. She quickly bowed her head and said, "Bless us, O Lord, and these Thy gifts, which we are about to receive from Thy bounty, through Christ our Lord. Amen."

Sharon said Amen and when Adora looked back up, she was getting a bit of an odd look from her mother. Adora didn't say anything as she picked up the chopsticks and started eating the sesame chicken she'd ordered. Silence again settled over the table. After about a minute, Sharon said, "That's an interesting prayer. Roman Catholic isn't it?"

Adora nodded as she said, "Yes, it's in the Catechism."

"You're Catholic now?" Sharon said, her tone mild.

Adore knew that tone for the trap that it was and felt her heart rate speed up.

"No," she said, plainly and as non-committal as she could manage. Again, silence fell between them both. After a short moment where they both took a moment to eat, Sharon spoke up again.

"Where are you going to church then?"

And there it was and Adora kicked herself for falling into complacency. It was asked very matter of factly, as if it was just casual conversation but Adora was reminded that there was no such thing with her mother. Everything was rife with meaning. She almost lied right then and there but she knew this was going to come up eventually.

“I’m not,” Adora said.

“How can you have a doctorate in religion and not go to church?” Sharon asked, as if confused.

Adora almost answered, “Because I’ve studied it enough to know what kind of tripe is being served up at pretty much every church within driving distance.”

She held back though and simply said, “It’s not something I do.”

Sharon was shaking her head as she took a moment to eat some noodles. Adora recognized the tactic, making her wait for Sharon’s response and felt her anger rising.

“You need to find yourself a church home,” Sharon said, looking Adora in the eyes. “I understand you think you know everything because of studies but you need a place where you can receive ministry.”

Adora picked up a piece of chicken and ate to keep herself from immediately snapping out something. She wasn’t sure why she held back until she realized that she wanted that relationship with her mother and she’d hoped, without even fully realizing, that this might be the start of that. It was something she thought she’d long ago let go of but she could feel that urge inside her to have a mother again, even if it was the one sitting across the table from her.

“I understand what you’re saying,” Adora said. “It’s not something I’m likely to take up again though.”

Sharon shook her head as she said, “Is it because of your living situation? You know there are several churches that are for people like you.”

Adora’s hand hit the table with a thump that rattled the dishes and silverware.

“Excuse me?” Adora said, her voice low as she fought to keep her temper in check, ignoring the several tables who glanced her way. “People like me?”

“Really, Adora?” Sharon said with a little shake of her head. “I didn’t say anything objectionable. I’d think you wouldn’t be so thin skinned.”

“I seem to remember that people like me was something you objected to,” Adora said, keeping her voice in check even though she wanted to scream it in Sharon’s face.

“And I still do but I love you,” Sharon said. “I do not approve of your sin but I still love you.”

For a split second, Adora remembered standing in the woods years before, telling Bow pretty much the same thing when she had found out he was trans. She could still hear Bow's response and it gave her the response she needed.

"I am not a sin," Adora said as she stared into Sharon's eyes. "If you do not approve of the so-called sin, then you do not approve of me."

"So melodramatic, you know exactly what I mean. I don't think you yourself are a sin," Sharon said as she brought some more noodles to her mouth.

"You think the core of my being is a sin," Adora replied. "That's me. That's who I am."

Sharon shook her head as she said, "That's nonsense. You dated that one boy at camp. Kyle I believe you said his name was, so obviously this predilection you have isn't some immutable core of your being."

Adora flipped between shocked, angry, and settled on angrily amused as she said, "Kyle is queer, Mom. He was the safe option for me."

Sharon blinked once, which Adora knew meant she had caught her off guard, before going forward as she said, "I'd say the same about him as well then."

“Is this why you wanted to see me?” Adora said. “You thought I just needed some good churchin’ and I’d be good ol’ hetero Adora again?”

Sharon frowned at Adora’s response as she said, “I wanted to see my daughter and may I remind you that you called me to have lunch.”

“I guess we’re having this talk then,” Adora said. “Do you or do you not accept me for who I am?”

“Of course I accept you, what a ridiculous question, you’re my daughter,” Sharon said. Adora didn’t relax though because she could hear the rest coming. “I just don’t accept your lifestyle.”

Adora looked down at her half eaten dish, her appetite gone. She wanted to scream, she wanted to throw dishes, and curse and make a scene so that her mother would understand, so that her mother would change her mind and love her. She wanted to say, “It’s not a lifestyle, Mom, that’s me,” but she could hear it in the same tones that a teenager might say, “It’s not a phase, *Mom!”* and knew it would be dismissed in the same way.

Adora pushed her plate away from her, shoved the chopsticks straight up into the rice bowl without thinking, and folded her hands on the table. She didn’t realize it was the exact same thing her mother had done any time she wanted to show just how

disappointed she was with Adora for something when she was growing up.

"I do not accept that," Adora said, her voice slipping into a precise and measured tone she used when discussing something with a particularly annoying student, as she looked right into her mother's eyes. "It is not as if I have decided to go out dancing too much or drive fast cars. It is who I am. I did not date Kyle because I was attracted to him, but because it was a way to try and be normal. I was wrong in that though. I already am normal and I expect you to accept that."

"Do you really think this is going to last, Adora?" Sharon said, her voice gentle and soft. "How can you feel like this has any kind of stability? I don't want you to be hurt."

Adora gave a pained smile as she said, "You don't want me to be hurt. How kind of you."

"I do not appreciate that tone," Sharon said as she set her fork down.

"What tone is right for me talking to you when you're telling me you don't accept me? Although I will say it's better this time because at least you didn't use a slur like last time," Adora said.

"I did no such thing," Sharon said. "I do not appreciate you doing this in public either."

“Although, you questioned my wife’s loyalty to me or maybe mine to her,” Adora said, just skipping over Sharon’s denial. “I think I’d prefer you have called me a slur.”

She was surprised at how calm she felt at the moment as Sharon replied to her.

“We can talk about this in private if you wish but we are not doing this here,” Sharon said. “Now eat your lunch and we will speak of something else.”

Adora’s hand reached for her chopsticks before she gave a little humorless chuckle to herself at how, even after all the years away, she still had that instinct to just do what was told to her by her mother.

“No, I think I’m done with my lunch,” Adora said as she stood up, relishing the surprise on Sharon’s face. “Thank you for coming.”

Adora was never happier to have been carrying cash on her for once as she took some out of her wallet and handed it to the server.

“Everything was great,” Adora said as she gave the server two twenties. “Keep the change.”

She knew she'd probably just tipped a ridiculous amount but she didn't want to wait around for the change and figured the cost was worth it to get out of the situation. She didn't see Sharon scrambling for her purse as she went out the door and was already at her car reaching for the door when Sharon called out to her.

"Adora! What are you doing!?"

Adora stood looking at the roof of her car. For a split second, looking at some dust on the roof, she thought about how it needed to get washed before she frowned a little and turned.

"I'm leaving. This was a mistake," Adora replied.

"We should really sit down and talk about this," Sharon said. "It seems you're still hung up on it."

Adora laughed, the sound like winter in the warm summer air, as she said, "I guess I am but we're not going to talk about this. There's nothing to talk about. Either you accept this or you don't."

"It's not that simple," Sharon said.

"It really is," Adora said and she suddenly fought back a lump in her throat. "All you need to do is just love me as I am, as I have

always been, but no, you have to have conditions on that I guess."

Sharon stepped up and set a hand on Adora's arm as she said, "Oh, honey, I've always loved you." For a moment, Adora almost hugged her, to hear that come out of her mouth, and then Sharon went on. "I do this because I love you and I worry about your soul."

Adora looked at her mother for a moment before gently pulling her arm away.

"I don't think this is going to work," Adora said. "I'm still going to donate if there's a match but I think this is done. I'm sorry for getting your hopes up."

Adora opened the door to her car and sat down as Sharon said, "You're really going to turn your back on your own mother?"

"You did it first, Mom," Adora said before shutting the car door.

Chapter End Notes

> Shout out to Fengs, a restaurant based on a real one that I frequent often. It's fantastic, it does have menus like that, and I have had some amazing meals out of both of them. I remember going in there once to pick up a big thing of West Lake Soup when I had a really bad head cold. The guy at the register took one look at me, said hold on, and came back with a little container full of some red liquid. Told me it was

spicy vinegar and to put it in the soup, it'd clear up my head. He wasn't joking. The soup made me feel better and that vinegar was just the right kind of hot. Got me going with a good sweat and then drained my sinuses, as promised.

As always, thank you for reading!

Chapter Seven

Chapter Summary

Adora deals with the fallout of lunch.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora drove down the street a little bit and parked in the parking lot next to a defunct buffet. She leaned her head against the steering wheel and screamed at the top of her lungs for a moment before the tears came. She spent a few minutes crying in the car before she took a deep breath.

"Suck it up, Adora," she muttered to herself. "You knew this was going to happen, you've just been lying to yourself."

She avoided her eyes in the rearview mirror as she took a few more deep breaths as several more tears tracked across her face before she drove off. As she drove, she realized she wasn't going back to her office but had taken the turn that would eventually take her to her home. She thought about that as she drove, knowing she could still take a highway that was up ahead and go back to work. After a little thought she took a moment at a stop light to text her department head to let her know that Adora planned to work from home for the rest of the afternoon.

She heard the phone vibrate a few minutes later but didn't give it any attention as she drove, focusing on the traffic and driving to

keep herself distracted. When that didn't work, she concentrated on counting in the ancient Greek she knew and then switched over to Hebrew. The exercise helped calm her down a little, although by the time she pulled into her home and parked she felt wiped out. She set her head against her wheel, reached up, and turned the car off and then let her hand drop, feeling the keys hit her leg before they hit the floor with a jingle.

Adora sat there for long enough that it started to get uncomfortable from the sun heating up the car's interior. She thought she'd cry again but she found she just felt blank. She sat up, got her keys, and got out of the car. She heard the sounds of hammers from inside the shop and was about to walk around the building when Catra came out the door, holding a neatly wrapped box.

"Adora? Aren't you supposed to be at work?" Catra said as she sat the box down on the hood of her truck. Then she frowned as she saw Adora's red eyes. "What happened?"

Adora just shook her head as Catra came over and took her hand.

"Don't shake your head at me," Catra said. "What happened?"

"I was stupid," Adora said, her voice bitter.

“Really, Doctor Manzana? I doubt that,” Catra replied, giving Adora’s hand a squeeze. “Tell me about it?”

Adora started to say something before her eyes settled on the box.

“You’re making a delivery, I don’t want to stop you,” Adora said.

“You’re deflecting,” Catra said.

“I know,” Adora said, squeezing Catra’s hand. “I really do have to go and do some work though and you have to make your delivery. I’ll live with it.”

Catra leaned forward and gave her a kiss before squeezing her hand before letting go and going back to grab the package off the hood of the truck. Adora admired the simple brown paper wrapping tied with twine and stamped with Catra’s company name on the side as Catra said, “At least tell me what it’s about?”

Adora almost told her not to worry but finally blurted out, “I went to lunch with Mom.”

Catra had the door to her pickup open and was placing the package on the bench seat when Adora replied.

“And you’ve been crying,” Catra said, her voice even and her eyes furious as she turned around.

“It’s nothing, really,” Adora said as Catra stepped back over to her.

“It’s not nothing,” Catra replied as she put both hands on Adora’s shoulder. “What did she do to you?”

Adora reached up and took Catra’s hands off her shoulders, giving them each a friendly squeeze as she replied, “You just asked what it’s about. I don’t want to get into it right now.”

Catra frowned as she said, “I can put this delivery off.”

Adora shook her head again as she said, “No, don’t do that. You got your reputation.”

“I got my wife,” Catra replied, “and that’s more important.”

“I’ll still be here when you get back,” Adora replied. “I’m fine, really.”

Catra stood and stared and Adora let go of one of her hands to give Catra’s shoulder a gentle push.

“Go on, really,” Adora said, forcing a smile onto her face.

“You’re sure?” Catra said, taking a step back.

“Yes, I already had my little break down in the car on the way home,” Adora said, trying to make a joke out of it.

Catra stepped back forward as she said, “See, that’s not what you say if you want me to think you’re fine.”

“I’m *fine,”* Adora said. “Really. We’ll talk about it tonight, alright?”

“OK,” Catra said as she finally went and got in her truck. “Love you.”

“Love you too,” Adora replied. The truck started up with what sounded like a grumble and Catra backed it up and drove out as Adora walked around to the patio door.

As soon as she was out of sight of Catra, Adora sagged a little. She got on her computer and answered some emails, saw that her boss had responded to her text that it was fine she work from home, lined up a visit with a local rabbi that she’d been meaning to interview, and then, as she was reviewing some of her lecture notes for one of her summer courses, she saw the email from

blessedofgod7 pop up. Adora hit delete and went on with her review.

After several minutes, though, she grumbled as she pulled the email out of the trash. It was short and to the point.

Dear Adora,

I have prayed to the Lord for discernment and meditated on The Word, time and time again. The answer I have received is clear. You have fallen into sin and that is not something that I can accept. I know it is the way of the World to ignore this, to hand wave it away, or to try and give revisionist readings of God's Word to account for it but it is very clear that it is a sin. I will not simply stay silent while you risk your eternal soul. Even if you did not care about yours, surely you would care about this woman you say you love. Do you wish to send her to damnation as well?

I do not wish for us to be parted but I will not simply stand by and watch as you trot down the road to Hell. You are my daughter, grown though you may be, and it is my duty given to me by God as a parent to instruct you. Proverbs 22:6 says that I should instruct you in the way to go and even when you are grown, you will not depart from it. It's obvious I failed at that when you were a child. I will not fail now. You said that I must accept the sin in your life as you say that it is who you are as a person. If we are to have anything together, you must accept that this is who I am. I am a proud child of God, who heeds his Word, and is not ashamed to admit it. I hope you will be the same.

Sincerely,

Sharon Weaver

Matthew 6:13

Adora stared at the screen for a moment, her jaw dropped, before her hand slammed into the top of her desk almost of its own volition. Everything rattled and then she jumped as she felt something furry run across her feet. She turned just in time to see Finn get out the door and head down the hall at top speed.

"Sorry, Finn!" Adora said before she turned back to the computer. She felt like spitting on the monitor and knew she wasn't going to get anything else done that day, at least nothing productive. After a staring contest with her email, she finally shut her computer down. She went into the living room to the reproaching eyes of Finn staring out at her from under a chair.

"It's not your fault," Adora said with a sigh as she knelt down and made little noises at Finn to get them to come back out. Finn's tail swished back and forth as she saw they had no intention of coming out and she sat down on the ground with a grunt. "It's just… I guess you don't know your mom do you? Of course, you're a cat. Are there crappy cat moms? Is that a thing? Like do they reproach you because, I don't know, you didn't lick your fur just perfectly or something or you didn't bring them just the right gift for cat mother's day? Is that a thing? Is that the same as our mother's day?"

Finn kept staring at her and Adora lay down on the ground to stare at the ceiling.

“You got it easy, Finn,” Adora said. “I mean, maybe not. Me slamming things down and scaring you and you don’t know why and I don’t know why I’m saying these things to you because you’re a cat but I want you to hear them anyway.”

After a few minutes, she heard a rustle and saw Finn getting out from under the chair and coming over to sit on her chest. They began purring as they curled up on her and Adora reached up and gently scratched between their ears.

“Thanks,” she whispered as she felt the tension ease a little in the pit of her stomach.

Adora was still on the floor ten minutes later when she heard the door slide open and Mista’s voice say, “Floor time?”

“Floor time,” Adora said as Finn sat up and jumped off Adora before sauntering out of the living room. She looked at Mista and saw some bags in her hand and an old green duffle over her shoulder. “What’s in the bags?”

“Well hello to you too,” Mista said to Finn as they passed her without looking at her. Mista turned back to Adora. “Dinner. You forgot I was coming over, didn’t you?”

“Dang it, yes,” Adora said as she got up off the floor. “Sorry. Let me get ready.”

“Nope,” Mista said as she came in and dropped her duffle on a chair and started towards the kitchen. “You sit down and talk to me. I’m making dinner. I actually found some nice red snapper in this town and I’m not letting you touch it.”

“Sounds interesting,” Adora said as she went into the kitchen and hopped up on the counter.

Mista started unloading veggies while she replied, “Can you believe I actually found scotch bonnet peppers? I remember when people around here thought serrano peppers were exotic. So I guess you’re sprawled out on the floor and you look like the world is ending because your lunch with her went just perfect?”

Adora was about to say not to use too much of the scotch bonnet peppers when she got blindsided by Mista’s question. She didn’t answer at first, trying to think of what to say, and Mista just casually kept unloading stuff and getting things lined up on the counter. She looked briefly at Adora to gauge what her reaction was before turning and pulling a large Mason jar full of rice over.

“Good, you got plenty of rice,” Mista said before looking back at Adora. “Cat got your tongue?”

“No, it didn’t go perfect,” Adora finally said.

Mista shrugged as she pulled the rice cooker over.

"I'd say I told you so but you got to figure that shit out on your own."

"Gee, thanks," Adora said.

"Hey, I told you so," Mista said with a glance over her shoulder and Adora couldn't help but give a little snorting laugh.

"It went OK at first," Adora said.

"It usually does," Mista said.

"Then she… you know what? I don't want to talk about this," Adora said.

Mista nodded as she put the fish in the refrigerator before turning around.

"Then talk to me about something else," Mista replied.

“Like what?” Adora said.

“I’ve been away to sea. Fill me in on the latest from you shore people,” Mista said.

“You make it sound like you just came around the Horn on a sailing ship,” Adora said.

Mista snorted as she said, “No, I didn’t just come around ‘The Horn,’ Adora. We haven’t managed Cape Horn yet. We’re hoping for next year. Seriously though, what’s everyone been up to?”

Adora began to talk with her and tell her about what everyone they knew together had been doing. She felt her phone vibrate, took it out of her pocket, and didn’t recognize the number. She set it on the counter next to her and went on telling her about one of the old counselors, Dela, and the whitewater rafting company she had started in Oregon. As she did, she didn’t notice the voicemail that was left on her phone as she continued to talk.

Chapter End Notes

Not much to say except. Thanks for reading!

Chapter Eight

Chapter Summary

Adora finds out about the voicemail.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

That evening, after dinner, they invited Mista to stay with them while she was in town. They talked and laughed but made an early evening of it. As Adora got into bed, she was getting ready to talk with Catra when she noticed the voicemail on her phone. As Catra got out of the shower and took her hair out of the shower cap, Adora listened to the voicemail.

"Hello, Ms. Manzana. This is Doctor Alsid. I'd like to discuss with you the results of your blood work. Please call me as soon as possible. Thank you."

Adora felt her guts cramp up at the words. Nothing was particularly wrong in the words. It was in how they were said.

"What's wrong?" Catra said as she sat down on the side of the bed next to Adora.

"The doctor called, they want to talk about my bloodwork," Adora said.

“And you think something’s wrong,” Catra said. “What did they say?”

“Nothing. Just that they want to discuss my bloodwork with me. It’s just… it’s just the way the message was left,” Adora said.

“Can I hear it?” Catra said.

Adora nodded and played the message back on speaker. Catra listened quietly before looking back at Adora, who felt her gut clench a little tighter.

“You hear it too,” Adora said.

“Yeah,” Catra said. “Something’s up.”

“Oh, God, what if I’m sick?” Adora said, her heart speeding up.

“Stop,” Catra said, taking her hands. “You get regular check-ups.”

“Yeah, but what if something showed up that hasn’t been caught?” Adora said. “I can’t leave you alone. I’m so sorry if I

leave you alone. I need to make a will. I need to make sure my life insurance is up to date."

"OK, there's the anxiety," Catra said with a soft smile. "Take a deep breath with me."

"Catra…," Adora started to say and Catra shook her head as she took Adora's phone, set it aside, and then took both of Adora's hands and gave them a gentle kiss.

"Deep breath," Catra repeated.

Adora nodded and together they took a deep breath, held it for a count of three, and then let it back out. They repeated it several times before Adora let go of Catra's hands.

"Better?" Catra said.

"Not really," Adora said. "I'm not freaking out as bad I guess."

"Then that's better," Catra replied. "Really, it's probably just some little thing. We're making too much of this."

"Maybe," Adora said.

She still was up until 1am staring at the ceiling. She woke up early, unable to sleep, and sat in her little office at home watching the clock slowly countdown to when the doctor's office opened at 8am. As soon as it was time, she started to dial the number and then stopped. She couldn't bring herself to hit send. A few minutes ticked past before she was finally able to make the phone call. Then it took several minutes to work through the automated system that answered before she finally got the receptionist.

After explaining why she was calling, the receptionist said, "Yes, Ms. Manzana, I do see that Doctor Alsid called. Can you hold please and I'll get him on the line?"

Adora agreed and spent five agonizing minutes waiting before the doctor picked up.

"Hello, Ms. Manzana."

"Hello."

"I called yesterday because there was an issue with your blood work. Unfortunately, you are not a match to be a donor for Ms. Weaver."

Adora sat and stared at the wall with her diplomas on it. They were proof that she had sat and thought of hard and difficult

questions about the meaning of life and what it meant to be human. In that moment, as Adora tried to make some sense of what she was hearing, they seemed less than worthless.

"Are… are you sure?"

"Yes, Ms. Manazna," Doctor Alsid said. "We checked and you are not a match. I'm sorry, I know this is hard. I can put you in touch with a counselor if you need one."

"No," Adora said, shaking her head even though she knew the man couldn't see her. "No, I don't need that. Do I need to contact… do I need to tell Ms. Weaver?"

"No, ma'am," Doctor Alsid replied. "We'll notify Ms. Weaver this morning. Did you have any questions?"

"What happens now?" Adora said.

"We'll try and get a match for her elsewhere," Doctor Alsid said. "We're not out of options. Now, if you have no other questions, I'll go. If you think of anything else, my staff can help."

"Certainly," Adora said. She felt like everything was coming to her from down a long, dark hallway. "Thank you for letting me know."

“Of course,” Doctor Alsid replied. “Good-bye.”

Adora carefully set the phone on her desk and stared at the wall. She startled a little as she felt Finn jump up in her lap and start purring. She began to gently pet them as she stared at the wall, knowing that it didn’t mean Sharon’s death but it still felt so final. The tears weren’t coming as she told herself it wasn’t the complete end, there were still things to try like the doctor had said. She also realized that she had no reason to keep in contact with Sharon but she still couldn’t shake the feeling that she should. It was stupid, she knew, because it was obvious that Sharon wouldn’t accept her or Catra or anything like it but still, Adora felt like maybe if she just gave it a chance.

“Am I being stupid, Finn?” Adora asked.

Finn looked up at the sound of their name and made a little chirping noise before settling back into Adora’s lap.

“That wasn’t very helpful,” Adora said as she scratched behind Finn’s ears.

Finn didn’t seem like they cared very much about being helpful beyond being a purring ball of fluff. Adora thought about going and telling Catra but she didn’t want to bother her as she was getting her day started. After petting Finn a little longer, she gently put the cat back on the floor and Finn trotted out to go see what was in their food bowl. Adora turned to her computer and started it up.

An hour passed as she managed to focus on some work and the background shop noise soothed her as it filtered in through the walls. She was busy outlining an idea she had for her next paper when she felt her phone vibrating. She picked it up and didn't recognize the number but answered it anyway.

"Hello, this is Adora," she replied.

"Doctor Alsid said he'd already talked with you and gave you the news," Sharon said.

Adora was about to snap and ask where in the hell Sharon had got her number when she realized she'd called Sharon on her phone to ask her to lunch.

"Yes, he did," Adora said.

"I suppose you're not going to speak to me again now that you don't have to do this," Sharon said.

"I never had to do this. I did it because it was the right thing to do," Adora said. "I'd also like to remind you that you were the one who cut me out."

Adora was ready for the cutting remark or denial. What she wasn't ready for was silence. After a few seconds, Adora spoke up.

"Why did you call?"

"I need a reason to call now?" Sharon said.

"Yes," Adora said, and then felt bad as she realized Sharon was probably scared.

"Well, I was calling to tell you about the results, if you hadn't heard but also…," Sharon said and then trailed off.

Adora had never heard her mother be anything but self-assured so it was weird to hear her trail off.

"Also?" Adora said.

"I would like it if you and your… partner came to Sunday lunch. Well, the place I have in mind is a brunch place but still, I would like to meet her," Sharon said.

"Are you serious?" Adora said and the little girl in her leaped at the chance while the rest of her tried to shove the feeling down.

“Of course,” Sharon said. “Would you like to meet at Scramble at 11:30? My treat.”

Adora recognized the place. It was a little hip place that had gone into an old building near downtown. She’d been with Glimmer a few times but she’d never been a big fan. She didn’t care though as she felt the little tug of hope that this was her mother trying to reach out. She kicked herself as she pursed her lips and said, “Fine. We’ll see you there at 11:30.”

“Very well. I’ll make reservations,” Sharon said.

“Alright,” Adora said and then surprised herself by going on. “I hope you’re going to be alright.”

“Thank you,” Sharon said. “It’s in God’s hands and I trust in His will.”

Adora heard the self-assured confidence in the statement but still said, “I hope you have someone you can confide in.”

“Of course, Adora,” Sharon said. “I speak with Pastor Tyler about these things. He’s a young minister but he’s a stalwart man of God.”

“I don’t think I remember him,” Adora said.

“Not a surprise,” Sharon said. “He’s younger than you but the Holy Spirit burns bright in him. He quit his day job to go into the ministry two years ago.”

Adora could feel the old reflexes of talking about church members coming back to her but she gave her head a shake as she remembered she didn’t want to discuss random people she’d never meet and, God willing, never would.

“Sounds like a heck of a guy,” Adora said. She swore she heard her mother’s lips purse a little at the heck. Adora remembered getting in trouble for saying heck when she was a child because, in Sharon’s words, “Substituting the word is almost the same as saying the word. At least have the strength of your convictions to say the word itself.”

Of course, Adora had gone ahead and said Hell the next time it’d come up and then got punished again, even more severely, but that was a whole other thing.

“He is,” Sharon said, in response to Adora’s comment.

There was a brief pause that Adora finally closed by saying, “Well, I hate to go but I must get back to work.”

“Of course,” Sharon said. “I look forward to Sunday.”

“As do I,” Adora lied.

Adora hung up the phone after saying good-bye and clenched her fists as she wondered why she’d ever agreed to go to brunch, lunch, or any other kind of -unch with her mother. She realized she better go and tell Catra right then and there. As she walked into the living room, she ran into Mista sitting cross-legged on the floor, eating a bowl of cereal and feeding Finn little scraps of bacon she’d fried. Adora noticed that Finn didn’t even look at her as she came into the room.

“Are you trying to entice my cat away from me?” Adora said.

“They’re sweet but I have a feeling they don’t have the makings of a ship’s cat,” Mista said as she scratched their ear before breaking another piece of bacon off and giving it to them.

“Why not?” Adora said.

Mista pointed at the three separate cushions for Finn she could see just from where she was sitting as she said, “Look at that. They’re spoiled rotten. They would not take well to only one cushion in a cramped ship.”

“Well,” Adora said, “I’m glad. Finn doesn’t need high adventure. Just pets and treats.”

“And that’s what they’ll get,” Mista said as she ran her hand down Finn’s back.

“With that in mind, I’m going to go and tell my wife that she and I have a brunch meeting on Sunday,” Adora said.

Mista heard the way she said it and raised an eyebrow.

“Yes, it’s her,” Adora said. “Yes, I’m an idiot so you can spare me.”

“I wasn’t going to say anything,” Mista replied. “If that’s what you want, then that’s what you do.”

“I can see you want to say something,” Adora said.

“Nothing I didn’t say the other day,” Mista said. “No reason to repeat myself.”

“OK,” Adora replied as she stepped to the door and took the hearing protection off the hook by the door. “Now let’s see how Catra responds.”

“I’m guessing loudly,” Mista said.

“You’re probably not wrong,” Adora replied.

“I’m going to be headed out in a few. Is it alright if I crash here another night?” Mista said.

“Yeah, we said you can stay here as long as you’re in town if you want,” Adora said.

“Sweet,” Mista replied. “I’ll grab something for dinner again.”

“Maybe not with the peppers this time?” Adora said, thinking of the fiery dish that Mista had served the night before.

“Ah, yeah, I forgot you have the weakest spice tolerance,” Mista said. “I didn’t even use that much.”

“It was good,” Adora said as she opened the door. “Just something a little easier.”

“Can do,” Mista said.

As Adora went into the shop she noticed Chuck wasn't around. Mia was working on an ornate iron railing and Catra was talking with a customer at a little standup desk by the front door. Adora made her way over as she overheard Catra say, "I know you paid a lot of money for it and you also signed a contract with a stated delivery time which, I might add, is still almost two weeks off."

The man standing in front of Catra was dressed in a polo shirt and nice slacks and had a look on his face like he'd just smelled something rancid. Adora quietly took a seat in one of two old seats by the front door and waited.

"Well, I need it sooner," he said. "Push it forward."

"No," Catra said.

"What do you mean 'no!?'" the man said.

"It's a complete sentence," Catra said. "However, since you didn't seem to get it, no, I won't push it forward. I have other jobs in front of you, jobs that paid just like you and who expect me to honor the contract date just like you should."

"Fine, I'll pay you more," the man said with a roll of his eyes.

“Still no,” Catra said and Adora hid her grin behind her hand. “I have a reputation and you can’t pay me enough to toss it out the door.”

“Then I want to cancel my order,” the man said. “Refund me the deposit immediately.”

“I’ll cancel it but I’m keeping your deposit,” Catra said. “That’s stated in the contract which, at this point, I’m pretty sure you haven’t read.”

Adora was beginning to get worried as the man stepped right up to the little desk and tried to tower over Catra. All Catra did was shift her look up so she was still looking in the man’s eyes.

“If you don’t, I will sue you!” he barked at Catra.

Catra reached into the pocket of her leather shop apron as she said, “I thought you might say that. Here’s my attorney’s card.” Adora saw Glimmer’s card in Catra’s hand as she held it out to the man. “I’ll let her know to expect your attorney’s call.”

The man stared down at the card and Adora wondered if he noticed the subtle sparkle in the heavy weave paper that Glimmer used for her business cards. He looked back up at Catra as he said, “Are you serious?”

“Hey, I want to make your order, collect payment, and move on. You want to go to court, not get your order, lose your deposit, and probably have to pay my attorney’s fees instead, well, that’s your business,” Catra said.

“Fine,” the man snipped after a pause. “Make it but I’m going to tell everyone how unprofessional you were.”

“You won’t be the first,” Catra said with a shrug.

“It better be on time,” he said as she slammed his way out the door.

Catra didn’t respond but she did laugh after he was gone as she came around the desk to give Adora a kiss.

“Sorry about that, babe,” Catra said. “Guy thought he was going to be Mister Important. This is the second time he’s tried this on me, although this was the first he threatened legal action.”

“Really?” Adora said. “What makes him think he’s so important?”

“He’s one of the bigger property developers in the city,” Catra said. “I’ve done five different custom jobs for him. Rico sent him to me; didn’t want to deal with him anymore.”

Adora knew Rico, he owned another custom metal shop in a nearby suburb, and said, "Why do you?"

"Because fuck him, that's why," Catra said. "He pays whatever I quote and Glimmer would eat him and his lawyers alive if he didn't. So what brings you out here?"

"Uh, I kind of have news that might make you mad," Adora said.

"Did you burn my favorite pan again?" Catra said with a little wink.

"That was an accident," Adora said, rolling her eyes at the reference to something she'd done in their first apartment.

"OK, so our cookware is safe," Catra said. "What's going on?"

"I… I, um, kind of told my mother we'd go to brunch with her on Sunday," Adora said.

Catra stared at her for a moment before she said, "OK. Why?"

"I don't know! I felt guilty I guess! It turns out I'm not a match and she called me and I felt bad and next thing I knew I was agreeing to go to lunch with her!" Adora said.

“Wait, that’s what the doctor called about?” Catra said. “Are you OK?”

Adora was about to ask why she was focused on that when Catra went on.

“It’s alright, Adora. I’ll go to brunch, I don’t care. I’m more worried about you not being a match. I know you did it because you felt like you needed to and I know how you get when you feel obligated about something,” Catra said.

“I didn’t do it because I felt obligated,” Adora said. Catra just raised an eyebrow at her. “Fine, I didn’t do it *just* because I felt obligated.”

“Glad you admit that at least,” Catra said. “Seriously, are you alright?”

“I don’t know,” Adora said after a pause. “I think so. The doctor said there were other options. It’ll be alright.”

Catra looked at her and then hugged her.

“You sure?” Catra whispered in her ear.

“I’m sure,” Adora replied. “Promise.”

As Catra let her go, she said, “OK, well, I’m looking forward to Sunday then.”

“Really?” Adora said.

“Phfft, kind of,” Catra said. “It could be amusing.”

“Seriously?” Adora said with a sigh.

“I’ll be on my best behavior,” Catra replied.

“That’s not very encouraging,” Adora said, seeing the little twinkle in Catra’s eye.

“I will,” Catra said. “I won’t be the one to screw this up.”

Adora sighed as she said, “No, she’ll probably do that on her own.”

Chapter End Notes

The author William Gibson once said that if you feel safer with a gun than you do with guaranteed health insurance, you don’t understand realistic adult fears. I was thinking of this when I wrote the voicemail part at the beginning of this chapter. As I get older, there is nothing that will chill your blood faster than a voicemail or email from your doctor after getting blood work done.

I'll also say that I'm getting close to being finished with writing this. I had a bunch of the end already written and I hit the point where I was able to link them to the main storyline. Now I just got to write the epilogue basically. Expect quicker posting very soon and thank you for reading!

Chapter Nine

Chapter Summary

It's time for brunch.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Sunday came and Adora was wide awake staring at the ceiling before the Sun had risen. By eight in the morning, she'd showered, had a light breakfast because her stomach couldn't handle anything heavier, did her hair five different ways, and gone through several wardrobe choices. Mista was sitting at their table nibbling on a piece of watermelon as she said, "For fucks sake, just put your hair up in a ponytail like you always do and put on something you'd wear to the office. You're making too much of this."

"I want to make a good impression," Adora said.

"She's the one who should be worrying about a good impression," Mista said with a yawn.

"I just…," Adora said and trailed off with a sigh.

"You want her to accept you," Mista replied.

“Yeah,” Adora said. “I know, it’s stupid.”

“It’s not,” Mista said. “Well, OK, yes, it is, but really, it’s not. I get you want to fit her into your life but don’t screw yourself over in the process.”

Adora didn’t reply and by the time Catra came out shortly after to grab something, Adora was sitting at the table with her hair up, wearing a button up and some slacks.

“Morning my fancy wife,” Catra said, giving Adora a kiss. “I’ll be ready in a few.”

“Is it too fancy?” Adora said as she started to stand up and Mista gave a little groan.

“Sit down,” Catra said with a little laugh as she headed back towards their bedroom with an apple to finish getting ready.

Shortly after, they were driving through the city in Catra’s pickup. Adora loved the old truck with its large bench seat. They’d both slept in it a few times when they traveled for one reason or another and even though they had been crammed into it with both laying on the seat, Adora had fond memories of it. Those were the thoughts she was thinking of as they pulled into the tiny parking lot of the restaurant a few minutes early. There was a line of people waiting to get in the door and a small group of people sitting around on sidewalk benches as they walked up.

“So, do we just shove our way in?” Catra said.

“I’d say just wait in line,” Adora said as she looked around. “I don’t see her here yet.”

“Might already be inside,” Catra said as she adjusted the collar on her flannel. Adora gave a soft smile at the sight because Catra had even taken the time to tuck the shirt in and Adora found her wife looking particularly attractive that morning.

“Maybe,” Adora said as they got in line.

“You ready for this?” Catra said.

“I could ask you the same thing,” Adora said.

“Meeting my wife’s mother for the first time is a big deal,” Catra said. “I’m not sure I am. What if she doesn’t approve?”

“Oh, whatever shall we do?” Adora said. Her tone was joking but Catra could see the look on her face.

“We’ll go home, that’s what we’ll do,” Catra said, taking Adora’s hand. “To our home, our lives we’ve made, and we’ll live.”

Adora hoped the tears that pricked her eyes for a moment would be the only time they showed up that day.

“Thanks,” she said softly.

Catra squeezed her hand and a few minutes later, they were being taken towards the back of the restaurant. The room was filled with people and so noisy that the music being played through the overhead speakers was only audible in the sense that it added to the noise level. The host took them through a glass door and the noise dropped appreciably as they walked out onto a small enclosed patio. The first thing Adora noticed was her mother sitting at a table. Then she immediately registered that she was chatting with a young man in a suit.

“Who the hell is that?” Catra whispered.

“I don’t know,” Adora said, although she had an idea.

As they got to the table there were a few pleasantries between Adora and her mother as everyone got seated and the host took their drink orders before moving along.

“Well, thank you for meeting me today,” Sharon said.

“Of course,” Adora said. “Mom, this is my wife, Catra Manzana. Catra, this is my mother, Sharon Weaver.”

“It’s so good to finally meet you,” Sharon said.

Adora could see that Catra’s bullshit detector was screaming in her head as she replied, “Of course, I’ve wanted to meet you for so long.”

“I should introduce my guest,” Sharon said as she made a brief gesture at the man sitting beside her. “This is Pastor Tyler Bertrand. I believe I mentioned him to you the other day.”

“You did,” Adora said, feeling the knot in her stomach get tighter. “It’s a pleasure to meet you, Pastor Bertrand.”

“The pleasure is all mine, Ms. Weaver,” Tyler replied.

“It’s Dr. Manzana, actually,” Adora corrected him.

“Oh, I apologize,” Tyler replied immediately as he turned to Sharon with a smile. “You didn’t tell me your daughter had a doctorate.”

“She’s recently earned it,” Sharon replied.

“What is it in?” Tyler replied.

“It’s in Religion, Ethics, & Philosophy,” Adora replied.

“Religion!” Tyler said with a big smile. “Now you’re in my field! I don’t know if Sharon told you but I answered the Call a couple years ago at 23.”

Catra managed to keep her face as neutral as possible when she saw Adora’s face when Tyler said it was his field. She’d seen it many times and knew that this guy was a few missteps from getting split in two, metaphorically, if he decided to try and debate Adora.

“She did mention that,” Adora replied. “May I ask what was it you did before?”

“Car salesman,” Tyler said. “A pretty good one as well but the church needed a full time pastor for the youth group and I answered and went from there. It was tough at first but well worth it.”

A server came over and set a large tray in the middle of the table. Half of it was full of fruit, crackers, hummus, and cheese while the other side had breakfast sausage links, bacon, and muffins and

biscuits while the center had several small jars of jams, jellies, and honey. The server turned to another server and grabbed their drinks and set it before them.

"Oh, I'm sorry, we haven't ordered yet," Adora said.

"I went ahead and ordered," Sharon replied. "After all, you paid for lunch the other day. I figured it was the least I could."

The server took their menus and for a moment, it was just background noise before Catra finally sat up a little in her chair and pulled one of the plates at the table to her as she said, "Well, I won't be shy. I'm calling dibs on those diced peaches there. Pastor, you better get into this before my wife here wipes it out. She's got an appetite."

Adora heard Catra put a little extra emphasis on the wife part and inwardly groaned before she immediately chastised herself. Catra was simply stating the truth. Although Catra was also picking at the other two, but Adora wasn't going to say anything about it. Besides, she was pretty sure Sharon had invited the pastor along for a reason.

"No problem there," Tyler said with a laugh. "As long as I get some of that bacon."

"Deal," Catra said as she took a biscuit and started putting honey on it.

“Adora, please, go ahead,” Sharon said.

Adora thought for a moment of stories she’d learned in a mythology class, stories of fairies and the traps they’d lay for mortals with food, and she couldn’t help but look at the tray in front of her and think of it as a trap. She still picked up some grapes, cheese, and a couple of sausages for her plate though. Only once Adora had done that did Sharon start to fill a plate for herself.

“So, Catra,” Sharon said as she artfully arranged her food. “I don’t believe I know what you do for a living.”

“Metalwork,” Catra said. “Got started as farrier when Adora and I moved in together and learned everything I could. Glad I did, it was lean years at first and that kept us supported. I run my own custom metal shop now.”

“Sounds interesting,” Tyler said politely.

“It is,” Catra said. “You’ve probably seen my work as well. You know First Christian Church over in downtown?” Tyler nodded, as did Sharon, and Catra went on. “When they were renovating, they bid out the railing and fences. I got both contracts.”

“Those are beautifully made,” Sharon said.

“Thanks,” Catra said. “I had some excellent apprentices to help, especially with it being a historic building and all the paperwork that entails, so I can’t take all the credit.”

“She made a lot of our kitchen ware as well,” Adora said.

“You weren’t kidding when you said you really tried to learn everything,” Tyler said with a grin.

“What can I say? Metal is my speciality but I know a little bit of this and that. Electricity I don’t like to mess with, although I can, but I know some plumbing, engines, carpentry and the like,” Catra replied.

“You know, Jesus was a carpenter,” Tyler said.

Adora was about to make a comment about how that was in dispute in certain academic circles due to some differing translations but Catra just nodded as she said, “So I’ve heard. Heard he was a hell of a kitchen manager too, what with feeding all those people with just a little bit of fish and bread. Probably topped it off with some fine wine from the local well.”

Looking at Tyler’s face, Adora didn’t know if she should laugh or put her face in her arms as Catra casually took a bite of her biscuit. Sharon’s face was blank as Tyler responded.

“Um, yes, I guess that’s one way to look at it,” Tyler said, hanging a fake smile on his face.

“Sharon, I’ve been rude,” Catra said. “I haven’t asked you anything about you. I know Adora has told me you do volunteer work. What else have you been up to over the last nine years?”

“Ministries,” Sharon replied as she narrowed her eyes as she looked at Catra. “I’m working on one for Tyler right now as a matter of fact. We’re just now getting it off the ground.”

“No sh.. oot,” Catra said, as Adora heard her catch herself. “What’s it for?”

“Ministering to the LGBT community,” Tyler replied.

Catra’s eyes narrowed a little but her smile grew a little as she leaned forward.

“Good, they need it,” Catra replied. Before either Sharon or Tyler could respond she went on. “After all, they’re more likely to commit suicide, be homeless, and be the victims of abuse than cishet kids. I’m glad you’re stepping up to help when, you know, their parents turn their backs on them as happens all too often.”

Catra's smile turned crooked with the last sentence as she stabbed Sharon with her eyes.

"It's not that kind of ministry," Sharon said, meeting Catra's eyes. "We'll work with the parents and the children so that the children can gain a measure of peace through the word of God as they learn His true path for their lives."

"You know, Adora did that, wrestled with a lot of hard concepts about things like true paths," Catra said. "It's one of the reasons she's got a doctorate now but why do I think we're not talking about the same thing?"

"No, I don't think we are," Sharon said as she sat up a little straighter.

"No, I don't think you are either," Adora said. "And I feel like we're dancing around this. You didn't come here to meet my wife, did you? What's going on?"

"I most certainly did come to meet her," Sharon said.

"Then what is he doing here?" Catra said, giving a little head nod at Tyler before she turned to look at him. "No offense, Padre."

Sharon was about to say something when Tyler spoke up.

“No offense taken. The reason I’m here is that, well, I was hoping to work with you two.”

Adora leaned back as she said, “How? Are you wanting me to consult on this new project of yours or something?”

Adora knew. She could see it in her mother’s eyes and so could Catra as she dropped her hands into her lap so neither Sharon or Tyler could see them closing into fists.

“I think I know how,” Catra said, the strain of keeping her voice level showing.

Tyler smiled as he said, “Now, it’s nothing bad! I promise! As part of this program, we’re going to be talking to the grown children of parents who worry about them. I thought, well, we could start with you two. Work things out, get you back on the path, and get you both happy again.”

“What in the hell do you mean, happy again?” Catra snapped.

“Back on the path God has for you,” Sharon said, ignoring Catra and looking at Adora. “Adora, I’ve seen how you are now. I remember the bright, vivacious child you were and you look so troubled every time I see you now.” Catra snorted but Sharon went on. “I’m not saying you need to never see each other but

you need help and I, and Pastor Tyler, are more than willing to give it to you."

Adora let out a disgusted sound and was about to reply but Catra was faster.

"Listen you two, I could be living in the damn gutter and as long as this woman was with me, I'd be happy. As the verse says, where she goes, I go and where she stays, I stay. She is my people," Catra said.

"And I'm sure you think you feel that way," Tyler said gently. "But if you just let us show you a different way…"

"Fuck you and your way," Catra said, her voice rising. "You're talking about splitting our marriage up!"

"I don't know why I thought you'd be happy that I'm happy," Adora finally managed to say as she shook her head.

"Adora! You and your friend are making a scene. You need to behave and get her in line as well," Sharon said in a tight voice.

"My friend!? *That is my wife!"* Adora said, loudly, and she heard the whole porch go quiet. "I know you want to forget so you won't have to remember who I am but that's your problem not mine! Catra, we're leaving!"

Catra was already halfway to her feet during Adora's comment and she grabbed another biscuit and a sausage link as she did. She gave Tyler a little salute with the sausage as Adora turned her back and started walking off.

"Manazna Metalworks if you ever need some work done," Catra said with a wicked grin on her face before turning and following Adora.

Sharon was right on their heels as they went through the restaurant, trying to get their attention. Adora plowed forward, people jumping out of her way as she headed for the front door, with Catra tight on her heels. They were on the sidewalk and heading towards the parking lot when Sharon finally shouted, "Adora Avery Weaver, you come back here right now!"

Adora snapped around and went right up to her mother and for a moment Catra was sure Adora was going to knock the woman down.

"How dare you!" Adora shouted as she stopped almost nose-to-nose with Sharon. "How dare you lure me here and spring that on me! I was an idiot! I thought you cared!"

"I do care," Sharon said in a more conversational tone. "Now, come back in and sit down so we can talk this out."

“There’s nothing to talk about!” Adora said, throwing her hands in the air. “You don’t want me in your life, you want some false memory of me in your life! I was never the person you think you remember!”

“That’s not true,” Sharon said and for a moment Adora felt bad at the sad look on her mother’s face but she didn’t let that stop her.

“It is, Mom,” Adora said. “I can’t do this. I can’t pretend again; I won’t pretend again. When you can accept me and my wife, you know how to contact me.”

Adora started walking away as Sharon said, “Are you seriously doing this?”

“I could say the same,” Adora shot over her shoulder.

Chapter End Notes

> That plate they had for brunch doesn’t exist at any restaurant I’m aware of besides my heart. It is based on a plate from a place I go to sometimes called Feed the Table. It’s two whole roasted chickens, one giant pretzel, six sausages of your choice (like bratwurst, jagerwurst, etc), and a huge heaping helping of french fries along with some mustard and comes out on a freaking board. I’ve had four grown adults go at it and still leave enough for leftovers. It’s fantastic but it definitely needs something from the vegetative side of the food groups. It also feels like you’re sitting down for some medieval feast, especially since the place serves beer and cider in liter glasses.

Thank you for reading!

Chapter Ten

Chapter Summary

Adora tries to move on with her life but life has a way of making its own plans.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The summer went past. Adora cried over the loss of her mother once again but her friends were there for her. The class she'd prepped for started and she taught it. She went to Camp Bright Moon on the Summer Solstice and danced in a field with her friends, helped roll a flaming hoop into the river, and swam and laughed and feasted at a campfire as the sky held twilight in her hands late into the evening. In all, Adora found comfort and went on, dealing with the hole in her soul the same as she had all the years prior.

It was mid-August when things changed. Adora was standing in her classroom, dressed in business casual, as she looked out at the twenty-nine students that made up the fall semester course.

"Hello, this is Intro to Philosophy and I'm Doctor Adora Manzana," she said, pointing to the whiteboard with her name, the class, and her professional contact information. "This information is in your syllabus that I've handed out and I highly recommend you read the whole thing, particularly the part on plagiarism since most of the grade for this class involves writing. It also has when every assignment and test is due as well as how everything is going to be weighted for your grade."

She went on, covering some general things she thought of as housekeeping for the class and that she could almost do on autopilot. She had each student introduce themselves and their intended major if they had one. She had some colleagues who thought she should do more than that but she remembered how much she hated professors that did some annoying get to know you game and so she never did it herself. Finally, she said, "Alright. Now, if you've noticed, we actually have a lesson today."

Adora tried not to grin when she heard a little bit of quiet grumbling from the class. She remembered her undergrad classes and how she loved the professors who let them go early on the first day. The problem was, she wanted to cover as much philosophical grounds as she could in the class and so that meant using every minute she could as she shifted into her lecture mode.

"To begin, you're going to be presented with many different ideas and viewpoints in this class. I don't agree with many of them and I'm not asking you to do so either. I'm not asking you to accept all of them, or any of them for that matter, but I am asking that you learn them and think about them," Adora said. "I prefer you engage with them deeply and thoughtfully but at the minimum, do enough to pass the tests."

She got a minor chuckle out of that before moving on.

"With that in mind, what is philosophy?" Adora said and then stopped. She just got people staring back at her as she smiled. "That's a question. Anyone got an answer?"

One student tentatively raised a hand and Adora gave a nod at them.

"It's like, the meaning of life and studying that?" the student said.

"Not bad," Adora replied. "If I'm going with the strictly dictionary definition then I'd say the study of reality, knowledge, or values based on logic and reason. It's a way of thinking about these things. But why study it? My personal answer is neatly summed up in a quote from Bertrand Russell. In his book A History of Western Philosophy he says, 'To teach how to live without certainty, and without being paralyzed by hesitation, is perhaps the chief thing that philosophy, in our age, can still do for those who study it.' That, right there, is what got me into philosophy before I had ever read that quote or even really knew what philosophy was about. I had uncertainty and I was searching for a way to deal with that and I hope I can help you do the same. It's one of my main goals for this class for you. The other is that you get your humanities credit."

That got another chuckle out of the class as Adora said, "Alright, let's talk about religion and philosophy."

With that she was off talking about ancient religions and the birth of western philosophy in Greece. She could usually tell the devout Christians in her class because they were the ones who were uncomfortable as they began to see connections between the old religions and Christianity. She'd had uncomfortable conversations with some students after class before and she knew more than one student had dropped the class because of that first day

lecture. She'd also had other students tell her how much they loved it and how it'd only deepened their faith with the additional perspective. Most of her classes were more middle ground, just students who did the work, passed the tests, and moved on and she had a feeling this class was probably going to be one of those, although they did interact better than most with her questions.

As the class came to an end, she said, "Alright, that wraps it up. Read chapters two and four from *Sophie's World* before the next class and start thinking about your mid-semester paper. See you then."

A few students came up to ask her some questions and she talked with them for a few minutes each before she finally went over to get her stuff. She put it all on a small cart and rolled it back to her office. There was a note stuck on her office door from the head of her department and she frowned. It wasn't a normal thing to see, since pretty much everyone communicated with email, and she took it down and read it.

It simply said: *Your mother called and asked that you call back. She stressed it was important.*

Adora frowned as she went into her office, wondering if Sharon really had the nerve to try and contact her now. Then Adora thought about how maybe she was reaching out to try and ask forgiveness and the little girl in her was hopping up and down, hoping that was true and that she'd finally be able to have her back in her life. Adora knew better though and shook her head as she crushed the note and threw it away.

It was two weeks later that she got a call as she was sitting in her office at school, working on her next paper. She picked up her cellphone and, not recognizing the number, shrugged before sending it to voicemail. She was working on a particularly difficult passage of Greek when she heard the phone buzz and looked down to see a voicemail. She grunted as she realized she wouldn't be able to concentrate on the translation with the little voicemail icon looking at her so she picked up the phone and dialed. After a brief moment, she heard an official voice.

"Ms. Manzana, this is Malia with Saint Peregrin's Hospital. We're trying to reach you on an urgent matter. Please give me a call back as soon as you can."

The woman left a number and Adora felt a chill run through her. The first thought she had was that Catra had been injured at the shop and rushed to Saint Peregrine, which was part of the hospital complex by their home. Adora quickly called Catra, her hands shaking as she waited for an answer. All she got though was Catra's voice saying, "This is Catra Manazana with Manazana Metalworks. I'm currently unable to answer the phone so please leave a message with your name, number, and your order number if you have it and I'll call you back as soon as I am able."

Adora called Mia, hoping maybe Catra's phone just wasn't nearby but when Mia didn't answer, Adora was on the verge of panic. Chuck wasn't in the shop for a few weeks and Adora was about to call Glimmer and ask her to go over when her phone rang. She saw Catra's picture and answered by saying, "Are you ok!?"

“Whoa! Calm down there!” Catra said and Adora could hear amusement in her voice. “Sorry, I missed your call, I was in the bathroom.”

Adora leaned back in her chair with a sigh as she said, “I got a call from Saint Peregrin and I was panicked that you had been hurt.”

“I’m sorry, honey,” Catra said. “I’m fine, promise. Besides, isn’t Saint Peregrin the cancer hospital?”

Adora sat right back up as she remembered that yes, it was, as she said, “You’re right. Call you right back.”

Adora hung up on Catra without waiting for an answer and dialed the number that Malia had left. After a few rings, it was answered.

“Saint Peregrin’s Hospital, this is Malia speaking,” Malia said.

“This is Adora Manzana returning your call,” Adora replied, a sick feeling in her stomach.

Malia’s voice went from neutral customer service to kind as she said, “Ms. Manzana, I’m calling because you’re listed as Sharon Weaver’s emergency contact. She is having issues and we need you to come in to make some decisions immediately.”

Adora almost dropped the phone as she felt a lump form in her throat and barely managed to say, “I’m sorry?”

“I know this is hard but we need you to come in and speak with us,” Malia said. “Are you able to come today?”

Adora swallowed hard as she replied, “Yes, ma’am, I am. I’ll be there soon.”

Malia gave her an address and suite number and then ended the call. Adora sat at her desk, tears pooling in her eyes, as she carefully dialed Catra back.

“Is everything alright?” Catra said when she answered.

“That call was because it seems I’m Mom’s emergency contact and the hospital needs me there now,” Adora said.

Catra was silent for a moment before she said, “I’m coming to get you.”

“No, meet me at the hospital,” Adora said.

“You sure you want to do this?” Catra said.

“No,” Adora said before giving Catra the location. “I’ll see you there.”

Adora walked into the hospital with Catra by her side. Catra had been waiting by the front door of the building and Adora got a little bit of amusement out of the fact that it was obvious Catra had gone right out the door after the call because she was still wearing her heavy leather shop apron. The amusement only lasted a moment before the dread took over again. Catra took her hand without a word as they walked into the building and found the relevant suite of offices. They were ushered right into Malia’s office, a middle aged woman with a look of gentle concern on her face as Catra and Adora sat down, refusing offers of water as they introduced themselves.

“I’m a hospice coordinator here at Saint Peregrine. I understand that you haven’t had contact with Sharon but she didn’t have any other contact information, so we’re reaching out to you,” Malia said.

“There really isn’t any other family,” Adora said, thinking about how her father had been an only child and his parents had died before he and Sharon had been married and how Sharon’s parents had died shortly after Adora had been born. “What’s going on?”

“Sharon’s cancer has gotten quite advanced and because of this, she’s opted to stop any further therapy,” Malia said. “She has

executed a power of attorney that does several things but the part we're concerned with is that it puts you in the position of making you a decision maker for future medical decisions, taking it out of her hands. She's not far enough along to go into full-time hospice yet but we need you to make some decisions."

Adora almost cursed right then and there as anger surged up in her, mixed with sadness and remorse.

"I assume she's here?" Adora said, straightening up as Catra held her hand tight.

"Yes," Malia said.

"I want to talk to her right now," Adora said.

"I understand but…," Malia started to say as Catra cut her off.

"Listen, I don't want to be rude but her mother cut her out of her life," Catra said. "We'll make the decisions that need to be made today but first, she needs to go and talk with her."

Malia looked at her computer screen before saying, "I understand. She's in room 1214."

The ride up the elevator was in silence, Adora gritting her teeth as she furiously wiped at her eyes. When they stepped out on the twelfth floor, Catra said, “What’s on your mind?”

“How mad I am that she’s forcing this on me,” Adora said.

“Thought you were a free will kind of person,” Catra said with a little shoulder bump.

“Then why do I feel like I’m on rails?” Adora said as she walked down the hall. When she got to the room, the door was cracked. Adora quietly told Catra to wait and went into the room alone.

When she got in, she was ready to blast Sharon for what was going on but she was pulled up short. The last time she’d seen Sharon, at the disastrous brunch, she’d looked fine. Two months later and she looked ravaged. What hair Adora could see under a little stocking cap was stringy and thin, her eyes were sunken into her face, and her cheeks were hollow. Her skin was sallow as she turned her head to look at Adora and a little smile broke across your face.

“You came,” Sharon said.

Adora moved to the bedside, each step taking every bit of effort Adora could muster, as she said, “I came. What’s going on, Mom?”

“I’m dying,” Sharon said matter-of-factly. “I need you to take care of the particulars.”

“Why me?” Adora said, doing her best to make it sound like a simple question and not the lament that it almost came out being.

“Because you’re my daughter,” Sharon said.

“That’s a terrible answer, Mom,” Adora said, thinking about how she’d spent a third of her life apart from her mother at this point.

“It’s your duty,” Sharon said. “Don’t worry, I don’t think it’ll be a long one.”

“You’re right, it won’t be because I have your power of attorney,” Adora said. “I’m ordering them to restart your therapy…”

Adora trailed off at the look in her mother’s eyes. She’d never seen fear like that even though it was gone a moment later as Sharon closed her eyes and said, “No. I don’t want that.”

“You need it,” Adora said.

Sharon's eyes opened again as she said, calmly and directly, "Adora, it's too late. At this point, it'll maybe extend my life just a little bit, at great pain I might add."

A little voice in Adora's head, a voice that Adora would remember for a long time in shame, said, "Good."

What Adora actually said was, "Is this what you think or what the doctor thinks?"

"Both," Sharon said. "They've been very honest and straightforward."

"God damnit, Mom, you drag yourself back into my life after *nine fucking years,* treat it like it was no big deal, try to break up my marriage, make me feel guilty, and now you're springing this whole new thing on me after ignoring me for two months because you think it's my *duty!?"*

The whole speech was in her head but instead of letting it out of her mouth, Adora turned her back on her mother and stared at the wall as a few hot, angry tears streaked down her face.

"You don't need to hide that you're sad I'm dying," Sharon said.

Adora didn't respond at first. She looked up at the ceiling before turning around.

“I’m not hiding that I’m sad you’re dying. I’m hiding that I’m mad,” Adora said.

“God does these things…,” Sharon started to say.

“I’m not mad at him, I’m mad at you,” Adora said. “I feel terrible because I’m mad at you.”

“Whatever for?” Sharon said and Adora felt herself actually chuckle, a tired and weary sound, at the sheer amount of confusion on her mother’s face.

Adora stood there and thought about demanding an apology for what Sharon had done. She wanted to sit down and get a reckoning for all the misery she’d suffered from Sharon over Adora’s life. Looking at Sharon lying in the bed, hooked to all the tubes and wires of modern medicine, she knew it was pointless. It’d mean less than nothing because either Sharon would never understand, she’d lie and say whatever was needed for Adora to do what she wanted, or she’d tell the truth but Adora could never be sure if it was the truth or not.

Adora remembered a therapist she’d gone to once telling her that the closure she sought was more than likely not going to be the closure she received. She’d never fully understood that until now.

“Everything but there’s no point,” Adora replied, not sure exactly what she meant by no point. “I’m going to find out what needs to be done.”

Adora waited for a response but Sharon had settled back into the bed and Adora realized she was slipping off into sleep. With a sigh, Adora turned and went out the door.

Chapter End Notes

I had a comparative religion class and a biology class that inspired parts of Adora’s speech to her class. The comparative religion part was the professor saying he expected people to keep an open mind when learning about other religions. The biology class was the professor saying she didn’t care what we thought about evolution. She didn’t expect us to accept it but she did expect us to learn enough to pass the test. I had good professors.

As to the story, I have so much I want to say about what's going on but I want to wait until the end to really say it. Some of it is about the story and the series and some of it as about my personal feelings wrapped up in this. For now, I'll just say, thank you for reading and there'll be more pretty quick.

Chapter Eleven

Chapter Summary

Adora makes a hard choice and is faced with facts about herself.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

Attention: If you're following along as I post, this is the second chapter I've posted today. Be sure and read chapter ten before this one!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The next two months were rough. After a little bit of time at the hospital, Sharon moved back into her home. Adora felt guilt settle on her like a shroud as she refused to go and attend to Sharon. She made sure Sharon had the appropriate care but she wouldn't go and visit her. She talked to Sharon over the phone but it was bland. Neither of them brought up the fact Adora wouldn't come and see her and the few times Adora tried to broach the subject of the past, Sharon had shut it down quickly. Morning, noon, and night, guilt stalked Adora for not going and doing more. One evening in late September, Catra found her at two in the morning, sitting in a chair and staring out the back door at the backyard shadows being cast by the reflected city light from low hanging clouds.

"You alright?" Catra said as she sat down on Adora's lap. Adora's arms immediately went around her as she let out a sigh.

"I can't sleep," Adora said.

“Obviously,” Catra said. “You’re sitting in a chair staring out the door. What’s wrong?”

“I feel like I should be helping Mom more,” Adora replied. “And I don’t want to.”

“You’re doing fine,” Catra said. “It’s not like she’s alone.”

“It’s just strangers though,” Adora said. “I’m her daughter.”

“Ah, this again,” Catra said. “Listen, that was bullshit what she said to you that day, about it being your duty. What about her duty to you?”

“She raised me,” Adora said.

“I guess,” Catra said.

The two sat quietly for a moment before Catra went on.

“You know, I have issues connecting with people sometimes because I didn’t have the kind of childhood they did and when they talk about family and stuff, I don’t really get it. I mean, I

guess I do, but in a theoretical way because I didn't have those things, just strangers raising me."

Adora hugged her as she said, "Well, I'm glad you connected with me."

"Adora, I connected with you because you have the same attitude that I do," Catra said. "You were raised by a stranger."

Adora opened her mouth to say something and then shut it as she realized that was a big reason she felt so weird about the situation. It was her mother, the stranger. She was taking care of someone who she realized she didn't even know, while still being connected to her.

"Hey, sorry, I didn't mean to make you cry," Catra whispered as she kissed the tears.

"No, it's just… I can't believe it took me this long to understand that," Adora said.

"I don't think it's entirely the same," Catra said. "Still, it's there."

"Any time I try and talk with her about anything like this, she just changes the subject or refuses to answer," Adora said.

Catra shifted a little and didn’t say anything until Adora gave her a little nudge.

“Fine, I’ll say it but… fuck, Adora, she’s not going to say it,” Catra said. “Whatever it is you want, no matter what you do for her, no matter what you say to her, I don’t think she’s ever going to be anything more than what she is now.”

“I know,” Adora said in a small voice.

“Then why?” Catra said.

“Other than to see it through to the end?” Adora said, wiping at a tear.

“Yeah,” Catra said.

Adora didn’t answer for a long time. Finally, right before Catra was going to speak up, Adora replied.

“Matthew five.”

“Going to have to be more specific,” Catra said.

Adora felt a little bit like she was lecturing, which relaxed her, as she said, "Matthew five is the Sermon on the Mount. Jesus lays out the Beatitudes and talks about some of what you could call the core tenants of his message. This is where the eye for an eye comes from and being a light to the world."

Catra sat and waited, she knew Adora well enough to know she was just getting to her point.

"In all of that, at the end in verse 43 and 44 , Jesus says, 'You have heard that it was said, Love your neighbor and hate your enemy. But I tell you, love your enemies and pray for those who persecute you.' I guess it's that. Love your enemies. I don't know if I'd call my mom my enemy but that's why. And before you say to give you the rest in context, it goes on to say, 'If you love those who love you, what reward will you get? Are not even the tax collectors doing that?' That's the point right there. I'm not sure if I'd call it a core philosophy but that right there is my thought I guess. People need help sometimes, even awful people, and it's easy to help the nice but the measure of a person is helping even the awful when you can," Adora said.

"You're too good for her," Catra said after a moment's pause.

"I know," Adora said. "I know my worth. I have to do this though. I know it doesn't make a lot of sense, it doesn't to me, but I have to do this."

"It doesn't but then again, it doesn't make sense for a lot of what we've done," Catra said.

"I was going to argue with you but you're right," Adora said before giving Catra a kiss. "Thanks."

"You're welcome," Catra said as she stood up from the chair and held her hand out. "Come on, dummy. Come cuddle with me and maybe you'll get some sleep."

Adora followed her to bed and then the next day, she kept going, doing her best. That's how she approached it, a day at a time, some good, some bad, and then one Tuesday in October she got a call. Sharon had suffered some kind of medical episode and she'd been moved to a hospice on the northwest side of the city.

When Adora got to the facility, she took notice of the beautiful building filled with soft lighting, blandly attractive art on the walls, and a silence that seemed to weigh everything down. After briefly talking with the staff, Adora stood outside the room they had Sharon in, trying to work up the courage to open the door.

It's the doors, Adora thought as she looked at it. *They're taller and wider than normal doors. Makes me feel like a kid again.*

She thought of waiting for Catra to arrive but she didn't know when she'd be able to get there and she didn't know how coherent her mother was going to be. Finally, she reached out and opened the door and walked into the dimly lit room.

Adora had expected some kind of smell, whether it was cleaning chemicals or something more organic she wasn't sure, but the air was just air, like everything in it had been scrubbed out to only the bare essentials. As she looked at her mother lying in the hospice bed, that was the thought that came to her, bare essentials. The bare essentials was all that was left of her mother as the cancer ran its course through her and soon it wouldn't even be that.

"You came," Sharon said, her voice tired.

Adora walked over and sat down in the chair next to the bed, looking down as she did.

"Yeah, I'm here," Adora said and surprised herself by carefully picking up Sharon's hand, being careful to avoid the IV lines. Adora felt the hand weakly grip her's and Adora thought she could feel each bone through the skin. "Turns out I can't just let you go."

"That's not a bad thing, sweetheart," Sharon said.

Adora gritted her teeth at the name but didn't correct her.

"I guess not," Adora said. "I was told… well, they said that I should ask if there's anything you want for… you know, afterwards."

“After I’m dead,” Sharon said and Adora finally looked up at her.

“Yeah, then,” Adora said, managing to talk around the lump in her throat.

“It’s alright,” Sharon said. “It’s not when I would have chosen it but I’m going Home.”

Adora grimaced as she said, “He does work in mysterious ways.”

“He does,” Sharon said. “I don’t think you believe that anymore but He truly does, Adora.”

Sharon’s eyes flickered a little and then closed. She was quiet for a little while and Adora watched Sharon slowly breathing as she held her hand. After about five minutes, they opened again and Sharon saw her sitting there and gave a crooked smile.

“You’re here,” she said.

“Yes,” Adora said. “Do you remember what we were talking about?”

Sharon stopped for a moment before saying, “Kind of.”

“I need to know what you want done after… after you’ve passed,” Adora said.

“I have a will,” Sharon said. “My attorney’s name is at home in my address book. The mortuary and burial are already taken care of; hospice has those details.”

Adora nodded and waited but Sharon didn’t go on.

“What about your service?” Adora said.

Sharon didn’t seem to know what she meant but then something seemed to click and she said, “You do it.”

Adora felt anger run through her to be slammed down just as fast by sorrow as she said, “Are… are you sure? Don’t you want your pastor to do that?”

“I know you’re ordained,” Sharon said. “You do it.”

Adora wanted to say that yes, she was ordained but she wasn’t up to this. She’d gotten ordained to help friends get married who wanted a minister but who, for one reason or another, didn’t have

one of their own. She'd first gone through the steps to be ordained to marry two women she'd known. It'd been half a political statement and half being helpful. It wasn't as if she'd ever intended to actually carry out the full duties of a minister.

"I don't know what to do," Adora said and she thought about how she sounded like a frightened child.

Sharon opened her eyes a little more as she said, "You? You've always known what to do. Always, from the day you were born. Your whole life has been driven by that."

Adora wasn't sure what to say as the words Sharon spoke seemed to alter everything she thought of herself. She remembered standing with Catra and knowing what she wanted as she pulled her close on the dock at Camp Bright Moon. She saw herself working through her degrees, constantly driven, constantly making decisions. She remembered the night when Madison had come to their home and knew what to do then, even while she was terrified. Moment after moment flicked past her as she saw the truth in that statement. She'd made mistakes but she'd always known what to do, in one way or another. With that realization, she began to speak.

"It'll be a service at the church," Adora said. "I'll make sure that everyone in your address book gets invited and I'll put out an obituary as well. I'll officiate and we'll celebrate your life and the works you've done for the church." Adora clenched her other hand as she said that but she went on. "I think we'll start with Rock of Ages for the opening hymn, I'll give a reading from First Thessalonians with a short homily, and then some eulogies, and

close out with I'll Fly Away for the hymn and a walk past the closed coffin."

Sharon was nodding slowly, her attention slowly fading in and out, and when Adora was finished she said, "That sounds nice. Why First Thessalonians though? I don't seem to remember anything from that."

Adora took a deep breath as she said, "Chapter four, verse 13 through 14, King James Version, 'But I would not have you to be ignorant, brethren, concerning them which are asleep, that ye sorrow not, even as others which have no hope. For if we believe that Jesus died and rose again, even so them also which sleep in Jesus will God bring with him.'"

Sharon gave a tired smile as she said, "That's nice."

Sharon faded out into sleep then and Adora took a shuddering breath. She couldn't help but watch her breathing, wondering if it was going to fail as she watched. A hospice nurse came into the room as Adora sat fighting her emotions and came up to the bedside.

"Are you Adora Manzana?" the worker asked quietly.

"Yes," Adora said, swallowing the lump in her throat.

“I’m the nurse on duty until 8pm,” he said. “My name is Carlos. Do you need anything?”

Adora blinked in surprise before shaking her head.

“No, I’m… I’m alright.”

“Don’t hesitate to ask,” Carlos replied. “Do you have any questions?”

Adora looked back at Sharon for a moment before turning back to Carlos.

“How long does she have?”

Carlos gave a sympathetic smile as he said, “Let’s step out into the hall for a moment, alright?”

Adora nodded and followed him out. Carlos pulled the door mostly closed before he said, “That’s not something we can really say with any kind of accuracy. That said, she’s still mostly coherent but all her lab work shows that everything is shutting down.”

“A few weeks then?” Adora said as she wiped at her eyes.

Carlos shook his head as he said, “She wouldn’t be here if that were true. More like a few days. Maybe a week.”

Adora felt the world tilt on her. It wasn’t as if she didn’t know that Sharon was dying, but to hear that it was more than likely going to happen before the coming weekend was something else entirely.

“Does she need anything?” Adora said. “Do you need anything?”

“No, everything was arranged already,” Carlos said. “If anything unexpected comes up, we have you and your wife on file as decision makers.”

“Wait, you have my wife down?” Adora said. “Is that just, like, a state law thing since we’re married?”

“No, Ms. Weaver changed it when she was being admitted,” Carlos replied.

Adora fell back against the wall as she covered her eyes. Tears fell through them as she found she couldn’t stand and slid to the floor. She was vaguely aware of Carlos kneeling in front of her and saying something comforting but she didn’t hear and she didn’t care as she wept. She let the weeping flow through her and when she was done a few minutes later, Carlos held out a small pack of

tissue to her. She nodded her thanks as she pulled the plastic open, took out a tissue, and blew her nose.

"I'm sorry," Carlos said. "I didn't mean to blindside you."

"It's alright. It just… it caught me off guard. I already knew about myself," Adora said. "I didn't know she'd put my wife on there. She… she didn't approve."

Carlos nodded as Adora got back to her feet as he said, "People see things differently as they approach the end."

Adora wasn't sure if that was true but she desperately wanted it to be so, the little child in her still desperately wanted mommy's approval, now more than ever, so she just wiped at her eyes.

"I need to go back in there," Adora replied.

"Be sure and take a break," Carlos said. "Let other friends and family members stay with her so you can take care of yourself. We'll be there to help as well."

Adora was about to say there really wasn't any family beyond herself when she suddenly realized, there hadn't been any friends show up either. Adora realized that of all the people Sharon had known, of all the people she'd done church work with over the years, none of them had shown up.

Adora pasted on a fake smile, itself unknowingly copied from Sharon, and said, “I’ll be sure and do that.”

Carlos nodded and went on his way as Adora went back into the room.

Chapter End Notes

OK, so Adora talks about loving your enemy and helping awful people. There’s a lot I want to say on this and, like Adora, I’m kind of tangled up in it. I’ll say this. I’ve seen a lot of charity drives in my time on various platforms. The ones who seem to get the most money are the ones who tug at the heartstrings. The ones who hit all the categories you want to see. The ones who “didn’t deserve” the tragedy they’re trying to deal with. The ones who are properly contrite and humble. I’m glad they get the help they need but I think that true charity is shown by helping those who you think don’t deserve it. Those who are in their situation because of bad choices, bad habits, and bad planning. They’re human beings worthy of help. It’s not a call to be a sucker or forgive someone who’s hurt you but it is a call to try and help where you can. Like I said, I’m kind of tangled up on this, I don’t have it fully thought out but it’s there.

Thank you for reading.

Chapter Twelve

Chapter Summary

Memento mori.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

Attention: If you're reading along as these are posted, this is the third chapter I've posted today. Be sure and read chapters ten and eleven before this one.

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The day that Sharon Weaver died was not remarkable. There were no portents that cracked the heavens, no sightings of any hovering ravens or quiet owls, and no feeling of Death stalking through the room and out into the hall. It was just a Friday in early fall.

Adora sat next to the bed, where she'd been off and on for the last few days. Catra had been forcing her to take breaks and Bow and Glimmer had shown up that first day to help. Scorpia had come down to keep watch for a few hours, Madison coming along with her to help out where they could. In the end though, Adora was there for as much as she could, sleeping beside the bed. She wasn't sure why but she felt like she should and so she did.

Sharon had been sleeping most of the time and the hospice people were quietly in and out, like attendants of Charon waiting to collect the toll. It was late in the evening, Catra asleep on the tiny love seat while Adora was reading a paper on some new theory on the Gnostics that she wasn't really involved with but

found a good distraction when she heard her name. Sharon had been saying names off and on for the last day or so but they didn't seem to have any connection to anything. She remembered waking up in the middle of the previous night to hear Sharon saying the name Clancy over and over as she looked around the room. That'd caused Adora's hair to stand on end because that was the name of her dead father and to hear it from Sharon's mouth like she was greeting someone standing at the end of the bed had been disquieting.

However, as Adora looked, she was a bit surprised to see Sharon looking at her with something that resembled awareness, admittedly cloaked in heavy painkillers. She sat the paper down on the nightstand and leaned forward to take Sharon's hand, shocked at how cold it felt, like death had already settled in it.

"I'm right here," Adora said.

Sharon muttered something but Adora couldn't understand her.

"I'm sorry, I didn't understand," Adora said.

Sharon muttered it again and Adora didn't understand at first but then the words managed to sort themselves out in her head.

"Proud of you, always have," she'd whispered.

Adora started crying again but it was quiet, just tears streaking down her face in the same course they'd gone over the last few days. Adora paid them no mind, they knew the way, they didn't need her attention at the moment.

"Thank you," Adora whispered back.

Sharon tried to whisper something else but she couldn't seem to say anything. Adora held her hand in both of her's and tried to think what to do. She remembered seeing people healed with the power of faith when she was a child. She remembered being told that prayer would overcome all. She was a long way from that now but she bowed her head because she'd also been told that prayer was a refuge and a comfort. Adora knew several languages and many prayers from several different religions and religious traditions for the dead and dying. Several flashed through her head but at that moment, she rejected all of them and prayed as she had as a child, fervently and from the heart.

"Lord, I come to you today with my mother, Sharon Weaver. It seems that it is your will that she is to be called Home soon and I ask that you take this cup of suffering from her and ease her journey. You have told us that you've gone before us to prepare a place in your Father's house for us. She's ready for that place, so please, bring her to you," Adora said and choked a little on a lump in her throat. "Bring her Home and take away her suffering. In your name we pray, Amen."

Adora would never be sure but she thought she felt the barest of pressure from Sharon's hand as if she was giving assent as well. Looking down at Sharon now, she still saw the woman who'd given her so much misery through her life but all the anger was

cool now and she saw her for what she was now, a dying woman in pain. She wasn't sure what she expected as she finished the prayer, if Sharon would shout, "It is finished!" in a loud voice or if a wind would whisper through the room but nothing happened, just the same barely perceptible rise and fall of Sharon's chest.

Adora didn't realize she was completely focused on Sharon's breathing until she felt Catra's hand on her shoulder. She looked up to see her wife looking down at her with a concerned look on her face. Adora just gave her a smile back, not realizing that her face was soaked in tears and the smile was quivering as she did. Catra squeezed her shoulder and continued to stand there behind her as the clock slowly turned.

Several hours later, as Catra slept on the couch, Adora was laying back in the chair next to Sharon, half asleep, when something roused her. She sat up to see Sharon's breathing falter for a moment before her chest managed to rise again. The noise that had roused Adora was the quiet rattling noise from the faltering breath and Adora picked up Sharon's hand again as she leaned over the bed's railing.

"It's alright," Adora whispered. "Go on Home, Mom, it's alright. You don't need to stay, I'll be OK."

All life ends, one way or another.

For Sharon Weaver it ended with a few quiet breaths, a brief pause, and then a slow, final exhale at 2:09 am on an unremarkable Friday morning as her hand was held by the only

person in the world who could claim to have any love for her at all.

Chapter End Notes

I don’t have much to say here. I’ve had the last few chapters mostly written for a while, as well as the next couple, and when I finally joined them up to the main story line, I changed them up some. Well, not this one. This one is almost exactly as I put it down, minus some minor style changes.

Thank you for reading.

Chapter Thirteen

Chapter Summary

Adora confronts the past and then works to put it to rest.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After Adora's mother passed, hospice arranged for the body to be taken to the mortuary. Adora walked out of the room with Catra by her side as they followed the gurney down the hallway. She watched it get loaded into the van and let out a little sigh as the doors shut.

"Let's go home," Adora said, her voice raspy.

She wasn't sure she'd be able to sleep when she got home but she went under as soon as her head hit the pillow and then woke up just a few hours later to Finn batting at her head.

"I'm up, I'm up," Adora said as she sat up, Finn giving her an indignant look as if they were upset at her for lounging around as late as nine in the morning without first checking in with them. "I don't wake you up early when you've been zooming around the house at 3am."

It was for that moment, in that veil of sleepiness just after waking up, that everything seemed normal. Adora would remember that

moment for the days to come because she wasn't sad. She was at home, in her bed, with her cat and she could hear her wife just down the hall. Everything was good. Then just as fast, everything wasn't as it all came falling back on her. Catra came in to find her crying and sat down on the bed to pull her close.

"It's alright," Catra said as she gently stroked her hair. "Do you need to sleep some more?"

"No," Adora said as she lay there with Finn curled up beside her purring. "There's things to do."

"I can do them," Catra said. "I can get Glimmer or Bow or Scorpia or hell, any of our friends, to do them. You've done enough."

"Not yet, I haven't," Adora said. "Just a little more though."

Catra leaned over and kissed the top of Adora's head before sitting up and saying, "OK, the extra mile I guess."

Adora nodded and finally rolled out of bed. She got ready and when she walked into the living room, Catra handed her a small stack of notecards.

"What's this?" Adora said as she looked at them. Catra didn't say anything as Adora started flipping through them. On each card were at least two names.

“Bow activated the tree last night and the calls started coming in early this morning,” Catra said and Adora suddenly realized that Catra looked like she hadn’t slept. “When they didn’t get you, they got me. They all wanted to express their condolences and they all offered help.”

There were names from old camp kids she’d known over the years, there were names from her colleagues, there were names from her close friends and friends she hadn’t heard from in years. Her vision blurred as she carefully stacked them together and nodded furiously.

“I should call them and thank them,” Adora said as she turned to get her phone.

“No,” Catra said as she gently got in the way of her wife and put a hand over her heart to stop her. “I told them thank you from both of us and that you appreciate it. You don’t worry about that. I’ve got the world for now; you take care of this one little bit of it that you need to.”

Adora wrapped Catra in her arms, the cards falling to the floor as she hugged her tight. They didn’t say anything at all because nothing needed to be said.

At noon that day, Adora stepped foot in her childhood home for the first time since she’d left for summer camp as an eighteen year old. Adora stood on the doorstep, looking across the

immaculate living room. She could see into part of the kitchen, where the table she'd had breakfast at for years sat. The fireplace had a glass front cover she didn't recognize but the built-in bookshelf next to it that they'd sat their Christmas tree in front of every year still held books, knick-knacks, and various photos of Adora starting as an infant and going up until she was eighteen.

"You alright?" Catra said.

"Been a long time since I've been here," Adora whispered, as if she was afraid of disturbing her mother. Catra just squeezed her hand as Adora walked across the room to the bookshelf. She looked at the photos, little captured moments of the past, and let out a sharp breath as she looked at the last one. It was her, the day she left for Camp Horde for the Lord for the last time, dressed in khaki shorts with her hair tied back and an official camp polo shirt on, standing on the front porch with a proud smile on her face. Adora took the frame off the shelf from where it was clearly visible across the whole room and stared at the photo, trying to make some connection to the surprisingly young face that looked back at her.

"I wonder what she thought when she realized I wasn't coming back," Adora said as she carefully sat the picture back down. Catra carefully looked at her, trying to gauge her emotions and utterly failing for once.

"I don't know," Catra finally said.

"Yeah, neither do I," Adora said, her voice suddenly harsh as she turned to kick the side of the couch. Then the yelling began. "I don't know! That's just how it fucking is from now on, isn't it!? God damn her, how could she not come to her fucking senses!? I was her only child! I was her only fucking *family!* No one showed up for her at the end! How could she not fucking understand that I fell in love!? How could she be so God damn fucking *cold!?"*

Catra was surprised to see fury written across Adora's face that was even more shocking because of the flowing tears.

"Adora, she just didn't…," Catra started to say as she stepped forward. Adora stepped away and pointed around the room as she cut her off.

"Of course she didn't! It was all about appearances! Look at this place! *Look at it!* See how beautiful it is?! How neat and tidy!? I got in trouble if I played in here! I either had to play in my room or I had to play on the enclosed patio! Because of fucking appearances! Couldn't have a toy out! Couldn't have any knick-knack out of place, had to keep that appearance, even with your own God damn fucking child!" Adora shouted, slamming her foot into the side of the couch again. "Couldn't have a fucking dyke for a daughter could you, Mom!? Fuck no, couldn't have that! What would the fucking church say!? What would her friends, those worthless *pieces of shit* , say about it!? Fuck me, what would they think about her daughter finding someone to love!? Fuck! FUCK!"

Catra was about to say something when Adora flipped the coffee table, sending a few small books and a basket full of wicker balls flying through the air, before picking up a lamp, yanking the power cord out of the socket in the process, and hurled it across

the room to smash into an oversaturated painting of a farmhouse. Everything fell to the floor in a tinkling shower of glass and ceramic shards as Adora stood panting for a moment, seemingly shocked at the outburst before her face went hard again as she stepped to the shelf, grabbed a brass heart that had "But as for me and this house, we will serve the Lord" engraved on it and threw it at another farmhouse picture. It thumped hard into the wall, breaking through the back of the picture and embedding in the wall for a moment before the picture fell and took the brass heart with it, leaving a small crater behind in the drywall.

Adora was reaching for one of the pictures of herself when Catra stepped up beside her and put a hand on her arm.

"Hey, hell of an arm there but coach says take it easy on the pitches."

Adora's hand dropped as she looked at the damage in the room and suddenly started laughing.

"She'd be so pissed…," she managed to say before sitting down on a couch, her laughter manically bubbling out of her. Catra righted the coffee table and sat down on it as Adora took notice of the things spread across the floor as her laughter pitched up a notch.

"Nothing out of place!" she said before leaning forward, her face in her hands.

Catra leaned forward, a hand on the side of Adora's face and the other up on the side of her head, as Adora's laughter turned to sobs.

"I don't know what to say to you that will help you," Catra said to Adora. "I don't know what to do besides what I'm doing but I'm going to keep being there for you. You want to trash this place, then let me get some hammers out of the truck and we'll trash this place. You do what you need, whatever helps you, I'm there."

Adora nodded as her crying slowly subsided and she looked up at Catra with bloodshot eyes and a tired smile.

"Amen."

"Amen," Catra said back before giving her a kiss on the forehead.

After a few minutes, Adora took a deep breath, stood, and headed down the hall. When she got to her mother's room, she slowed down as she walked into it. She'd expected some feeling of Sharon to be lurking there, call it a ghost or just a stray echo of her, but there wasn't anything. She hadn't been in the room since she'd gone into hospice so there was no smell left lingering of her body spray or makeup. It was as Adora remembered it except for the stripped bed and the laundered sheets sitting folded on top of it. Adora went to the dresser and picked up her mother's address book before going to the closet to flip through a few dresses.

“This one,” Adora said, pulling a black dress out to give it a quick once over.

“You sure?” Catra said. “You don’t want to look more?”

“No, this will be fine. It’s a formal dress,” Adora said. “She wore one like it to things like Christmas services.”

“OK,” Catra said. “Anything else we need?”

“No, let’s go,” Adora said as she folded the dress up and tucked it under her arm with the address book. As she walked out the door of the bedroom though, she took only a few steps before stopping in front of a closed door. She didn’t look at first but finally shook her head as she turned to open it. She expected her old bedroom to be empty or transformed into storage or a craft room or an office or anything but what faced her.

“You really liked pink,” Catra said, looking over Adora’s shoulder at the soft pink painted walls.

“She didn’t change anything,” Adora said, looking at her desk with some books stacked on it and her shelves with various items on them. She saw a few stuffed animals on the bed and remembered talking to them the morning she left for camp about how she’d see them in the fall. She wanted to go in the room but she found she couldn’t step inside. She shook her head as she whispered, “Nothing at all.”

“Maybe face this another time,” Catra said, putting her hand on Adora’s shoulder.

“Yeah,” Adora said and started to pull the door shut before she stopped and spoke into the room. “I’m sorry, but I’ll be back. It won’t take as long this time.”

As Adora locked the front door behind her, she wasn’t sure if she’d talked to the stuffed animals, the room, or the house itself and she held the dress in her lap all the way to the mortuary in silence.

Adora was true to her word. She put out the obituary, she contacted everyone in her mother’s address book, and she tried to get the church to hold the funeral. However, Pastor Tyler politely refused her without giving any explanation.

“I’m sorry, it’s just not possible,” he’d said.

Adora knew he was lying but she’d kept her cool as she said, “If it’s cost, that’s not a problem. Neither would set up or tear down. I can have all of that handled, I just need the space. Mom did put in a lot of work for the church and it would mean a lot to have her service there.”

Adora could hear the simpering smile over the phone as Tyler had politely refused her and suggested she try the mortuary for suggestions. She almost asked for a better explanation from him. She even thought about going up to the church and confronting him in person but in the end, she knew why he was doing it and it just wasn't worth it to confront him over it, so she let it go.

On the day of the funeral, the chapel at the mortuary had been standing room only and Adora couldn't help but notice way more than half the crowd had been her friends, family, and associates. There were some people who she didn't recognize, she assumed they were her mother's associates in one way or another, she couldn't bring herself to say friends, and when she started the service it took effort not to start by accusing them of being hypocrites and false friends.

Instead the service went as she had told Sharon. They had an opening prayer followed by Adora giving an opening address where she talked about some of the things Sharon had accomplished through ministries and the church. They sang Rock of Ages, followed by the Bible reading of First Thessalonians and a homily on it, and then they were to the part Adora had been dreading, the eulogy. No one had bothered to offer one and Adora knew it fell to her but she hadn't really known what she was going to say until that morning when Catra had simply said, "Tell the truth."

Then she knew precisely what to say.

Now, at the podium, Adora looked out at the faces looking back at her and began to speak.

"We gather here today to remember my mother, Sharon Weaver. I wasn't sure what to say here. When I talked about it this morning with my wife, she said one thing to me. Tell the truth. As a philosophy professor I, of course, immediately thought of something from Voltaire. He stated, 'We owe respect to the living; to the dead we owe only truth.' It's no secret that Mom and I hadn't seen or spoken to each other since I was eighteen until just recently. Even before that, my relationship with her was difficult for me. I'm not here though to try and talk that out. Even if I wanted to, it's too late to do so. The other side of the dialogue is in the coffin in front of me and unable to answer. So my eulogy of Sharon Weaver is that she was my mother, a woman who loved her God and worked hard for her church. She was a complex woman who held to her faith and in doing so, lost her daughter. My emotions are complicated but I loved her and I think she loved me but the great tragedy is that I'll never be able to say that without saying, 'I think' before it. I wish things had been different. Remember that. Let us pray."

After the prayer, they sang the final hymn, I'll Fly Away as promised, and then the procession went past the closed casket to soft generic organ music. Adora stood next to it with Catra as people gave their sympathy although she noted that some didn't even bother to speak to her or even look at her in some cases. She went back up to the podium one last time, closed with a short prayer, and then announced, "The graveside service is closed to all but close family. Thank you for coming."

It was a gentle autumn afternoon when Adora buried her mother in an old cemetery in the center of the city next to family members long gone. She'd never met any of them, and barely even heard of most of them, but she knew the plot that had been dug up was the spot where her father's ashes had been scattered.

Despite what she'd said at the mortuary, there wasn't a graveside service. She'd had many people offer to come but in the end Adora had asked that it just be Bow and Glimmer there with her and Catra. They all watched the coffin be lowered into the ground as Adora leaned her head onto Catra's shoulder as Glimmer stood beside her with an arm around her and Bow stood beside Catra, his arms around her shoulder and his hand resting on Adora's head.

When the coffin settled, Adora stepped forward to the edge and looked down. She had intended to say something at the graveside but looking down at the top of the coffin, all her words fled from her and she said the only thing that she felt could be said.

"Good-bye."

Then she turned and left with the people she called family now.

Chapter End Notes

The over-saturated painting of a farmhouse that got cut down by the lamp is a Thomas Kincaid. If you don't know this work, go read up on it. It seemed the thing Sharon would have in her house in abundance.

The stuffed animals kind of messes me up every time I read it. I get emotional over stuffed animals. They're these little pieces of fabric and fluff that we put so much love into and I know they're just inanimate objects but I still feel bad over scenes like the above. They've been waiting on Adora for nine years, not knowing what happened.

I thought I'd have this one ready a few days ago but I kept revising and revising and revising. Nothing drastic but I kept

shifting words around and making sure things sounded just so. At any rate, I finally called it done and it's here for you. Thank you for reading and there’s just one more chapter to go after this one.

Chapter Fourteen

Chapter Summary

It's all over except for the coping.

Chapter Notes

Shall we?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

About a month later, Adora was sitting on the back porch of Glimmer's parents home after a Thanksgiving lunch. She'd started a fire in the adobe oven on the back patio and was sitting close to it soaking in the heat coming from the entrance. The Sun wasn't doing much to add to the warmth, especially skipping in and out of the clouds, as Angella made her way out and sat down across from Adora, holding her hands out to the warmth coming from the oven.

"How're you doing?" Angella asked.

Adora shrugged. After a little over a month, she still didn't know how to answer the question. At least with Angella she didn't feel like she had to try beyond the shrug.

"I understand," Agnella replied. "Tired of people asking that yet?"

Adora gave a little smile as she said, "Yes, but I don't mind that you do."

“I know Glimmer said you’re fine but sometimes she doesn’t see these things I think,” Angella replied.

“She’s not wrong. Well, kind of. Some days are worse than others,” Adora said, thinking about cleaning her mother’s house out to get it ready to sell. She’d always been restricted from certain parts of the house and finally having unrestricted access had shown Sharon in a new light. It had been like Catra had said, Adora hadn’t known her mother, not really, and it had been like cleaning out a stranger’s home, albeit one that made her cry often.

Angella just nodded as Casta came out onto the porch with a big stretch, the bulky sleeves of her sweater sliding a little down her arms as she reached towards the sky. She went up beside the other two and held her hands out towards the fire. After a minute, and Adora trying not to look out the side of her eye at her, Casta spoke up.

“I’m not going to ask how you’re doing.”

“And by saying that, you do so anyway, but make yourself look different,” Angella replied.

“She’s on to me,” Casta said with a little smirk and a gentle elbow dig at Adora.

“Listen, you can ask me all you want if I’m alright,” Adora said. “Catra certainly does.”

Casta pulled a flask out of her sweater as she said, “Well, we worry you know.”

She took a swig and held the flask out to Adora, who had a flashback to a Thanksgiving at the same house, years before, where she’d decided she was twenty-one and was going to drink. As Catra would have said, it had been an interesting day, though not one Adora thought should be repeated at the moment.

“I think I’m going to skip that for the moment,” Adora replied.

“Probably for the best,” Casta said as she tucked the flask away. “Don’t need you howling at the sky again.”

Adora heard Angella chuckle to herself as Adora rolled her eyes.

“I wasn’t howling.”

“Sounded like howling,” Angella said with a smile.

“The local coyotes were sure confused,” Casta said.

Catra came out on the back porch at that moment. Adora's face lit up in a smile as she saw her wife carrying two big mugs of hot chocolate.

"I heard howling and coyotes," Catra said. "We talking about Adora communing with nature a few years back?"

Adora walked over and took a mug while giving Catra a kiss before she said, "OK, communing might be a better way of putting it."

"Well, getting you back to the trailer that night was a beast," Catra said. "I should have just taken Glimmer's advice and thrown a few blankets over you."

"Where is my daughter?" Angella asked.

"Her and Bow are both crashed out in her room," Catra said.

"It wasn't that heavy of a meal," Casta said.

"Not with you and Juliet eating vegetarian," Catra said. "Although she's asleep on the couch next to Micah who's also asleep in his easy chair in front of the wood stove."

“She’s a bit like a cat sometimes,” Casta said with a smile. “Loves her mid-afternoon naps.”

“I knew I liked her for a reason,” Catra said as she flipped up her hoodie with the little molded cat ears in the hood.

They all talked a little bit before Adora finished her drink and excused herself, saying she wanted to go take a nap herself. She went over to the little trailer they always stayed in when they were at Glimmer’s parents and went inside. She didn’t think the tiny travel trailer had moved since long before her and Catra had taken up residence in it after they’d left Camp Horde for the Lord. The whole place had little touches throughout the place that showed it was their second little home and Adora took a moment to look at the rainbows flaring across the wall from the little crystals she’d hung up in the windows. They weren’t the ones Catra had rescued for her years before, those hung in their home, but new ones she’d bought to hang as a reminder of when they’d had almost nothing but each other and what things could fit into a couple of duffle bags.

Adora grabbed a small backpack off the floor by the bed and threw it over her shoulder. She told the three stuffed penguins, giraffe, and white buffalo on her bed she was going to go out for a while but she would be back. She’d brought them to her home from her mother’s house the day after the funeral and they normally lived on her bed at home but she’d brought them with her for the trip.

Adora glanced out the window and saw that everyone had gone inside for the moment. She took that opportunity to quickly leave the trailer and head down the little trail that ran from the yard out into Camp Bright Moon. She was just a few paces down the trail when Catra stepped out from behind an elm tree, causing Adora to jump a little.

"Going somewhere?" Catra said with a grin.

"I was just going to take a hike," Adora said. "I just had to get my backpack."

"Without me? I'm hurt," Catra said as she went up beside her. "What about your nap?"

"It's not like that," Adora said with a roll of her eyes. "I just wanted a little quiet."

"I can stay behind if you want," Catra said, taking Adora's hand. "I don't mind. I just knew you were up to something with your lame excuse of wanting to go lay down yourself. You never take naps if I'm not around."

"I just… OK, you can come along," Adora said, threading her fingers through Catra's fingers. "

Catra gave her a kiss and they started walking. Everything in the camp was full of memories. She avoided the office, like she had for the last few days they'd been there, because it still reminded her of her mother yelling at her, giving her an ultimatum all those years before. She didn't avoid the arts and crafts pavilion though and she hummed the tune to Creep as she walked through, remembering Sea Hawk playing it one fantastic summer night for all the assembled camp counselors.

"Can't believe I missed that," Catra said, recognizing the tune and remembering the story Adora had told her about the night.

"I wish you'd been there," Adora said. "It really was magical, as silly as that might sound."

"Doesn't sound silly," Catra replied. "Anywhere you are is magical."

Adora rolled her eyes as her heart melted a little while she laughed as they kept going. She walked past the trail to the campfire ring, thinking about how in another month, they'd be visiting again to go through the winter solstice ritual with everyone. As they walked, Adora knew where they were going, even while she wouldn't voice it. She'd set out for a hike with a little purpose in mind and her feet were taking her to the docks. She looked across the river to the bluff where the former Camp Horde for the Lord sat. They hadn't managed to visit Scorpia and Perfuma yet but they'd planned on doing it the next day with Bow and Glimmer.

The wind came across the river, chill and with a damp smell on it, causing Catra to pull her hoodie a little closer in on herself, as Adora walked out on the dock and watched the swirl of the river go past. She thought about how she'd wanted to tell her mother about the good times she'd had on that dock and the great times she'd had with Catra all over and the hard times they'd both gone through and as she thought about it, Catra put her arms around her.

"Thinking about her again?" Catra asked softly.

"Yeah," Adora said.

"Want to talk about it?" Catra replied.

"No. Help me gas up that boat," Adora said, nodding at a boat Micah kept in the water for his own use.

"Adora, it's freezing out here," Catra said. "You want to go out on the water?"

"Just for a little bit," Adora said, glancing back over her shoulder at the position of the Sun. "We've got plenty of time before sundown."

"That wasn't what I was worried about," Catra said as she went and got one of the gas cans and brought it over. Adora took the

can from Catra and got it hooked up to the engine, set her backpack at her feet with a thump, and had Catra undo the mooring lines. Soon they were motoring across the river with Catra mumbling about the cold as Adora went upstream. After a little bit, they pulled into a little spot that Adora hadn't visited since the night she left Camp Horde of the Lord.

"Why does this look familiar?" Catra said as Adora nudged the boat up onto the muddy beach.

"Because this is where we snuck back in," Adora said. "Tie us off would you?"

"What are you up to?" Catra replied.

"Hey, I was going to do this myself but you just *had* to come along," Adora said with a grin as Catra tied them off to a tree. Adora killed the engine and took the fuel line with her just in case.

"Yeah, do what?" Catra said as they went up the bank and started walking.

"Something," Adora said.

"What something?" Catra said. "And why are we going in the back way instead of going to the docks?"

“Listen,” Adora said as she took Catra’s hand, “I want to keep this quiet. It’s just something I’ve wanted to do.”

“You’re not making me feel any better,” Catra said as she fell behind a little and Adora tugged on her hand with a smile to get her to catch up.

“It’s fine, really,” Adora said. “It’s just… I don’t know, it’s weird, I feel kind of stupid about it but I want to do it anyway.”

“Hey, I’ve seen you be plenty stupid,” Catra said. “Remember that night you and some of your work friends tried to adapt Scrabble to Greek even though you didn’t have the alphabet and you couldn’t agree on point values for the letters? I have never seen so many academics so pissed.”

Adora snorted as she said, “Because you’ve never been to any of the conferences.”

“Point being, you’re fine. Let’s do whatever it is we’re supposed to do. It’s not going to bother Scorpia is it?” Catra said.

“No. I should have called and told them I was coming, right?” Adora said.

“It’s fine. We’ll be sneaky, just like that night we left,” Catra said.

“Oh yes, the night I screamed at the top of my lungs at an assembled crowd,” Adora replied. “Very sneaky.”

Catra squeezed her hand a little as they kept walking. Soon they were coming up on the barn and Catra heard the sounds of a few horses inside. The barn itself had seen better years but Catra could see where Scorpia had worked on patching up the worst of the wear and tear so that it was at least suitable for stables again. She took a moment to stick her head inside the barn and the horses looked up at her with interest, wondering if she was there to bring an early dinner. She noticed that the inside of the barn, particularly the part with the horses, was immaculate and well taken care of. She saw the chore list beside the door and could smell the stocked hay and let a little smile play across her lips as she shut the door and followed along after Adora.

After a little bit, Adora started to slow down and look around. She looked confused and Catra gave her a nudge as she said, “Did you get us lost again?”

“No,” Adora said before looking around again. “At least, I don’t think I have.”

Everything looked a bit different. The trees had grown, brush had popped up here and there, the old paths hadn’t been kept maintained and were just whispers on the ground now, and Adora was beginning to doubt her memory.

“Maybe just tell me what you’re trying to do,” Catra said. “I can help you know. I’m good at that.”

Adora smiled at her as she said, “Yeah, you are. Thank you for that by the way.”

“What are you talking about?” Catra said with a confused look.

Adore smiled wider as she ran her hand through Catra’s hair but didn’t answer. She walked forward a little more, around a little curve in the path, and frowned as she came to a stop. Catra caught up to her as Adora said, “I’m looking for the cabin I stayed in that year.”

Catra looked around as she said, “It should be right around here. Isn’t that the bathhouse?”

Adora saw the cinder block building and nodded as she started walking forward.

“Yeah, it is. It should be right over there,” Adora said, pointing. “Surely it’s not covered by brush.”

Soon they were standing at a spot that Adora knew she remembered. She remembered shouting out at Joshua that there

was no fear in love from that spot but there was no cabin there like she remembered. She could see some old cinder blocks in the weeds but that was it.

"It's gone," Adora said and then shook her head in disbelief. "It's really gone."

"It looks like it," Catra said as she walked out to where the cabin would have sat. She looked around for a moment as she went on. "These must be the cinder blocks they used under the foundation. This is it."

"I wonder what happened?" Adora said.

Catra shrugged as she said, "Well the barn wasn't in great shape and Scorpia's been taking care of that. Remember when we visited them in the old cafeteria?" Adora nodded, remembering the place that Scorpia and Perfuma had decided to make their home on the property. "It wasn't in great shape either. We didn't really get to tour around that time, I bet the rest of the property is falling apart. Joshua was embezzling the money from this place after all. I doubt he did a lot of upkeep."

Adora shook her head as she sighed and kicked at the ground as she said, "I don't know why I thought it'd still be waiting."

Catra was about to respond when she looked up and shouted out, "Come on out, Lynda! I see you!"

Adora turned around to see Scorpia emerge from behind a tree with a smile. Perfuma peaked from around a tree herself as she waved.

"Told you I heard someone," Scorpia said with a laugh to Perfuma before she turned back to Catra. "I couldn't get you to call me Lynda when it mattered at camp but now you're not going to call me Scorpia?"

"Naw, you're always Scorpia," Catra said as she walked up and hugged her friend. Adora followed along as Perfuma came up and caught her in a hug.

"I know you might be tired of hearing it but you have our sympathies," Perfuma said.

Adora hugged the woman back as she said, "Yeah, but it's nice to hear from you."

"So what are you doing here?" Scorpia said, looking over Catra. "Is Bow and Glimmer with you? Wait, were you supposed to be here today? I thought it was tomorrow!"

"Take a breath," Catra replied. "It is tomorrow. Adora is being all mysterious and tried to slip over here by herself for some reason."

“Oh, really?” Perfuma said. “Why?”

Adora said, “Well, I came to see the old cabin for one.”

“Sorry about that,” Scorpia said. “I had to tear most of the old cabins down. Some of them were just unsafe to begin with and I’m using the material to build our greenhouses and fix up the barn. This was one of the first to go, the roof was collapsing on it.”

“You don’t have to apologize,” Adora said. “That’s not the only reason I’m here.”

“Well, what is that?” Catra said. “I know I’d really like to know myself, since you dragged me across a cold river to get here after all.”

Adora set her backpack down, feeling vaguely silly as she unzipped the top. Nestled in the backpack, inside a big plastic bag to keep it dry just in case, was a big leather photo album. Adora remembered finding it in her mother’s closet. She’d never seen it before and when she’d opened it, she found photos of people Adora had never known with a version of Sharon she’d never known either. Her mother hadn’t been a person who had smiled or laughed much but the photos in the album were full of Sharon smiling and laughing with the various people at cookouts, restaurants, concerts, and in various homes in t-shirts, shorts,

jeans, and anything other than the all-present conservative dresses that Adora had known her to wear.

Some of the last photos in the album had been of Adora's father, Clancy, with Sharon. She'd never seen her mother happier than she had been in those photos and Adora had broken down weeping when she'd turned to one of the last pages and seen Clancy sitting on a bank of a river in what the label of the picture had said was Colorado. He'd been reading a book of philosophy. Across from it had been a picture of herself as a baby sitting on his lap with Sharon standing behind him smiling radiantly. It had been dated only about a month before his death.

Catra knelt down next to Adora as she said, "Is that what I think it is?"

"Yeah," Adora said as she unwrapped the book. As she was about to talk, a little radio on Scorpia's belt crackled and a woman's voice called out.

"Scorpia, you there?"

"That's Mom," Scorpia said with a huge smile as she unclipped it from her belt and answered. "I'm here. Go ahead."

"There's a woman and a man here at the house. They said they're Glimmer and Bow and they're looking for Catra and Adora? Was dinner with them supposed to be today?"

Scorpia laughed as she said, “No, Mom. Catra and Adora are up to something, they’re here with us. Let them know we’ll head that way.”

“Can do.”

Adora couldn’t help but notice how much Scorpia’s mother had a voice like her. Adora wondered if she had a voice like her mother or like her father but she didn’t want to ask at the moment as she put the photo album back in her bag.

“Listen, let’s go back to your place. I’ll talk about it there,” Adora replied.

“I swear,” Catra said with a roll of her eyes but a laugh as well.

“A little mystery won’t kill you,” Adora said.

“See how she treats me?” Catra said as Adora put her backpack back on and took Catra’s hand.

“Yeah, real monster,” Scorpia said with a laugh as she took Perfuma’s hand and they started walking.

When they got back to what used to be the dining hall, Adora admired the cover Scorpia had put over the patio made from thin planks of red cedar that had been cut on the property and milled by a local. There were a few woven mats that were raised at the moment but could be dropped if the wind got a little too much and a big recently built adobe stove, like the one Glimmer's parents had, sent a thin trail of smoke up into the air as it warmed the patio.

Adora waved at Bow and Glimmer who were sitting and talking with two older women. One stood, with almost white blonde hair, and Adora knew it had to be Scorpia's mother. The other woman, tall with black hair, stood as well. Scorpia went up and hugged them both, greeting them each as Mom before saying, "Mom, this is Adora and Catra. Guys, this is my Mom, Nicole and her wife, Mary."

"Nice to meet you," Adora said, standing up straighter.

"Good to meet you too," Nicole replied.

Before they could go on, Glimmer was already talking.

"OK, what are you two up to? You just disappeared!"

"I didn't disappear," Adora said. "I came over here to do something."

“Which she won’t say what it is,” Catra said.

“Adora, are you alright?” Bow asked.

“Do we need to go?” Mary said, looking between everyone.

“No,” Adora said. “It’s alright. I don’t know why I’m being so mysterious. Here, let me show you.”

She walked over to a round table made out of a giant wire spool and sat down in one of the chairs next to it. An oilcloth patterned with sunflowers sat over the top of it and a little unlit lantern sat in the middle. Adora sat her backpack down at her feet and pulled out the photo album and sat it on the table.

“Oh,” Glimmer said as she walked over to look over Adora’s shoulder. Bow came over as well and Catra stood next to him as Adora looked down at the photo album. The others sat down in chairs around the table as Adora lay a hand on top of the photo album.

“Sorry for dumping this on you Mary and Nicole. I don’t know what Scorpia has told you but I spent a lot of time here when I was a teenager. I never knew my dad, he died not long after I was born, and it never really seemed to matter much to me because, well, I didn’t know him. It was just something about

me," Adora said and then flipped the book open to the back. There Clancy sat, looking down at his book. "This is him. His name was Clancy." Adora looked at the other picture and felt a lump catch in her throat. "This is my Mom. Her name was Sharon. That's me."

"You were a cute baby," Perfuma said, looking at the picture.

"Thanks," Adora said. "I've been… this sounds so stupid…"

She trailed off and Bow put a hand on her shoulder as Catra sat down next to her and caught her eye.

"Hey, stop that. It's alright. You're with friends," Catra said.

"No, I'm with family," Adora said with a smile as she wiped away a tear. She saw Mary and Nicole take each other's hands and went on. "OK, so I found this cleaning my Mom's house out. I'd never seen it and I don't know why. It's full of photos of Mom before she had me or was even married I think. At first, I couldn't really bear to look at it but over the last week or so, I've been talking to these two pictures. I've told Dad about my life and I've told Mom about what I thought about how I was raised. I've even told baby me about how her life is going to be."

Adora stopped and looked at the pictures again. No one spoke as they waited for her to go on. After she wiped another tear away, she spoke again.

“I came over here to show Dad where I spent my summers. Like I said, stupid.”

“It’s not stupid,” Glimmer said.

“I get it,” Perfuma replied. “You’re communing with his spirit in a way.”

Adora shook her head but she was smiling as she said, “I don’t think of it that way. I know he can’t hear me but at the same time, I hope he can. I hope she can as well.”

Catra looked at Adora as she said, “Maybe. You never know.”

“Mark 9,” Adora said with a little shake of her head and a laugh.

“OK, you know no one else here knows that one,” Glimmer said.

Mary spoke up almost at the same time and said, “I think she means the part about ‘Everything is possible for one who believes.’ Right?” Almost everyone turned to her in surprise. “What?”

Nicole picked up her hand and kissed it as she said, "Yeah, she and I met in a support group of people getting over religious trauma."

"I think we're going to get along," Adora said. "And yeah, that's exactly what I meant. I don't know though. It just feels good to say these things."

"Well, you came all this way," Bow said. "Tell them about your time here. Or should we give you some privacy?"

"No, please stay," Adora said before taking a deep breath. "Mom, Dad, this is Catra. She's my wife. I'd give everything up for her. I have given everything up for her. She's my world; I love her. I see how you two look together, I think you get the idea." Adora pointed at Glimmer and Bow as she continued to look at the photo album. "This is Bow and Glimmer. They're together and have been my friends ever since I left here for the last time. Glimmer has saved me so many times, Bow has as well. I love them too. This is my friend, Scorpia. She and I went to camp here together. She worked as a counselor and she and her partner, Perfuma, own the place now. I don't see them nearly enough but I love them as well and consider them family, just like I do Bow and Glimmer. That's Scorpia's mom and her partner. I just met them but I think I'm going to like them as well."

Everyone was quiet as Adora took a deep breath.

"I came here today to show you around and tell you about my summers here. It was… I don't know how to put it. I remember

coming home when I was a camper so tired and exhausted but absolutely alight with the Spirit. We'd play games, go swimming, and hiking and camping. We'd spend hours in the chapel in worship. I'll show that to you later. I remember sitting at a table in the building behind me when it was a dining hall with Catra, just laughing and talking about… stuff. I don't honestly remember what, it was just stuff. We were best friends. When I became a camp counselor, I thought it was the greatest thing. I got to spend all my time here in the summer and I got to do it with my best friend! I got to show kids to God and help them grow in their faith. It was a dream come true I thought."

Adora stopped again and took a shuddering breath.

"I've done so much work to understand and some day I think I understand and some days I don't even have faith that I can make coffee right. I can say that I know that what I taught here, I definitely don't believe anymore. Part of that is that I've met kids who I was a counselor for now that I'm grown. Some of them are really screwed up. I'm afraid I had something to do with that," Adora said as Catra started to lean forward to say something. "Catra has heard this before and she's about to tell me that it wasn't my fault. Except it was and I know it. Maybe it shouldn't sit as heavy as it does but I had some hand in that. I need to face up to that. Mom, I wished you had faced up to what you had done but you were determined to go to your grave without doing so, weren't you?"

Adora was almost growling at that point as she stopped and looked up.

“Sorry. Sorry, that wasn’t what I was here for,” she said to everyone.

“Don’t apologize on our account,” Nicole said. “I understand how you feel.”

“Speak your truth,” Perfuma said. “Anger isn’t something you should hold in.”

Scorpia nodded as she said, “Yeah, she and I both know that.”

“Go on,” Glimmer said. “You’re with family, like you said.”

Adora quickly nodded before she looked back down.

“OK, so you know what I was doing. I’ve said it already, recently in fact,” Adora said. “I was going to tell you about my summers here but I don’t know what else to say. I was a counselor. I loved it almost right up until the moment that I walked away from it. I’ve questioned myself over and over about that decision. Sometimes it seems so unfair that you make a decision and you can’t go back and make it again, make it better. Not that I want to not meet Catra, or anyone else here, but that I could have maybe kept my Mom. I can see that wasn’t possible though. Maybe I could have tried harder. Course, so could you have. Anyway, this is Camp Horde for the Lord or was at least. It said it changed lives. It certainly did mine, for the better, but not the way they expected.”

Adora sat for a moment in silence, looking at the photo, before she reached over and closed the book. Catra hugged her tight as Adora wiped at her eyes.

"Thanks," Adora said.

"You're welcome," Glimmer said.

"I didn't really tell them about camp," Adora said with a little laugh as she sat back.

"Sure you did," Bow said. "You said what mattered."

"Do you need some water?" Mary asked.

Adora let out a long sigh and she seemed to float upwards a little as she said, "No, I'm good. I feel… lighter."

"Because you knocked," Nicole said and Mary put her arm around her and squeezed.

"What do you mean?" Adora said.

“Something Mary and I talk about,” Nicole said. “That verse in Matthew, ask, and it shall be given you; seek, and ye shall find. We’ve done a lot of soul searching together, about who we were, and I kept falling back on that. It was like a promise. If I just go looking, if I try, the answer will come to me. I’ll make it out the other side.”

Adora reached forward to rest her hand on the photo album as she thought for a moment and said, “Make it out the other side. Yeah, I can get that.” She started to put the album away as she went on. “Thank you for letting me do this but I think it’s time we got out of your hair and let you enjoy your day.”

“It’s not a problem,” Scorpia said. “I’m glad you dropped by. I’d invite you to dinner but we haven’t even started cooking yet and I know you got your thing going on.”

“Do you all want to come with us?” Bow said. “Bring what you got, I know we got plenty of room back at the house.”

Scorpia’s mothers, Scorpia, and Perfuma started talking about how they couldn’t possibly intrude while Glimmer grinned at Bow just inviting four more people over but she knew her parents wouldn’t mind. After it went on for a minute, she spoke up.

“Listen, Mom and Dad aren’t going to care. It’s a big house and like Adora said, you’re in this family of ours, however it might be. Come on over, seriously, we’d love to have you,” Glimmer replied.

Mary laughed as she said, “OK, I’m going to be the one to say yes. Come on, let’s get our stuff packed up and we’ll drive over.”

People started getting up and Adora and Catra said they were going to go. Bow and Glimmer did as well when Catra said, “Wait, how did you get over here? We took the only boat.”

“No, you took the only motorboat,” Glimmer said. “The canoe hanging in the rafters wasn’t a problem to get down and in the water at all.”

“You *paddled* over here?” Catra said.

“I’ve paddled all over this river. Some of us don’t mind a little physical labor,” Glimmer said, flexing her arm. “Come on, let’s go get ready.”

Catra smirked as she flexed right back at Glimmer and the groups went their separate ways. That night, they had a huge meal, a little later than expected but still a fantastic time. Adora had the told the others what had happened when she got back and with her permission, Angella had taken the photo of Sharon, Clancy, and baby Adora out of the photo album and put it in a frame that sat with the rest of the family photos on a table and it watched them as they ate and laughed and played games with the old family and the newfound family.

Late that night, Catra and Adora went into the trailer and collapsed onto the bed, full of food, and pleasantly tired from everything that had happened that day. Adora felt her heart warm as Catra slid up under her arm and rested her head on Adora's shoulder.

"I love you," Catra said, her voice full of sleep.

Adora kissed her hand as she said, "I love you too."

With that, cuddled up with Catra under a warm blanket in their home away from home, Adora felt content and happy. She knew her life for what it was and it was good.

End of Story Note

OK, a little wish fulfillment in this story. I want that patio that Scorpia and Perfuma have. I almost made it roofed with eastern red cedar boughs but the problem with that is then you can't really have fire next to it because dried eastern red cedar boughs burn faster than just about any plant I've seen. Seriously, I saw a live one get hit by a wildfire once and it went up into a fifty foot towering flame in seconds. Dried isn't any safer. Anyway! I love that little patio.

Now for the big part. We're at the end of the story and that means we're at the end of the series. I've got things to say. First, this whole thing started out as a lark when I wrote Camp Horde for the Lord. I didn't think it would be long, it was. I didn't think it'd really hit home like it has for so many. I didn't think I'd write

an entire series in this AU. I've said before that I love my other series. My post-season five series have really been fun and I've got some great compliments and comments on it. This one though, this one I could tell really touched a nerve for people. I've gotten such raw and emotional comments on this that have really touched me. To everyone, thank you for letting me know how much this meant to you. I've said since I started writing fic that I write for myself but I post for everyone and I've never felt more vindicated in that sentence than I did with this series.

Let's talk about Shadow Weaver and Catradora now. In the fandom, it's kind of a thing to see people basically say that Catra and Adora are going to dance around because Shadow Weaver is dead. This shows a lack of understanding of both the dynamic and the actual onscreen reaction. When Shadow Weaver dies, both Catra and Adora cry. Adora actually drops to her knees in shock. The writing shows that ND Stevenson and the other writers had a good understanding of these kinds of dynamics.

I know people who've had terrible parents, who've had to break contact with them, and they're all torn up about it. It's not that they want to go back to what was, it's that they want to have what never was and they mourn that loss. That's what I was trying to show here. Adora deserved a good mother who loved her and supported her. Instead, as she said at the funeral, she's going to be forever wondering. I do kick myself a little because Catra is going to be having similar feelings and while you can kind of see them, a bit, in the end this was Adora's story so I focused on her. Maybe Catra's story will get a little attention in my In Between series, where I do stories from closed down series that come to me, but I don't know.

As to Adora and her taking care of her mother, even after everything that happened, this was directly influenced by someone in my life who took care of their mother when she was dying. They had a poor relationship with their mother but they still did it. The scene with Adora destroying things in her mother's house was something that they did (not precisely, they threw a bowling ball straight through a wall, several times). I'll say that it

was a really odd emotion to see because the person in question that influenced this had been very calm and collected in taking care of their mother up to that point.

Now this whole series has been personal, but this one was particularly so. I wrote the end pretty early on in the fic, before it ever got posted, and maybe just a couple of weeks after, a friend's mother announced she had cancer and then passed within just a couple of weeks. I almost scrapped this whole thing because of it. Why didn't I?

In December 2020, my wife and I came down with COVID. I've talked about this before but I'm going to be a little more personal now. My wife ended up in the hospital because it attacked her lungs and her blood oxygen kept dropping and she wasn't staying lucid. I dropped her off at the front entrance to the hospital and watched her walk in. It's probably one of the hardest things I've ever endured in my life. We didn't say it at the time to each other but we knew that might be the last time we ever saw each other. I went home where I barely remember the next few days because COVID really tore into me as well. I went to sleep several times sure I wasn't going to wake up. I recovered. My wife did as well, after several months on oxygen therapy, and while it's definitely affected us physically, we're doing well.

What it did to me though, was to really drive home the concept of death. I used to be more relaxed about it. I could talk about funeral preparations and wills and such pretty easily. Not now. It has really messed me up. I'm saying this to say that part of the reason I wrote this fic, even after the whole thing I talked about with my friend up above, is because of the old joke about fic being therapy. I needed to get this out. I needed to deal with this in some manner. It really has helped some. I think I'm always going to have this problem but at least it's gotten better.

Every time I end a series, I feel emotional and this is no different. I could probably get some more stories out, I have one about Adora getting drunk at Thanksgiving that I mentioned in this chapter, and I might write them later. However, I want to draw a

line in the sand and say, “This is done,” because everything needs a proper ending. I think this ends it just right.

As to all you reading this, I’m going to go on and say thank you, to each and every one of you. I say that I write for myself but I post for you and this series seems to really play out. I’d say I hope it meant as much to you as it did to me but I’ve seen your comments. I’m pretty sure we’re both on the same level. Thank you again for reading. I appreciate you more than I can say.

Chapter End Notes

> Notes are in the story. They're too long for this but I did have a little something extra to put here.
>
> I also wanted to say, the stuffed animals are my and my wife’s stuffed animals. I got them together for a photoshoot today so they could be seen with their fic debut.



The penguin on the left on the bottom is Perky, she's a burrowing penguin (she likes to burrow under blankets). The one on top of her is Sophie. She's an African Penguin we got from a zoo when we saw her counterpart in the water. The white buffalo is Al. He likes giving wet nose kisses. The giraffe is Nanner and she's very sweet but a bit timid. The next penguin is Perky Junior. She's Perky's sister and she's a burrowing penguin as well. Blahaj there isn't mentioned in the story, he's just along for the ride. :)

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